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Is The NYSC Reform Another Uniform Makeover?

ELVIS EROMOSELE

In a country where “national service” has too often translated into national sacrifice, the Federal Government has rolled out what it calls the most comprehensive overhaul of the National Youth Service Corps (NYSC) in its 53-year history. Approved by the Federal Executive Council (FEC), the reforms promise a shift to civilian operational leadership, technology-driven call-ups, extended orientation camps, specialised career streams, and a spiffy new uniform to replace the threadbare, sweat-inducing khaki that has defined generations of reluctant graduates.

One can almost hear the applause in Abuja. Meanwhile, parents across the federation exhale a cautious sigh, wondering if this time, the scheme might stop sending their children into harm's way dressed as moving targets. Born with noble intentions after the Civil War to foster unity in a fractured nation, the 1973 relic has frequently functioned as a one-year lottery with appalling odds. The official rhetoric behind these new reforms aims to change that, transforming the NYSC into a “skills-driven, productivity-focused engine” capable of feeding a projected \$1 trillion economy.

Under the new playbook, the traditional three-week camp stretches to six weeks, structured into neat, corporate-friendly fortnights. The first two weeks for civic responsibility and national values (the traditional patriotism booster shot); week 3-4, career mapping, business planning, and basic accounting (to teach corps members how to budget their allowances against skyrocketing inflation) and 5-6, specialised training across 11 career tracks, including tech, agriculture, and health.

Primary assignments will better align with academic backgrounds, reducing the spectacle of engineering graduates teaching primary school



pupils with no materials. The traditional, sweat-soaked Passing Out Parade will also yield to a “formal graduation ceremony.”

Sarcasm aside, these elements deserve genuine applause. Civilian leadership might inject fresh administrative energy, unburdened by military hierarchy, provided it doesn't devolve into another layer of political patronage.

More importantly, however, the corporate buzzwords dance gracefully around the elephant in the room, one that isn't wearing a newly redesigned uniform, but rather carrying an AK-47 on an unpaved highway. For over a decade, the greatest hazard of national service hasn't been the lack of running water, but a terrifying game of geographical roulette. Corps members, fresh out of university and brimming with youthful idealism, are posted to unfamiliar territories where they must dodge banditry, secessionist violence, and kidnapping syndicates. The mandatory journey to service has become a multi-day gauntlet through highway badlands where a corps member's uniform behaves less like a shield of state protection and more like a neon sign for ransom negotiators. Recent tragedies, including the killing of corps member Abdulsamad Jamui in

Abuja, are painful reminders that “service” sometimes ends in an obituary.

To its credit, the new framework mentions a “risk-sensitive deployment” system. Details, however, remain scarce. While operational leadership pivots to civilians, the military is expected to handle security. This creates a spectacular paradox: we are demilitarising the administration at the exact moment the operational environment requires tactical counter-insurgency expertise. A civilian Director-General using a digital call-up process cannot algorithmically dissolve a bandit checkpoint.

Without a radical overhaul, “risk-sensitive deployment” will simply become bureaucratic shorthand for sending the children of the elite to Lagos and Abuja. Meanwhile, the politically invisible will continue to test

If these reforms deliver safer and more productive services, they will mark a historic turning point

their faith in the hinterlands.

True reform demands more than policy pronouncements and prettier khaki. If the NYSC is to transform from an existential gamble into a genuine national asset, the government must implement actionable security and structural updates.

First things first, establish a digital shield. Every corps member deployed to a medium- or high-risk zone should be integrated into a tech-enabled early-warning network. The NYSC mobile app should feature mandatory, zero-data check-ins and instantaneous SOS routing directly to localised military and police rapid-response units.

Second, create commercialised local placement. If the private sector wants to attract elite talent from the tech or medical streams, it must pay a mandatory security premium into an expanded NYSC Welfare and Protection Fund. These corporate sponsor-

ships should guarantee secure, gated accommodation at Primary Places of Assignment (PPAs).

Third, set up the regional cluster model. National integration loses its charm when it requires crossing geopolitical zones via unsecured roads. The scheme should adopt a decentralised model where corps members are deployed outside their home states, but strictly within neighbouring states or secure corridors where safe transit infrastructure actually exists.

Besides, the Corps must institute accountability and alternative paths. Here, I'm thinking hybrid or virtual models for high-risk zones. Furthermore, when corps members die in service, thorough independent investigations, not perfunctory probes, must follow, with swift compensation and institutional accountability.

Yes, it is time for the government to modernise the NYSC! But modernisation without confronting the hard truth risks purely cosmetic change. A glossy certificate in digital marketing or automated agriculture is entirely useless if the recipient does not survive the year to collect it.

If these reforms deliver safer and more productive services, they will mark a historic turning point. The corps members and their anxious families deserve a promise that outlasts the press release.

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Federal Competition & Consumer Protection Commission

MERGERS & ACQUISITIONS: OBLIGATION OF FIRMS, LAWYERS AND OTHER STAKEHOLDERS UNDER THE FCCPA (2018)

Pursuant to the provisions of the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Act (FCCPA), 2018, the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission (FCCPC) is mandated to review, authorise (with or without conditions), or prohibit mergers and other business combinations upon notification.

A transaction is notifiable where it meets the thresholds prescribed by Notice 1 of the FCCPA, 2018 Notice of Threshold for Merger Notification Pursuant to Section 93 (4). Accordingly, parties to a merger or acquisition that falls within the prescribed thresholds are required to notify the FCCPC and obtain prior approval before implementing such transactions. This obligation applies to various forms of business combinations, including acquisitions of shares, assets, joint ventures, and other arrangements that fall within the scope of mergers as defined under the FCCPA and its relevant regulations.

The notification requirement enables the FCCPC to assess whether a proposed transaction is likely to substantially prevent or lessen competition in the Nigerian market, or otherwise give rise to public interest concerns. It also supports the FCCPC's mandate to monitor market developments and maintain a comprehensive understanding of market structures and competitive dynamics across sectors of the Nigerian economy.

Businesses and their advisers are encouraged to engage with the FCCPC at an early stage in respect of transactions that may be notifiable. Early engagement, including pre-notification consultations where necessary, facilitates regulatory certainty, promotes efficient review processes, and ensures compliance with applicable legal requirement.

The FCCPC emphasises that failure to notify a notifiable transaction constitutes a contravention of the FCCPA and shall attract stiff penalties and other enforcement actions. Parties are therefore advised to take all necessary steps to ensure compliance prior to the implementation of such transactions.

For further information or clarification, stakeholders are encouraged to contact the FCCPC or visit the website at www.fccpc.gov.ng.

The FCCPC remains committed to promoting fair competition, protecting consumers, and fostering a transparent and efficient business environment in Nigeria

Eme Eyo David-Ojugo

Head, Mergers and Acquisitions Department

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Two Years Of Impact: Transforming Consumer Protection Under Tunji Bello



Joyous leaders of workers union at Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission (FCCPC) after the presentation of a brand new coastal bus by FCCPC EVC/CEO, Mr Tunji Bello (middle in blue kaftan), to ease the transportation of junior workers as part of activities to mark Workers Day at the Commission's headquarters in Asokoro, Abuja.



FCCPC operatives, in separate operations, seal the offices of two real estate firms in Abuja for failing to comply with regulatory directives and provide redress to aggrieved consumers, and a textile warehouse in Kano for alleged deceptive trade practices involving the sale of under-measured fabrics, respectively.

Redefining Competition and Consumer Protection: The FCCPC Under Tunji Bello

Over the past two years, since Tunji Bello assumed office as Executive Vice Chairman and Chief Executive Officer of the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Commission (FCCPC), the Commission has experienced one of the most active periods in its history. What was once seen largely as a complaint-driven agency has developed into a more proactive regulator with an expanding role in promoting fair competition and protecting consumers across Nigeria's economy.

When Bello assumed office in July 2024, he acknowledged the economic pressures facing Nigerians. While recognising that inflation reflected genuine market realities, he also observed that some price increases appeared "teleguided" and warranted closer regulatory scrutiny. That outlook has shaped the Commission's approach, placing greater emphasis on market surveillance, consumer protection, competition enforcement and collaboration with other public institutions.

Operating under the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Act (FCCPA) 2018, the Commission has strengthened its statutory authority through a series of significant court victories. The Competition and Consumer Protection Tribunal upheld the FCCPC's US\$220 million administrative penalty against Meta Platforms and WhatsApp over discriminatory and exploitative practices affecting Nigerian consumers, while directing corrective measures on data protection and consumer rights.

The Federal High Court also affirmed the Commission's authority to investigate consumer complaints involving banks, healthcare providers and airlines, dismissing challenges brought by United Bank for Africa, Air Peace and other regulated entities. Together, these decisions have reinforced the FCCPC's position as Nigeria's principal competition and consumer protection authority.

The Commission has also expanded consumer redress. Between March and August 2025 alone, it resolved more than 9,000 complaints across 30 sectors and secured recoveries exceeding ₦10 billion for consumers. Banking, fintech, telecommunications, electricity, e-commerce and consumer goods generated the highest number of complaints, demonstrating the breadth of the Commission's engagement with everyday consumer issues.

Alongside complaint resolution, the FCCPC has shifted its attention towards structural market practices.



Tunji Bello

Investigations into supply chains uncovered exploitative conduct, including hoarding, artificial scarcity, deceptive marketing and misleading pricing.

The cement distribution chain became a notable example. BUA Cement disclosed that cement supplied to dealers at about ₦3,500 per bag was eventually sold to consumers for between ₦7,000 and ₦8,000 by distributors, illustrating how downstream practices can significantly inflate prices. Rather than move immediately to enforcement, the Commission first convened town hall meetings with market leaders in Abuja, Lagos, Uyo and Kano, emphasising that while businesses are entitled to make profits, collusion and other anti-competitive practices are prohibited under the law.

Retail pricing has received similar attention. The FCCPC directed supermarkets to display accurate shelf prices to eliminate discrepancies between displayed prices and checkout charges, and launched a nationwide study into those differences. The Commission has consistently maintained that it does not regulate or approve prices except in the limited circumstances provided by law. Its role is to prevent practices such as collusion, abuse of dominance, deceptive pricing and market allocation that distort competition.

The Commission has also expanded

its interventions across key sectors. In the electricity industry, it worked with regulators to ensure that consumers were not required to bear the cost of replacing faulty prepaid meters, supported reforms promoting compulsory metering and smart-meter deployment, and temporarily sealed Ikeja Electric's headquarters over regulatory breaches before securing compliance commitments.

In telecommunications, the FCCPC reaffirmed its concurrent jurisdiction with the Nigerian Communications Commission on competition matters. It also maintained that any tariff increases should be accompanied by improved service quality and greater pricing transparency.

Digital lending has undergone substantial reform through the introduction of the Digital, Electronic, Online and Non-Traditional Consumer Lending Regulations (DEON). The Regulations require lenders to register with the Commission, provide transparent loan disclosures, lend responsibly, protect consumer privacy and refrain from abusive debt recovery practices. They also provide for sanctions, including financial penalties and, where appropriate, the disqualification of company directors.

Enforcement activities have extended to counterfeit and substandard products. The FCCPC sealed

businesses involved in rebagging locally produced rice as foreign brands, uncovered textile traders selling undersized materials, intercepted unregistered sugar imports, shut down a bottled water factory following the discovery of microbial contamination, and sealed a visa processing centre after consumer complaints and the alleged obstruction of regulatory officials.

To strengthen oversight, the Commission established a Joint Market Monitoring Taskforce with market unions and has begun developing a national product traceability portal that will use QR codes to help consumers verify product authenticity.

Competition regulation has remained central to the Commission's work. During the 2025 festive season, it reviewed domestic airline pricing, investigated unusually high fares and refund practices, strengthened oversight of mergers and acquisitions, and examined allegations of exploitative conduct without seeking to impose price controls. The Commission also pursued investigations involving MultiChoice while successfully defending its statutory powers before the courts.

Recognising that effective regulation depends on strong institutional cooperation, the FCCPC expanded partnerships with agencies including NAFDAC, SON, NCC, NERC, the Nigerian Midstream and Downstream Petroleum Regulatory Authority, the EFCC, LASCOPA and the ECOWAS Regional Competition Authority. It also renewed its Memorandum of Understanding with NAFDAC to improve information sharing, joint investigations and coordinated enforcement.

The Commission's work has attracted national recognition. In 2025, LEADERSHIP named the FCCPC Government Agency of the Year, while New Telegraph recognised it as Regulatory Agency of the Year in acknowledgement of its institutional transformation, consumer-focused interventions and regulatory performance.

Two years into Tunji Bello's tenure, the FCCPC has developed a more confident and proactive regulatory culture. Its approach combines engagement with enforcement, consumer education with market surveillance, and institutional cooperation with a firm commitment to the law. As Nigeria advances the Renewed Hope Agenda, the Commission's work is helping to build consumer confidence, encourage fair competition, improve market transparency and create a more predictable environment for businesses and investors alike.

News

From right: President Bola Ahmed Tinubu (right); Abike Dabiri-Erewa, Chairman, Nigerians in Diaspora Commission (NIDCOM) (second right); Iziag Adekunle Salako, Minister of State for Health, Minister of State for Health and Social Welfare (second left), and Chike Nweke, Managing Director, Calgoz Ltd, during the presentation of an award of recognition and commitment to a better future for Nigerians all over the world, held at the Presidential Villa, Abuja, on Friday. PHOTO: STATE HOUSE



Lagos Indigenes Forum Endorses Hamzat

★Pledges Grassroots Mobilisation Ahead Of 2027 General Elections

SEYI TAIWO-OGUNTUASE

The Lagos State Prominent Indigenes Forum has declared its support for the governorship ambition of Dr. Kadri Obafemi Hamzat and his running mate, Damilola Sonayon James, calling on Lagos indigenes to unite, take an active interest in politics, and mobilise at the grassroots ahead of the 2027 general elections.

Speaking at the 2026 Summit of the Prominent Indigenes of Lagos State Forum, held at Eko Club, Surulere, the Convener of the Forum, Chief Adesunbo Onitiri, said the summit marks a transition from a declaration of support to a sustained movement for action general elections.

According to him, the gathering brought together sons and daughters of Lagos from the five IBILE divisions—Ikorodu, Badagry, Ikeja, Lagos Island and Epe to reaffirm their unity and prepare for the political task ahead, emphasizing that electoral success is built through grassroots organisation rather than rallies.

Onitiri urged members of the Forum to mobilise residents in their communities, places of worship, markets, workplaces and polling units across the state, calling on youths, women, elders and community leaders to champion peaceful democratic participation, promote the message of progress and encourage greater political inclusion of indigenous Lagosians in governance and public service.

While describing the emergence of an indigene of Lagos State as President of Nigeria as a historic milestone, Onitiri said the 2027 elections would be about continuity, experienced leadership and the collective vision for a stronger Nigeria, urging Lagos indigenes to embrace politics as a vehicle for shaping society rather than viewing it as a dirty enterprise.

Reaffirming that Lagos would remain a welcoming home for all Nigerians, he maintained that the Forum's activities would be guided by discipline, civility, persuasion, service and unity.

In his address, Babajide Olusola Sanwo-Olu, Lagos State Governor, urged leaders and citizens to view continuity not as a political slogan but as a governance impera-

tive, calling on successive administrations to build on sound policies and complete projects that advance the long-term development of Lagos State.

He encouraged prominent Lagos indigenes to remain an enduring voice for responsible governance by documenting, advocating and holding every administration, present and future, accountable for building on sound policies and completing worthwhile initiatives in the best interest of the state.

The Governor, who described Lagos as a city built through the sacrifices and vision of successive generations, said every generation of Lagosians has a responsibility to determine the kind of state it would hand over to the next.

According to the Governor, "No

Flooding: Akwa Ibom Introduces Stricter Sanctions Against Indiscriminate Waste Disposal, Other Offenses

IDONGESIT ASHAMERI
UYO

The Akwa Ibom State Government has announced stricter enforcement measures against indiscriminate waste disposal and other environmental sanitation offences, warning residents that activities capable of blocking drains, gutters and waterways will attract prosecution.

The government's latest directive comes amid growing concerns over flooding in parts of the state, as the state has continued to blame the worsening impact of heavy rainfall on accumulation of refuse and the obstruction of water channels.

In a public notice issued on Friday by the Commissioner for Information, Mr Aniekan Umanah, the state government reminded residents that maintaining a clean, safe and healthy environment was a shared civic responsibility.

The notice, issued pursuant to the Environmental Protection and Waste Management Agency Law, Cap. 51, Vol. 3, Laws of Akwa Ibom State, 2022, and the Public Health Law, Cap. 119, Vol. 5, Laws of Akwa Ibom State, 2022, warned that breaches of environmental regulations constituted offences punishable under the law.

Specifically, the government listed the dumping of refuse outside approved containers or designated disposal points as an offence, alongside throwing

materials capable of blocking drains, gutters and waterways.

It also outlawed any act that obstructs the free flow of water on streets or highways, maintaining that indiscriminate waste disposal aggravates flooding and creates serious risks to lives and property.

Landlords, caretakers and occupiers of premises were equally directed to provide standard refuse bins and ensure that their surroundings were kept clean, while the discharge of human or animal waste in unauthorised places was prohibited.

The government further declared the accumulation of refuse, decaying food, animal or vegetable matter, as well as the discharge of wastewater or other noxious substances onto roads, gutters and drains, environmental sanitation offences.

It also warned residents against littering public places and allowing weeds or unkempt surroundings to persist within their premises, stressing that any act or omission capable of endangering public health, life or property would attract enforcement action.

According to the notice, offenders may face sanctions including fines, community service, abatement of nuisance and other penalties prescribed by law, while persons arrested for environmental sanitation offences would be prosecuted before a court of competent jurisdiction.

RAJI ADEBAYO
IBADAN

The Oyo south senatorial candidate of the Allied Peoples' Movement (APM) and member representing Ibadan North-west/Ibadan South-west federal constituency of Oyo state in the House of Representatives, Hon. Adedeji Dhikrullahi Stanley Olajide Odidiomo, on Friday, strengthened his personal engagement with the muslim community by donating 5 million naira towards the installation of

Oyo South APM Senatorial Candidate, Olajide Support Gbagi Muslim Community With N5m Solar Lights

a solar power system at the Gbagi central mosque, Lebanon street, Ogunda, Ibadan.

The donation was announced shortly after the lawmaker observed the weekly Friday Jumat prayer with muslim faithful at the mosque, where he reiterated his commitment to supporting initiatives that promote religious activities in the state.

According to a statement

made available to journalists by Tolu Mustapha, Special Adviser, Media and Public Affairs to the federal lawmaker, the intervention is aimed at providing a reliable alternative power supply to enhance activities within the mosque and improve the comfort of worshippers.

Addressing the congregation, Olajide said his philosophy of leadership has always been about

serving humanity through practical interventions that improve the welfare of communities, irrespective of religious or ethnic considerations. He described places of worship as vital institutions for promoting moral values, unity and discipline, stressing that supporting faith based organizations remains an investment in the social and moral development of society.

NUJ Seeks Regulation Of Cooking Gas Retail Outlets

...Wants Legislation Compelling Property Owners To Clear, Desilt Drainage Channels

IDONGESIT ASHAMERI
UYO

The Nigeria Union of Journalists (NUJ), Akwa Ibom State Council, has called for urgent regulation of the proliferation and operations of cooking gas retail outlets across the state, warning that their indiscriminate establishment could pose serious fire and safety risks to residents.

The Union made the call in a communiqué issued at the end of its Congress held at the NUJ Press Centre, Information Drive, Uyo, and made available to correspondents in Uyo on Friday.

In the communiqué signed by

the State Chairman, Comrade Nsibiet John and Chairman of the Communiqué Drafting Committee, Comrade Effanga Usen, Congress urged the State Petroleum Monitoring Team to urgently regulate the proliferation and operations of cooking gas retail outlets across the state.

Congress warned that the indiscriminate establishment and operation of gas plants posed serious fire and safety risks if left unchecked. It therefore urged relevant authorities to ensure strict compliance with safety and operational standards.

It made case for the establishment of a stand-alone Fire Service Agency, adequately

equipped with modern firefighting facilities and personnel, to improve emergency response and safeguard lives and property.

The Union also recommended the enactment of legislation compelling residents, landlords, property owners and business operators to regularly clear and desilt drainage channels around their premises as part of measures to address flooding and environmental degradation in the state.

Congress expressed concern over the indiscriminate disposal of waste by some citizens and residents, noting that the practice had continued to obstruct drainage channels and worsen

environmental challenges, particularly during heavy rainfall.

While appreciating the Akwa Ibom State Government for its timely intervention over recent flooding concerns, the Union urged the government to intensify efforts to combat environmental degradation and strengthen measures aimed at preventing avoidable flooding.

The Union further called on the State Government, through the Ministry of Women Affairs and Social Welfare, to develop sustainable measures to address the increasing presence of mentally challenged persons across the state in the interest of public safety and welfare.

Open Defecation: Jakande Fellows Move Against Menace With Awareness Walk

VICTORIA OJUGBANA
LAGOS

As part of efforts to check open defecation in Lagos State, the Lateef Jakande Leadership Academy (LJLA) will on Saturday, July 25, stage a 10-kilometre awareness walk to promote improved sanitation, behavioural change and cleaner public spaces across the state.

The project's Team Lead, Bayode Oke-Thomas, who disclosed this during a press conference on a sanitation project to tackle open defecation, titled: "Pee-Poo To Power Lagos," on Friday, said that the walk is scheduled to take place from Allen Junction to LAMATA Motor Park, Ojota.

He added that the initiative is aimed at checking indiscriminate urination by converting human waste into clean energy through biodigester technology.

According to Oke-Thomas, the initiative was developed after months of research, stakeholder engagement and community consultations, which identified poor sanitation practices as one of the major public health and environmental challenges confronting the state.

He explained that the project combines modern sanitation infra-

structure with a circular economy model capable of converting human waste into biogas while driving behavioural change through sustained public enlightenment campaigns.

Oke-Thomas noted that the team has proposed a pilot sanitation hub at a busy transport terminal where upgraded public toilets will not only provide cleaner and safer facilities but also generate renewable energy from human waste.

Co-Lead of the awareness walk, Shalom Ernest, said the exercise is designed to sensitise residents to the dangers of open defecation and indiscriminate urination while encouraging greater personal responsibility for environmental hygiene.

He noted that the 10-kilometre distance symbolises the long journeys many residents undertake to access decent public toilets, underscoring the urgent need for increased investment in sanitation infrastructure across Lagos.

According to Ernest, the participants would assemble at Allen Junction before proceeding to Ojota, where activities would conclude with the screening of a documentary showcasing the project's conception, sustainability model and future expansion plans.

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Police Arrest Suspected Cultist In Delta, Recover Four Guns

ANDREW UTULU
LAGOS

Police in Delta State said they have recorded breakthrough in the fight against cultism and unlawful possession of firearms with the arrest of a suspect and recovery of four locally made guns.

Bright Edafe, Police Public Relations Officer (PPRO), Delta State Command, who confirmed the incident said operatives acted on a complaint received from a male victim (name withheld), who reported that he was shot by one Oghenebuba Mamatime, on July 21, 2026 at about 5pm.

Edafe, a Superintendent of Police (SP), said that operatives of Jesse Division in a combined effort with some community youths in Jesse, arrested Mamatime, 28-year-old, alleged to be a notorious cultist and member of Eiye Confraternity.

The PPRO added that the suspect had been on the command's wanted list for allegedly shooting a victim on July 2, 2026 along Ujomi Road, Jesse

Town.

He disclosed that following the arrest, 3 locally made pistols and 1 locally made single-barreled gun were recovered from the suspect.

"Preliminary investigation revealed that the suspect, who is a member of Eiye confraternity, was unhappy with the victim over his decision to quit cultism, and in a bid to force him back into the confraternity, an argument ensued which led to the shooting. The suspect is in custody, and investigation is ongoing."

The Commissioner of Police, Delta State Command, CP Yemi Oyeniyi, has commended the synergy between operatives of Jesse division and the community youths in the fight against cultism and other vices.

He urged them to maintain the synergy, which he said should not be limited to cultism but extended to drug abuse, kidnapping and other serious crimes in their locality.

The CP also advised members of the public, particularly the youths, to shun all forms of cult-related activities.

Cruz's Anti-Nigeria Comments Risk Fueling Religious Tensions, Says Senator Sumaila

SOLA SHITTU
ABUJA

Senator representing Kano South Senatorial District, Suleiman Abdu-rrahman Kawu Sumaila, has accused United States Senator Ted Cruz of promoting a misleading narrative about Nigeria's security situation, warning that such comments could inflame religious tensions and undermine ongoing peace efforts in the country.

In a statement issued on Thursday, Sumaila said Cruz's repeated calls for Nigeria to be viewed primarily through the prism of religious persecution misrepresent the country's complex security challenges and threaten national cohesion.

The lawmaker argued that Nigeria's insecurity

affects citizens across religious and ethnic divides, stressing that reducing the crisis to a Christian-Muslim conflict distorts realities on the ground and could encourage policies that do not address the root causes of violence.

According to him, despite the decision of the administration of former United States President Donald Trump to remove Nigeria from the list of Countries of Particular Concern (CPC), Senator Cruz has continued to campaign for a different international perception of Nigeria.

"Senator Cruz's continued campaign to re-label Nigeria appears to be driven not by an objective assessment of the facts, but by a narrative that oversimplifies Nigeria's security challenges and portrays them primarily through a reli-

gious lens," Sumaila said.

He warned that portraying Nigeria's security crisis solely as religious persecution ignores the fact that terrorists, bandits, kidnappers and insurgents have targeted both Christians and Muslims, as well as churches, mosques, schools, markets and rural communities.

The senator maintained that such narratives could deepen existing divisions, undermine reconciliation efforts and encourage external actions that fail to reflect Nigeria's realities.

He, therefore, urged Christians in Nigeria and across the world to critically examine claims about the country's security situation and reject narratives capable of promoting religious polarisation.

According to him, genuine friends of Nigeria

should support peace, interfaith cooperation, national unity and sustainable development rather than rhetoric capable of heightening tensions.

Sumaila also paid tribute to members of the Nigerian security forces, noting that personnel from different religious backgrounds continue to work together in the fight against terrorism, banditry and other forms of violent crime.

He said overlooking their sacrifices in favour of divisive political narratives would be unfair to Nigerians who have borne the brunt of insecurity.

Reaffirming Nigeria's sovereignty, the lawmaker rejected what he described as attempts by foreign political actors to exploit the country's internal security challenges for ideological or political purposes.

We Enacted Pension Reform Act 2004, Stop Shadow Chasing, Atiku Tells Tinubu

JOY ANIGBOGU
LAGOS

The presidential flag bearer of the African Democratic Congress (ADC) and former Vice President of Nigeria, Atiku Abubakar, has waved off the recent insinuation and innuendo by President Bola Ahmed Tinubu in respect of Federal Government Pension backlog, as unnecessary ghosting and futile political shadow chasing by an inept APC-led administration.

The Atiku Media Office in a response on Friday described as

untenable frivolity the disguised brickbat by the President to visiting Northeast political stakeholders led by Governor Babagana Zulum, where he blamed pension problems in the country on the Obasanjo/Atiku government that left office almost two decades before his.

"Both President Tinubu and his inept APC administration should seek more knowledge about good governance and developmental communication. Government is a continuum. The present helmsmen cannot continue to waste

valuable national time and resources on ghosting and blaming past administrations. A successor must inherit assets and liabilities," Atiku insisted.

It reminded that when President Olusegun Obasanjo/Atiku Abubakar took office in 1999, they inherited a broken, unfunded, and non-contributory Defined Benefits Scheme (DBS) that had accumulated an unsustainable pension liability deficit estimated at over N2 trillion (about 25% of the country's GDP at the time). They did not embark on calling out their predeces-

sors but rolled their sleeves to turn around the situation.

"But by the time Obasanjo/Atiku left office in 2007, their administration had completely revolutionised the sector by enacting the Pension Reform Act of 2004, leaving behind a fully funded, privately managed Contributory Pension Scheme (CPS) regulated by the newly established National Pension Commission (PenCom)."

As could be recalled, the old Pay-As-You-Go model relied purely on annual budgetary allocations, which were severely underfund-

ed and generated massive arrear backlogs.

The pension administration preceding the Obasanjo/Atiku era was highly fragmented across various government agencies, plagued by ghost pensioners, data inaccuracies, and severe bureaucratic delays.

Recall that many private sector employees completely lacked pension coverage, and the few existing schemes were mismanaged or entirely unfunded.

But when the Obasanjo/Atiku administration left office in 2007,

it was to their credit and benefit of pensioners that they left behind the Pension Reform Act (PRA) 2004, a landmark law modeled after international best practices which completely overhauled the country's retirement architecture.

The Obasanjo/Atiku administration introduced a mandatory system where both employers and employees contribute a minimum percentage of basic salary into individual Retirement Savings Accounts (RSAs).

It was mischievous of Tinubu not to acknowledge that the

AIG Zone 5, Dogo-Garba Bows Out, Lauds Edo, Delta Support In Crime Fight

FRANCIS ONOIRIBHOLO
BENIN

The Assistant Inspector-General of Police in charge of Zone 5, AIG Salman Dogo-Garba, has commended the Edo State Governor, Senator Monday Okpebholo, and his Delta State counterpart, Rt. Hon. Sheriff Francis Oborevwo, for their support during his tenure as the AIG of the Zone, attributing his success to their cooperation, especially their timely interventions in the fight against crime.

According to the retired AIG, "I attribute the successes my zonal command recorded

in the fight against crime in Edo and Delta states to the interventions and support of the two state governments."

AIG Dogo-Garba stated this during his pull-out parade held at the Police Training School, Ogida, Benin City, where he formally bowed out of the Nigeria Police Force after a distinguished career.

The retired AIG said the support provided by the governments of Edo and Delta had strengthened the capacity of the police to confront security challenges and sustain peace and order across the zone.

"I am particularly commending the Edo State Gov-

ernor, Senator Monday Okpebholo, and his Delta State counterpart, Rt. Hon. Sheriff Francis Oborevwo, for their cooperation and timely interventions in the fight against crime.

"I also wish to sincerely appreciate the Executive Governors of Edo and Delta State, Your Excellencies, Senator Monday Okpebholo and Rt. Hon. Elder Sheriff Francis Oborevwo, through their support, cooperation and timely interventions, we were better equipped to confront security challenges, strengthen public confidence, and maintain peace and order across Edo and Delta State.

"I also wish to express my gratitude and appreciation to the good people of Edo and Delta States, traditional institutions, religious bodies, community leaders, the media, civil society organisations, and all stakeholders whose cooperation significantly contributed to maintaining peace and public safety within the Zone. Security is a shared responsibility, and your partnership has been invaluable", he said.

Dogo-Garba described his tenure as AIG Zone 5 as one of the greatest privileges of his policing career, saying the achievements recorded were products of collective efforts,

teamwork and commitment by officers and men of the force.

AIG Dogo-Garba urged officers to wear the police uniform with pride and honour.

"To every officer still in service, I encourage you to wear the uniform with pride and honour. Let your conduct always reflect the core values of the Nigeria Police Force.

"Be courageous in the discharge of your duties, compassionate in dealing with members of the public, and resolute in protecting the lives and property of our citizens.

"Remember that the true legacy of an officer is mea-

sured not by rank, but by character, integrity, and the positive impact made on society," he stated.

The retired police chief also acknowledged the contributions of traditional rulers, community leaders, religious bodies, the media and other stakeholders, stressing that security remained a shared responsibility.

Dogo-Garba, who said he was leaving with cherished memories and a sense of fulfilment, pledged to continue supporting initiatives aimed at promoting peace, justice and national development even after his retirement from active policing.

Saturday Special

What Government Must Do Before Transiting 12-Year Compulsory Basic Education Model — Analysts

For over four decades, Nigeria has repeatedly sought to reinvent its education system. Successive governments have overhauled curricula, rebranded programmes and launched ambitious reforms, each promising to better equip graduates for a rapidly changing world. Yet, the reality within the nation's classrooms remains stark: overcrowded facilities, outdated materials and millions of children left entirely outside the school system. Against this backdrop, the Federal Government's proposal to transition to a unified 12-year compulsory basic education model has sparked a fierce national debate. While officials champion the plan as a vital step toward ensuring uninterrupted learning, critics are left questioning whether the government is genuinely fixing its schools or merely adjusting the arithmetic. **SOLA SHITTU** writes

For more than four decades, Nigeria has repeatedly attempted to reinvent its education system. Governments have changed curricula, renamed programmes and introduced ambitious reforms, each promising to produce graduates better equipped for the demands of a changing world. Yet the country's classrooms still tell a troubling story. Across many public schools, pupils squeeze into overcrowded classrooms, teachers struggle with outdated instructional materials, and millions of children remain outside the school system altogether.

It is against this backdrop that the Federal Government's proposal to replace the existing education structure with a unified 12-year compulsory basic education model followed by four years of tertiary education has sparked one of the most significant debates in the sector in recent years. To government officials, the reform is a bold attempt to guarantee uninterrupted learning and improve educational outcomes. To many education stakeholders, however, it raises an uncomfortable question: Is Nigeria fixing its schools or merely changing the arithmetic?

Education Minister Dr. Tunji Alausa insists the proposal is designed to keep every Nigerian child in school for twelve uninterrupted years before proceeding to higher education. Presenting the proposal to stakeholders, the minister argued that the reform would improve retention, reduce dropout rates and provide a stronger educational foundation for young Nigerians. He maintained that the objective is not simply to alter the structure but to align Nigeria's education system with evolving global standards and prepare learners for the demands of a knowledge-driven economy.

The announcement immediately revived memories of another ambitious reform introduced in 1982. Then, the 6-3-3-4 system was celebrated as a revolutionary departure from the colonial grammar school model. The idea was simple: six years of primary education, three years of junior secondary, three years of senior secondary and four years of tertiary education. More importantly, it promised vocational and technical education that would produce self-reliant graduates instead of job seekers.

The promise was compelling. The outcome was far less inspiring.

Across much of the country, technical workshops were never fully established. Laboratories remained poorly equipped, vocational subjects suffered from shortages of qualified teachers, while many state governments lacked the financial capacity to sustain the programme. Years later, the Universal Basic Education programme effectively merged the first nine years into a continuous cycle, yet many of the structural problems remained unresolved.

For many education analysts, this history explains why Nigerians are responding to the latest proposal with cautious opti-



Dr. Tunji Alausa, Minister of Education

mism rather than outright celebration.

"What matters is not merely the structure but the quality of implementation," former Executive Secretary of the National Universities Commission, Professor Peter Okebukola, has repeatedly argued in public lectures on education reform. According to him, teacher quality, curriculum delivery and sustained funding remain the real determinants of educational success.

His position reflects a growing consensus among education experts that Nigeria's greatest challenge has never been the absence of policy ideas but the inability to implement them consistently.

Indeed, available data reveal the scale of the challenge confronting the sector:

According to UNICEF, Nigeria has about 18.3 million out-of-school children, the highest number globally. Poverty, insecurity, child labour, early marriage, displacement caused by armed conflict and inadequate school infrastructure continue to keep millions of children away from classrooms. In several northern states, attacks on schools have further compounded the crisis, while rapid population growth has placed enormous pressure on already overstretched education facilities. Against this backdrop, many education experts argue that increasing school enrolment and improving learning outcomes should take precedence over another structural reorganisation of the education system.

Against these realities, critics argue that reorganising the education ladder, however well-intentioned, may not by itself improve learning outcomes.

Professor Emeritus Pai Obanya, one of Nigeria's foremost education scholars, has consistently maintained that successful reforms depend on what happens inside classrooms rather than on administrative restructuring. His long-held position is that investment in teachers, curriculum content and learning resources ultimately determines whether reforms succeed or fail.

That raises another question that the

government has yet to answer comprehensively: how much will the transition cost?

Transforming the existing structure into a seamless twelve-year compulsory education programme will require curriculum reviews, teacher retraining, expansion of classrooms, new instructional materials and increased financial commitments from both federal and state governments. Many states are already struggling to meet existing obligations, including teachers' salaries and school infrastructure.

The concern is particularly significant because education remains on the concurrent legislative list, leaving implementation largely dependent on the financial strength and political commitment of individual states. Without substantial investment, observers warn that the new model could inherit the same weaknesses that limited the effectiveness of previous reforms.

That possibility lies at the heart of the current debate. For many stakeholders, the issue is no longer whether Nigeria should embrace another education reform. The real issue is whether this reform finally addresses the systemic failures that have undermined every major policy introduced over the last forty years.

If the Federal Government succeeds in convincing the National Council on Education and other critical stakeholders to embrace the proposed 12-year compulsory basic education model, the real work will only just be beginning.

Beyond the policy announcements lies a more difficult assignment—finding the resources to make the reform meaningful.

That challenge becomes even more daunting when viewed against Nigeria's education financing record. Although allocations to the education sector have increased in nominal terms over the years, analysts note that they still fall short of what is required for a country with one of the world's fastest-growing school-age populations. The proposed 12-year compulsory education model will demand thousands of additional classrooms, recruitment and retraining of teachers, expanded digital learning infrastructure and increased funding for instructional materials. Without a corresponding financial commitment from both the Federal Government and the states, experts warn that the reform risks becoming another well-intentioned policy undermined by inadequate implementation.

Education experts argue that no restructuring can succeed without corresponding investments in teachers, infrastructure,

learning materials and technology. Nigeria's public schools already face an acute shortage of qualified teachers, while thousands of classrooms across the country require renovation or complete reconstruction. In many communities, pupils still sit on bare floors, share outdated textbooks or learn under makeshift structures.

Former Minister of Education, Dr. Obiageli Ezekwesili, has repeatedly argued that Nigeria's education crisis is fundamentally a governance challenge. Speaking at various education forums over the years, she has maintained that sustainable reforms require accountability, transparency and consistent investment rather than periodic policy pronouncements. Her position echoes the concerns of many education advocates who fear that successive governments have often launched new initiatives without fully implementing existing ones.

Private school operators, who educate millions of Nigerian children, have also urged caution. The National Association of Proprietors of Private Schools (NAPPS) has welcomed discussions aimed at improving educational quality but insists that major reforms should emerge from broad consultation with stakeholders. Its National President, Yomi Otubela, has said any transition of this magnitude must involve state governments, school owners, teachers, parents and curriculum experts to avoid unintended consequences that could disrupt learning.

Teachers' unions have equally stressed that the success of any reform depends on those who stand before the classroom every day. While many educators agree that uninterrupted learning may reduce administrative bottlenecks between junior and senior secondary school, they argue that motivation remains poor. Large class sizes, delayed promotions, inadequate welfare and limited opportunities for professional development continue to affect classroom performance. Without addressing these concerns, they warn, changing the structure alone will not improve educational outcomes.

International experience appears to support that position. Countries frequently cited as global models—such as Finland, Singapore and South Korea—did not transform their education systems simply by adjusting the number of years pupils spent in school. Their success was built on sustained investment in teacher quality, curriculum relevance, educational technology, continuous assessment and strong institutional accountability. The lesson for Nigeria is that structural reforms are only one component of a much broader ecosystem.

There is also a political dimension to the current proposal. Every administration seeks a signature policy capable of defining its legacy. Education, because of its far-reaching impact, naturally attracts ambitious reforms. Yet history offers a sobering reminder that policies are remembered not for the elegance of their design but for the effectiveness of their implementation.

The 6-3-3-4 system itself was conceived with lofty objectives, including vocational education and self-reliance, but inadequate funding and weak execution prevented many of those aspirations from becoming reality.

For parents struggling with rising living costs, the debate is far less theoretical. Their expectations are simple. They want schools that are safe, qualified teachers who are motivated, classrooms that inspire learning and graduates equipped with practical skills for employment or entrepreneurship. Whether those outcomes are delivered through a 6-3-3-4, 9-3-4 or 12-4 framework matters less than the quality of education their children ultimately receive.

That perhaps is the central question confronting policymakers. Is the proposed reform addressing the root causes of Nigeria's education crisis, or is it another attempt to redesign a system weakened by years of underfunding, inconsistent implementation and policy discontinuity?

The answer will not emerge from policy documents or stakeholder meetings alone. It will be found in rural schools where children still walk several kilometres to class, in overcrowded urban classrooms where one teacher manages dozens of pupils, and in the confidence with which future graduates compete in an increasingly knowledge-driven global economy.

As the debate gathers momentum, Nigerians appear willing to give the proposal a fair hearing. But they are equally demanding evidence that this time will be different. After decades of reforms that produced mixed results, expectations have shifted from ambitious promises to measurable outcomes.

If the proposed 12-year compulsory basic education model eventually becomes national policy, its success will not be judged by the number of years a child spends in school or by the simplicity of its structure. It will be judged by whether it produces children who can read with understanding, think critically, solve problems creatively and acquire skills that improve their lives and strengthen the nation's future.

For now, the Federal Government has placed another bold idea on the table. Whether history records it as a genuine turning point or simply another chapter in Nigeria's long catalogue of education reforms will depend not on the policy itself, but on the political will, financial commitment and institutional discipline required to make it work.

Ultimately, Nigerians are not asking whether the country should adopt a 12-4 education system. They are asking a more fundamental question: after decades of abandoned promises, does the Federal Government have the political will—and the financial capacity—to ensure that this reform succeeds where every previous one struggled? Until that question is answered with action rather than policy declarations, changing the numbers may do little to change the future.

Life&Style



**Despite The Illegality Of Piracy,
It Sometimes Gave Actors
Massive Visibility — Queen
Oluwa**

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THE TEAM	
Tomi Falade	Life Editor
Oyin Somorin	Reporter
Ovwe Medeme	Contributor
Samuel Obanikoro	Intern
GRAPHICS	
Brown Clement	
Joseph O. Ajibolu	

News



His Eminence Muhammadu Sa'ad Abubakar III, Sultan of Sokoto (left); Biodun Oyeboji, Governor, Ekiti State/ special guest of honour (second left); Ahmad Aliyu Sokoto, Governor, Sokoto State (second right), and Senator Aliyu Wammako, former Governor, Sokoto State, during the commissioning of Arkilla-Gidan Fulani-Gidan Dare Road project in Sokoto, on Thursday.

Probe Cause Of Enugu Air Runway Excursion At Benin Airport, Obi Urges NCAA, NSIB

FRANCIS ONOIRIBHOLO
BENIN

Peter Obi has called for a thorough investigation into the runway excursion involving an Enugu Air aircraft at Benin Airport, describing the incident as a stark reminder of the need to strengthen aviation safety standards in Nigeria.

In a statement shared on his official social media page on Friday, the former Labour Party presidential candidate reacted to the incident, in which the aircraft veered off the runway while landing at the airport.

Obi expressed relief that all 68 passengers and crew members on board escaped without injury

or loss of life.

The Anambra State former governor urged authorities to conduct a comprehensive investigation to establish the cause of the incident and implement measures to prevent similar occurrences, emphasising that the safety of air travelers must remain a national priority.

"I received, with profound relief, the news of the runway excursion involving an Enugu Air aircraft during its landing at Benin Airport today," Obi said.

He expressed gratitude to God that everyone on board the aircraft disembarked safely, stressing that the protection of human lives must remain the highest priority in the aviation sector.

Obi also commended the pi-

lot, members of the flight crew and emergency response personnel at the Benin Airport for what he described as their swift and professional handling of the situation.

"I commend the pilot, the flight crew, and the airport emergency response teams at Benin Airport for their swift and professional handling of the situation, which averted what could have been a major tragedy," Obi said.

He said the incident underscores the importance of strict compliance with aviation safety procedures, regular aircraft maintenance and sustained investment in airport infrastructure.

He urged the Nigerian Civil Aviation Authority, NCAA, and

the Nigerian Safety Investigation Bureau, NSIB, to carry out a comprehensive, transparent and timely investigation to determine the cause of the incident.

"I urge the relevant regulatory and investigative bodies particularly the Nigerian Civil Aviation Authority (NCAA) and the Nigerian Safety Investigation Bureau (NSIB) to conduct a thorough, transparent, and timely investigation into the root cause of this incident," Obi added.

The Anambra State former governor maintained that the incident should serve as a learning opportunity to reinforce aviation safety measures and enhance efforts to keep Nigeria's airspace safe for all passengers and operators.

Seplat Reaffirms Commitment To Advancing Africa's Future Workforce

Seplat Energy Plc, foremost Nigerian indigenous energy company, has reaffirmed its commitment to advancing education and developing Africa's future workforce, emphasising the need for stronger collaboration between government, the private sector and development partners to build sustainable learning systems across the continent.

The company restated its position at the 2026 Africa Social Impact Summit (ASIS), where it sponsored the plenary session, Powering Africa's Future: Private Sector Leadership in Education Transformation. The session brought together policymakers, business leaders, development partners, academics and education stakeholders to explore how strategic partnerships, digital innovation and investment in STEAM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Arts and Mathematics) can prepare young Africans for the future of work.

The Chief Executive Officer of Seplat Energy Plc, Mr. Roger Brown, represented by Chioma Afe, Director, External Affairs and Social Performance, said the company's partnership with ASIS reflects its commitment

to driving meaningful impact through collaboration.

"Our partnership with the Africa Social Impact Summit provides an opportunity to collaborate with organisations that share our vision of transforming education on a national scale. This goes beyond conversations to action," he said.

Brown noted that Seplat Energy continues to invest in educational development across its host communities in Edo, Delta and Imo states, with plans to extend its interventions to Akwa Ibom State. These investments span basic and secondary education, tertiary scholarships, teacher empowerment programmes, STEAM education through the company's Access to Energy initiative and STEAM laboratories, as well as the Seplat Innovation Programme, which encourages secondary school students to develop innovative clean energy solutions in partnership with the Nigerian National Petroleum Company limited (NNPCL).

He stressed that addressing Africa's education challenges requires stronger partnerships among governments, the private sector and development organisations.

Court Dismisses David Mark's Objection To Nafiu Gombe's Suit On ADC Leadership Dispute

KENNETH ATAVTI
ABUJA

Justice Peter Odo Lifu of the Federal High Court on Friday, dismissed the objections by the National Chairman of the African Democratic Congress ADC, Senator David Mark to the bid by a chairman of the party, Nafiu Bala Gombe, to amend his claims in the leadership suit filed against ADC and others.

The Judge in a ruling on Friday held that the objections by Mark and Rauf Aregbesola to originating summons amendment by Nafiu Gombe were frivolous, baseless and without iota of merit.

Justice Lifu said that the sought amendment which was to give life to the case of the plaintiff was a normal attempt in a civil litigation to ensure that miscarriage of justice is prevented.

Besides, the Judge held that the sought amendment was occasioned by a change of counsel adding that the apprehension exhibited by David Mark was unnecessary and uncalled for.

Justice Lifu said that the ADC national chairman and other defendants in the matter are at liberty to file counter affidavit against the Amended originating summons to indicate conse-

quential amendment to the earlier one.

The Judge said that after perusing the whole objections of the defendants, he was unable to see where they would be overwhelmed, overreached or jeopardised if the amendment was granted.

Justice Lifu consequently dismissed the objections and allowed the amendment by the plaintiff.

He imposed a fine of N500,000 on Mark and Aregbesola to be paid to Nafiu Bala Gombe.

David Mark and the National Secretary of the party, Rauf Aregbesola, had kicked against the fresh attempt by Nafiu Bala Gombe to amend claims in the leadership suit filed against them.

Mark and Aregbesola had urged Justice Lifu not to allow the amendments to the allegations against them on the ground that doing so would lead to a miscarriage of justice.

Nafiu Gombe, a former Deputy National Chairman of the ADC, had through his counsel, Lukman Fagbemi (SAN), moved an application seeking amendments to the originating summons he filed against the ADC, Mark, Aregbesola, and others, challenging the emergence of the defendants as new national officers of the party.

Workers Aren't Just Voters But Equal Partners In Governance — Accord Presidential Candidate

JOY ANIGBOGU
LAGOS

Presidential Candidate of the Accord Party and Co-Chairman of the Movement for Democratic Renewal (MDR), Dr. Gbenga Olawepo-Hashim, has said that Nigeria cannot be renewed without its workers, describing organised labour as the indispensable force for rebuilding the country's democracy and restoring accountable governance.

Hashim made the declaration at the formal launch of the Movement for Democratic Renewal (MDR) in the Federal Capital Territory, held at the Nigeria Labour Congress (NLC) Labour House, Abuja, in collaboration with the NLC FCT Council, on Friday.

The event brought together labour coordinators from affiliate unions, labour leaders and democratic stakeholders to inaugurate the movement in the FCT and mobilise support for a nationwide campaign for democratic renewal, responsible leadership and National restoration.

Represented by his Chief of

Staff, Mr. Kamaldeen Adebayo Sanni, Hashim said workers must no longer be seen merely as voters during elections but as equal partners in governance, policy formulation and National development.

"Nigeria cannot be renewed without its workers. Workers are not just voters; they're Nation builders. They must become equal partners in governance, policy making and National development," he declared.

He outlined the Movement's priorities, including expanding economic opportunities through entrepreneurship, technology, vocational skills and agricultural value chains; improving access to quality education and digital literacy; strengthening affordable healthcare; protecting citizens through institutional reforms; and promoting leadership based on competence, integrity and merit.

Gbenga Hashim also reaffirmed his confidence in the rule of law despite the ongoing legal proceedings concerning his emergence as the Accord Party's Presidential candidate, urging supporters to remain peaceful,

law abiding and committed to democratic principles.

Earlier, Chairman of the NLC FCT Council, Comrade Stephen Nnabayi, welcomed participants and described the launch as timely, noting that Nigeria is facing enormous socioeconomic and political challenges requiring organised labour to once again assume a leading role in defending democracy, protecting workers' rights and advancing good governance.

He commended the leadership of the Movement for Democratic Renewal for partnering with organised labour to build a broad coalition for National transformation.

Presenting the vision of the Movement, Comrade Nanman Philemon Kash explained that MDR was established as a broad National coalition committed to democratic accountability, responsible leadership, transparency, social justice, workers' political participation, youth and women inclusion, National unity and people-centred economic reforms.

She said the movement seeks to reconnect citizens with gover-

nance and promote ethical leadership capable of restoring confidence in Nigeria's democratic institutions.

Also speaking, Hashim's Legal Adviser, Mr. Chukwunyer Akwiti, emphasised that respect for the rule of law remains fundamental to democratic stability, urging Nigerians to strengthen confidence in constitutional institutions and judicial processes.

The Director General of the Hashim Grassroots Mobilisation Movement, Pastor Ayinla Samuel, called for sustained grassroots mobilisation, saying meaningful democratic change must be driven from communities, workplaces and polling units across the country rather than from political elites alone.

A major highlight of the launch was an interactive session during which labour leaders identified rising living costs, unemployment, insecurity, weak democratic institutions, electoral reforms, declining workers' influence in governance and poor political accountability as major National concerns.

Life & Style Interview

How I Fought Idumota Marketers, Survived, The Unfiltered 33-Year Odyssey Of Queen Oluwa

If there is one thing you must know about **Queen Temitope Oluwa**, popular as **Queen Oluwa**, it is that she does not know how to play small, bow to gatekeepers, or back down from a fight. In a career spanning over three decades, the Nollywood actress and producer has seen it all, from physically confronting tyrannical film marketers on the streets of Idumota to being blacklisted for refusing to let her work be pirated. In this explosive, deeply personal conversation, Queen Oluwa breaks down the chaotic transition from the wild days of VHS and Alaba piracy to the modern YouTube hustle. She opens up about the absurd societal stigmas female stars face, including an offer to trade her acting career for a business. Finally, she reveals the astonishing, spiritually guided series of events involving two pairs of jeans, \$30 in cash, and a near-death encounter that accidentally turned a two-day trip to America into a permanent relocation. **TOMI FALADE** brings excerpts.

Nollywood has evolved so much from the era of VHS and DVDs to the rise of streaming platforms. I remember when streaming first started, it was a huge issue. Yewande Adekoya was one of the first people to start uploading her films on YouTube, along with you and Kunle Afod. I remember the marketers were seriously upset and fought back. Having witnessed this evolution, and being someone whose relocation hasn't stopped you from producing or featuring in films when you return for holidays, how do you view this transition from the VHS/DVD days to where we are now?

It has been a long and remarkable journey. I am genuinely happy that many producers are doing well today because they have independent platforms to sell their work without having to bow to marketers. That was one of our biggest struggles back then.

My personal experience with marketers was awful. I was actually blacklisted at one point because my film was pirated. I had just finished editing a movie and was walking around the Island when I started hearing my own voice coming from several small local cinemas. I thought it was a promo, but then I met an actress who asked why I didn't feature her in the film. That was when it hit me that someone was showing my full, unreleased movie. I walked into one of the cinemas, turned off the projector right there, and we ended up at the police station. It turned out a marketer had leaked it. Everyone, including top actors, begged me to drop it, saying, "You cannot fight marketers." But I refused to listen and kept pushing. As a result, I was blacklisted for years.

Back in the VHS days, if you sold a thousand copies, you were considered a success. Then came DVDs, which brought higher sales volume but also ramped up piracy that ruined many careers. Marketers at Idumota operated like mini-gods; actors would literally beg them for transportation money just to get home. But because I am 100% Lagos Island-bred, whenever they messed with my money, I would show up at Idumota with my people to "re-arrange their brains." Eventually, marketers left Idumota, and today, even they have been forced to join the YouTube wave. Actors are definitely faring better now than they did back then.

I know many people argue that while the VHS and DVD days were rife with piracy,



those platforms gave immense popularity to faces and films that built the foundation of the industry today. Do you agree with that?

I completely agree. Back then, with video rental clubs everywhere, the reach was incredible. Market women were the ones driving the hype. Today, most of those women do not go to the cinema or watch YouTube, so they do not know the newer faces. Despite the illegality of piracy, it gave actors massive visibility in places they never expected. People in remote areas would recognise you instantly. Now, streaming is trying to replicate that reach, but getting onto major streaming plat-

forms today is almost as difficult as dealing with the old marketers because of the moneyed gatekeepers involved.

What are your thoughts on the current marketing trends on social media and YouTube?

The only thing I really dislike about the current YouTube era is the mandatory dancing required for promotion. Everything now requires dancing and noise. Back in the day, you went on Gbenga Adewusi's show to talk about your film, but now it is all about viral dances. I remember releasing a movie on YouTube through a marketer after recovering from an accident. Madam Saje called me, furious, asking why I wasn't dancing to promote the project. I told her, "Mama, I just had an accident, I can't dance!" Eventually, I had to take the movie down until I was fit enough. It is tough for those of us who aren't natural dancers, though I suppose you can always hire dancers to do it for you now.

33 years in a career is no small feat, doing the same thing back and forth, even while shuttling between Nigeria and the US. Over these 33 years, this has been your main platform for fame and livelihood. Do you ever regret getting into acting?

No, not at any point.

So, what has this career taken away from you?

A lot. There are people who instantly disrespect you the moment they find out you are an actress, though I don't entirely blame them given how some ladies behave. I remember being in a store in the UK when a man was talking to me. Someone mentioned I was an actress, and right in front of me, the man remarked to his friend, "Oh, those prostitutes." I just walked away. What was I going to say to him? He must have seen or heard something.

On another occasion, I was dating a guy and went to meet his parents. His mother was cold toward me, despite admitting she enjoyed one of my movies. She pulled her son outside, and on our way back, he told me, "Queen, we have to make some changes. My mum sells Viju Milk, and she isn't comfortable with your acting career. I'm going to get you a shop so you can start selling Viju Milk too!" Imagine that! Me, selling Viju Milk? Look at it now.

I notice a massive wave of Nollywood ac-

tors relocating abroad—to the UK and the US. You could practically shoot a full Nollywood blockbuster in the UK or US with the number of actors living there now, like She-Baby, Taiwo Aromokun, Kiki Bakare, Mimi Daniels, Doris Simeon, Funsho Adeolu, Joseph Benjamin, Teju Babyface, and Yinka Adewale. What do you think is the motivation behind this mass relocation, and what is your own story?

Honestly, I was never motivated to relocate. I love Nigeria, and I love Lagos State with all my heart. My relocation was an absolute accident. In January 2017, I was supposed to start shooting a movie in Nigeria on the 21st. My cousin in the US had been on my neck to bring my daughter over for school. So, I bought a ticket to New York, intending to stay for just two days, drop my daughter off, and fly right back to Lagos for my shoot. I travelled with just two pairs of jeans, four tops, \$30 in cash, and less than \$500 on my Bank of America card.

When I landed in New York on January 17th, my cousin suddenly stopped picking up my calls. I was stranded. A friend picked me up and took me to a hotel, where I was paying in Naira using my GTBank card. My brother warned me on the phone never to return to Nigeria with my daughter after all the back-and-forth. When my cousin finally called back two days later making excuses, I went to her place, but her husband refused to let my daughter stay.

Scrambling for solutions, I headed to Maryland to stay with my uncle. While there, I received a phone call from a friend's sister whom I had only met once in London. She told me God said I should stand still wherever I was because He was keeping me there for a purpose. Then, she put an elderly man on the phone who repeated the exact same message to me.

That was when I broke down in tears. You see, before leaving Nigeria earlier, a stranger had warned my friend about a vision of a coffin in front of me, telling me not to travel. I ignored it, went to Nigeria anyway, and shortly after, I collapsed for no medical reason. I was bedridden for months, receiving blood transfusions, and at one point, doctors told my family I was brought in dead and revived by a miracle. So when that man in America gave me the exact same spiritual instruction to stay put, I knew I couldn't risk flying back. That was how a two-day trip with \$30 cash turned into my permanent relocation.

Dating Affairs

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HeartBeat

My Husband Doesn't See Me As Virgin Material

DEAR OYIN,

My one-month-old marriage is in turmoil as I write this. It all started the very night we got married. My husband says I lied to him. But I never lied when I told him I was a virgin. I didn't want any promise-and-fail, so I told him I wasn't going to have sex until marriage, and he agreed.

Throughout our dating period, he kept asking questions: if I was ever kissed, why I never slept in any man's bed, and my age being too old to be a virgin – but I stood my ground, and according to him, that was the reason he expedited everything so we could get married before our relationship was even a year old.

On our first night together, I went through hell. I have never known pain that intense. But I endured it in silence so he could have what he had always wanted. Right after we had sex, he rolled onto his back and stared at the ceiling.

He said I lied to him, but I could barely talk because of the pain. I demanded why he accused me of such, and his answer was, "You're not a virgin. Why was it so



easy for me to go through? And why isn't there any bloodstain?"

He pushed me aside and checked the bed. There was nothing there.

He concluded that I had lied just to get him to marry me while I had been sleeping with other men all along. I was deeply hurt, and it quickly turned into an argument.

For the past one month, we haven't had anything that resembles a marriage. He goes out and comes back whenever he wants. He doesn't eat anything I cook. He even stopped me from bringing all my belongings into his house because of this.

Now I'm back at my parents' house, waiting to see what his next move will be.

Why is it so hard for him to believe me?

Mary, Lagos

Dear Mary, He doesn't believe you because he never loved you in the first place. What he wanted was sex, which he already got. He is having regrets because he had expectations of what a virgin would be like.

I guess he is disappointed in himself, not you. He is not worth you, so my advice: move on. Let him be the one to feel concerned that you don't feel his absence, or else he will take advantage of things in the relationship. He is already doing that, wanting you to plead for attention. This I would advise you never to do.

Relationship Tips:

Tips To Create A Great Relationship (2)

Talk about sex, openly and honestly - Telling your partner what feels good and what you like and don't like helps you have better sex. Never pressure your partner into doing something they don't want to do, or let your partner pressure you, consent is a must.

Take care of your sexual health - Talk to your partner about how you're going to protect each other against STDs and unintended pregnancy. Practice safer sex and get tested for STDs.

How do I know if your relationship is healthy?

It's good to check in with yourself from time to time to see how you're feeling about your relationship. The questions below focus on romantic and sexual relationships, but they can apply to other kinds of relationships, too. After you've asked yourself these questions, it could be helpful to answer them again from your partner's perspective.

Does your partner listen to and respect your ideas?

Does your partner give you space to spend time with your friends and family?

Do you have fun spending time together?

Do you feel comfortable telling your partner when something they do upsets you?

Do you feel comfortable sharing your



thoughts and feelings?

Can you tell your partner what you like sexually? Does your partner make an effort to get along with your friends and family?

Is your partner proud of your accomplishments and successes?

Does your partner respect your differences?

Can you talk to your partner about birth control and/or safer sex?

To be continued

Roses & Thorns



Coca-Cola Ambassador

My neighbour, Mama Kemi, is not just a human being... she is a full-time ambassador for Coca-Cola.

Every morning, before the sun even stretches, you hear "pssshhh!" — that sweet sound of a bottle opening. That is not an alarm clock; that is Mama Kemi starting her day. While normal people drink water to brush their teeth, Mama Kemi rinses her mouth with Coke as if it were holy water.

One day I greeted her, "Good morning, Ma."

She said, "Wait first," and took one long sip like she was charging her spirit. Then she replied, "Now I'm ready. Good morning."

This woman does not joke with Coke. I once went to her house thinking I would collect some sugar. When I entered her kitchen, I nearly fainted. No water, no juice, no milk... just Coke. Big Coke, small Coke, bottle Coke, can Coke — even the fridge was sweating from overwork.

I asked her, "Mama Kemi, don't you drink water?"

She looked at me as if I had insulted her ancestors and said, "Coke is water with an upgrade."

One afternoon, a neighbourhood

meeting was called because somebody's goat drank her Coke, which she had kept outside to chill. Mama Kemi did not shout small ooo. She said, "This goat has tasted greatness; it can never be normal again!"

From that day, the goat started behaving strangely. It would be jumping around as if it had a motivational speech inside its body. People said Mama Kemi had turned the goat into "Coke ambassador junior".

The funniest part happened last Sunday. Mama Kemi went to church with her handbag. Inside that bag? Not a Bible... not a notebook... but two bottles of Coke. When it was time for prayer, everybody closed their eyes, but Mama Kemi opened a Coke quietly like she was performing a secret operation.

Pssshhh!

The whole church turned around.

The pastor said, "Who opened that?"

Mama Kemi said, "Sir, it is the spirit refreshing me."

Even the choir could not continue singing properly. One of them whispered, "Is it possible to fast from Coke?"

That day, the pastor preached about self-control, but Mama Kemi just nodded and took another sip, as if to say, "God understands my situation."



The People's Verdict

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FRSC's Amendment Bill: Good Intentions, Poor Optics

Good public policy is measured not only by the nobility of its intentions but also by the wisdom of its design and the optics of its implementation. In a country as ethnically and religiously diverse as Nigeria, where public trust in institutions remains fragile, policymakers have a duty to ensure that legislation commands confidence as much as it pursues legitimate objectives.

It is against this backdrop that the Federal Road Safety Corps (FRSC) Amendment Bill, 2026, deserves a second look before it receives presidential assent.

No one disputes the need for safer highways. The proposed stiffer sanctions for speeding, drunk driving, reckless driving and other traffic violations are largely commendable. Nigeria loses thousands of lives annually to avoidable road crashes, and stronger deterrence is long overdue.

However, two provisions of the bill threaten to overshadow its noble objectives: the criminalisation of preaching in commercial vehicles and the proposal to arm the FRSC.

Evidence-based public policy should rest on demonstrable facts rather than assumptions. While there is abundant empirical evidence that driver distraction contributes to road crashes, there is no comparable body of evidence establishing religious preaching in commercial buses as a distinct or measurable cause of accidents. Unless such evidence exists, expressly criminalising "preaching" raises an important question: is the law addressing a proven road safety risk or merely legislating perception?

If distraction is indeed the concern, then the law should prohibit every activity capable of distracting a driver—religious, political, commercial or social—without singling out any particular form

of expression. Such an approach would not only achieve the same safety objective but would also be constitutionally safer and socially less divisive.

Whether the provision was intended to target Christians is almost secondary. Leadership is judged less by the purity of its intentions than by its appreciation of context. Nigeria remains a nation navigating delicate religious fault-lines. The lingering controversy over the Muslim-Muslim presidential ticket, recurring allegations of religious marginalisation, reports of sectarian violence, and the prevailing trust deficit have all combined to heighten public sensitivity around issues of faith.

Against this backdrop, expressly criminalising "preaching" in commercial vehicles was always going to provoke suspicion, particularly because organised bus evangelism is more commonly associated with Christian denominations. The optics, therefore, are poor, regardless of legislative intent.

It is unsurprising that organisations such as the Northern States Christian Elders Forum, the Christian Council of Nigeria and the Organisation of African Instituted Churches have urged President Bola Tinubu to withhold assent to the bill in its current form. Their contention is straightforward: road safety can be enhanced without creating the impression that constitutionally protected religious expression is under legislative



Tinubu

assault.

The concern extends beyond religious freedom. It is also about legislative precision. How, for instance, will enforcement distinguish between organised evangelism, two passengers discussing religion, someone sharing a personal testimony, or an imam offering a brief exhortation? Such ambiguities create fertile grounds

for arbitrary interpretation, selective enforcement and avoidable confrontation.

The proposal to arm the FRSC is even more troubling. Nigeria is already awash with armed security and law enforcement agencies. While the safety of FRSC personnel is a legitimate concern, creating yet another armed institution may amount to an unnecessary expansion of the country's coercive architecture. Every additional armed agency in-

troduces new risks of jurisdictional conflicts, abuse of power and greater militarisation of civilian spaces.

More importantly, the proposal appears premature at a time when the national conversation is increasingly gravitating towards state policing. Should Nigeria eventually embrace state police, security presence and response

capacity at the subnational level would be significantly strengthened, including along highways where violent crimes occur. Against that emerging reality, transforming the FRSC into another armed agency would merely duplicate responsibilities better handled by institutions constitutionally established for that purpose.

The FRSC was conceived as a road safety and traffic management agency, not as a conventional security outfit. Institutional effectiveness is better achieved through specialisation and stronger collaboration with the Nigeria Police Force and other security agencies than through an ever-expanding mandate.

Good governance requires more than good intentions. It demands sensitivity, restraint and an appreciation of context. A policy that appears technically sound but ignores constitutional realities, institutional boundaries and Nigeria's fragile ethno-religious equilibrium is bound to encounter resistance, irrespective of its value proposition.

President Tinubu has an opportunity to preserve the commendable aspects of this legislation while returning the contentious provisions for further legislative refinement. The objective of safer roads is too important to be undermined by avoidable controversies.

Sometimes, the difference between a good law and a great one lies not in what it seeks to achieve, but in how wisely it is

NGOZI UMA

Nigeria is set to host a landmark international conference and festival aimed at promoting coffee as a major economic commodity while strengthening cultural and commercial ties between Africa and the Arab world.

The organisers, Spirit of Coffee 2.0, announced that the two-day event will take place on November 18 and 19, 2026, at the Arts and Culture Centre, Garki Area 11, Abuja.

In a statement issued on Sunday in Abuja, the organisers described the festival as a new annual platform designed to promote creative excellence, trade, cultural diplomacy and investment in Africa's growing coffee industry.

The event is being organised by Spirit of Coffee 2.0 in partnership with the West Africa Specialty Coffee Association (WASCA) and Naeche Communications Ltd.

According to the organisers, the conference will bring together representatives from several African and Arab countries, diplomats, government officials, private sector leaders, coffee merchants, investors, academics, media practitioners and industry experts to explore the enormous economic potential of coffee and its value chain.

They said discussions will focus on how

Nigeria To Host African-Arab Art, Coffee, Cultural Commerce Festival In November

coffee production, processing and trade can contribute to increased Gross Domestic Product (GDP), foreign exchange earnings and job creation across African countries.

Beyond the economic discussions, the organisers said the event is designed to unite Africa and the Arab world through coffee, which they described as one of the world's most widely shared cultural traditions.

They explained that the festival will serve as a meeting point for artists, master baristas, coffee producers, investors, policymakers and cultural leaders, creating opportunities for collaboration, innovation and business partnerships.

The organisers said the event would be built around four major activities, including a curated coffee-themed art exhibition,



a national baristas' championship, executive papers and panel discussions, as well as a closing awards and auction ceremony.

According to them, Spirit of Coffee 2.0 is not intended to be a one-off event but an annual institution that will continue to grow in significance while showcasing Africa's creative economy and coffee industry to the global market.

They also noted that Africa has for

decades exported coffee as a raw commodity, only to import finished coffee products at much higher prices. They believe the festival will help change that narrative by encouraging local value addition, creativity and enterprise across the continent.

Speaking on the initiative, President of Spirit of Coffee 2.0, Mr. Larry Segun Lean, said the festival belongs to everyone involved in the coffee value chain, from farmers and artists to baristas and entrepreneurs.

According to him, Abuja will host an opening ceremony, high-level panel discussions, a fiercely contested national baristas' championship, coffee-inspired art exhibitions and installations, and a gala night featuring awards and auctions.

He said the overall objective is to build lasting commercial and cultural relationships between African and Arab creative communities, businesses and diplomatic institutions.

Lean called on embassies, cultural organisations, government agencies, cor-

porate institutions, investors and development partners to support the initiative, describing it as a movement that would redefine African-Arab cooperation through coffee, culture and commerce.

"This is an invitation not merely to attend, but to belong," he said, adding that the festival offers stakeholders the opportunity to become part of a project that will shape Africa's coffee and cultural industries for generations.

Also speaking, the Secretary of Spirit of Coffee 2.0, Chief T.P.C. Benjamin, mNGE, described the festival as Africa's response to the need for the continent to move beyond supplying raw materials to creating globally recognised products and experiences.

He said the initiative combines heritage, creativity and enterprise while providing a platform for Africa to tell its own story through its culture, craftsmanship and commercial potential.

Benjamin added that the organisers are committed to building a lasting institution that will create opportunities for future generations and strengthen Africa's identity in the global coffee industry.

He called on governments, institutions, private organisations and individuals who share the vision of a more prosperous and globally competitive Africa to partner with the organisers in making the maiden edition of Spirit of Coffee 2.0 a success.

Reel 2 Real

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STAGE, SCREEN & SOCIAL MEDIA

What To Expect From The Season 11 Big Brother Naija Show Tomorrow

As the countdown ticks down to its final hours, the entire continent is collectively preparing for the return of Africa's biggest reality television juggernaut. Big Brother Naija Season 11 officially premieres this Sunday, July 26, at 7:00 PM WAT, bringing an end to weeks of social media speculation, fan theories, and widespread anticipation.

For the next 10 weeks, pop-culture conversations, social media trends, and living room debates across Nigeria and the African continent will once again be dominated by the happenings inside Biggie's house. If you are wondering what to expect as the curtains rise on this landmark edition, here is your essential preview of what lies ahead for launch night.

The stakes for Season 11 have been elevated to an unprecedented level in the franchise's history. MultiChoice Nigeria confirmed that this year's ultimate winner will walk away with a staggering N160 million grand prize package, which includes a cool N100 million in cold hard cash alongside a brand-new Sports Utility Vehicle (SUV). With a life-changing fortune on the line, viewers should expect housemates to hit the ground running with intense, calculated, and high-stakes gameplay right from day one.

No Big Brother Naija launch night is complete without the master of ceremonies himself, Ebuka Obi-Uchendu. Returning to host another thrilling season, Ebuka is expected to deliver his signature



BIG BROTHER NAIJA

blend of sharp, unscripted wit and jaw-dropping sartorial statements. Beyond the fashion, viewers can rely on Ebuka to ask the uncomfortable questions as he introduces the new batch of contestants before ushering them through the iconic doors.

While the organisers have kept the identities of the housemates closely guarded, fans can anticipate a carefully curated mix of personalities, backgrounds, and professions drawn from across the country. The real intrigue, however, lies in the secret structural twists MultiChoice has engineered for this season. With betPawa stepping in as the official Headline Sponsor, joined by

Guinness and Minimie, executive producers have teased that fresh game mechanics will disrupt traditional strategic play right from the premiere.

The opening ceremony will air live from 7:00 PM WAT across Africa Magic Showcase and Africa Magic Family channels. Immediately following the launch broadcast, the dedicated 24-hour live feed will kick off on DStv Channel 198 and GOtv Channel 49, as well as on-the-go streaming via the DStv Stream and GOtv Stream apps.

Viewers can expect intense competition, unscripted drama, and strategic gameplay right from the opening night."

Battle Of Verses: 11 Outstanding Poetry Collections Make \$100,000 Nigeria Prize For Literature Longlist

Out of a staggering 223 submissions received from writers across the country and the diaspora, 11 exceptional poetry collections have officially emerged on the longlist for the 2026 edition of The Nigeria Prize for Literature. Sponsored by Nigeria LNG (NLNG), the annual contest, now in its 22nd year and carrying a life-changing grand prize of \$100,000, stands unarguably as Africa's biggest and most prestigious literary honour.

Announcing the longlist, the Chairman of the Advisory Board for the Prize, Professor Akachi Adimora-Ezeigbo, described the milestone as a pivotal phase in the competition that reflects the extraordinary quality, technical depth, and sheer creative diversity of contemporary African poetry. The 2026 cycle, which rotates back to the poetry genre, brings together a formidable mix of celebrated literary veterans and vibrant modern voices.

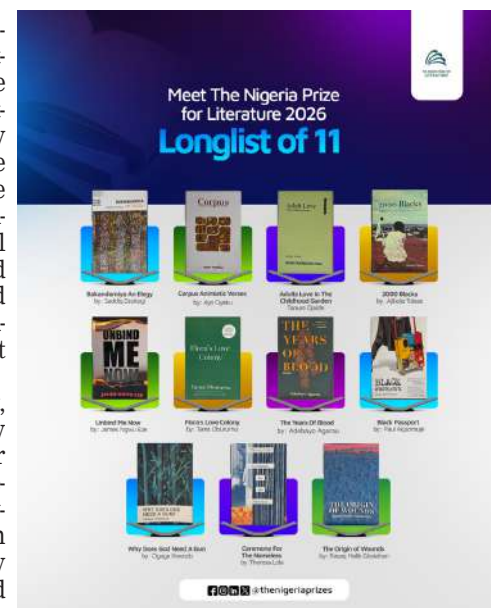
The 11 longlisted titles, arranged in alphabetical order, are Adult Love by Tanure Ojaide, Bakandimiya by Saddiq Dzukogi, Black Passport by Paul Akpomuje, 2000 Blacks by Ajibola Tolase, Ceremony for The Nameless by Theresa Lola, Corpus: Animistic Verses by Ayo Oyeku, Floral's Love Colony by Tares Oburumu, The Origin of Wounds by Malik Gbolahan, The Years of Blood by Adebayo Agarau, Unbind Me Now by James Ugwu Eze, and Why Does God Need a Gun by Ogaga Ifowodo.

According to Professor Adimora-Ezeigbo, the selected collections vividly demonstrate the remarkable capacity of poetic language to illuminate the human experience through thoughtful reflection, cultural memory, and artistic innovation. She observed that many of the longlisted works revisit history while interrogating dominant narratives, exposing the subtle and overforces that shape collective identities and social relations across generations. Despite their varied thematic focuses, the Advisory Board noted that the books share

a profound commitment to exploring human resilience, individual endurance, and community survival in the face of violence, oppression, and social fragmentation.

Commending the panel of judges for their rigorous evaluation, Professor Adimora-Ezeigbo highlighted the impressive range of artistic techniques displayed across the longlist, ranging from lyrical intensity and symbolic depth to allegorical modes that draw heavily on folklore, oral traditions, and modern realities. She emphasised that the fluid, evocative, and aesthetically refined language of these collections serves to challenge established perspectives while giving a resonant voice to both private and collective experiences.

With the 11-title longlist now officially public, the race moves into its next crucial phase. The judging panel will undertake a closer reading of each work, evaluating language, form, originality, and lasting literary value before pruning the list down to a shortlist of three contenders in August. The ultimate winner of the \$100,000 prize will be announced in October, continuing NLNG's enduring commitment to literary excellence, intellectual vigour, and the promotion of a robust reading culture across the continent.



If anyone still doubts the global, unstoppable momentum of contemporary African music, Asake has just delivered a masterclass in artistic grandeur that should permanently silence the sceptics.

In a monumental moment for the

History In High-Definition: Asake, Spotify Debut Groundbreaking 'M\$NEY' Concert Film

Afrobeats ecosystem, the Nigerian superstar has officially teamed up with streaming giant Spotify to drop Asake -M\$NEY Live in London (Spotify Live). The project is not merely another live recording; it represents a historic milestone as the first full-length live album performance film ever released by Spotify globally.

Captured live at London's iconic Theatre Royal Drury Lane—marking the very first time an Afrobeats artist has headlined a venue of such heritage and stature—the concert film documents an intimate, one-night-only performance of his chart-topping album, M\$NEY.

For the invite-only spectacle, close to 2,000 privileged fans and top Spotify listeners flooded the historic West End venue. Adhering to a strict black-tie

dress code, the audience turned up in immaculate, high-fashion fits, setting the stage for an evening that bridged West African street culture with classical British opulence.

Ditching standard backing tracks, Asake elevated his performance into a grand orchestral movement. Backed by a full live orchestra, a powerful 40-person choir, and the renowned live band The Composers, the artist delivered a soul-stirring rendition of the M\$NEY tracklist.

In addition to performing hits from the May 2026 project live for the first time since its release, Asake treated the audience to an unexpected gift: the live debut of four brand-new, unreleased tracks—a secret appetiser ahead of his upcoming global tour later this year.

"This performance was a reflection

of everything M\$NEY represents: gratitude, growth, my spiritual and creative journey all in one," said Asake.

Reflecting on the landmark evening, Asake shared:

"This performance was a reflection of everything M\$NEY represents: gratitude, growth, my spiritual and creative journey all in one. Everything flows from a place of gratitude to God and every moment that's shaped me, and I hope that comes through. M\$NEY was always meant to travel when you feel good music, you feel it in your chest. That's what I wanted this album to be. Something that crosses every border."

The release of M\$NEY reaffirmed Asake's standing as one of the world's premier digital hitmakers. A bold meditation on prosperity, spirituality, and ambition, the album surged to the top

of streaming charts in over 19 countries, including Nigeria, while peaking at an impressive No. 8 in the United States. The release propelled him to No. 15 on Kworl's Global Digital Artist rankings alongside the biggest names in the international music industry.

Spotify celebrated the launch of the concert film with an exclusive premiere screening at its newly opened Listening Lounge in central London. The film joins Spotify's elite lineup of exclusive live performance content, which recently featured global heavyweights like Bad Bunny in Tokyo and Olivia Rodrigo in Barcelona.

Both the concert film and the companion audio-only live album, Asake -M\$NEY Live in London (Spotify Live), are now available to stream exclusively on Spotify.

Snapshots

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Chadwick Boseman's Family Alleges Widow Kept Estate Funds To Herself

Chadwick Boseman's brothers are accusing his widow of withholding assets from the late actor's estate. Derrick and Kevin Boseman filed a petition in Los Angeles Superior Court on behalf of their parents, against Taylor Simone Ledward, claiming she has failed to distribute the 'Black Panther' star's estate after he died without a will.

Ledward inherited 50% of the estate, while Boseman's parents – Leroy and Carolyn Boseman – each inherited 25%, according to the petition. But Ledward, acting as the estate's administrator, has yet to fully distribute it, "willfully defying a clear directive from this Court."

The brothers also accuse Ledward of a "lack of transparency," which they said "creates the appearance that she is concealing assets" from his family.

Ledward quietly married the actor shortly before his death in August 2020, but the couple had been dating since 2015. The pair did not share any children.

The brothers said in the filing that Ledward's alleged misconduct has impacted the family,

denying them "long overdue closure or participation in decision-making regarding matters" in Boseman's estate and financial security at a "vulnerable age."

"Imagine flipping through the channels and stumbling on a film starring your deceased son or brother, knowing that someone you do not know or trust is profiting from his image without your input or consent," they said, per the petition.

Derrick and Kevin Boseman requested the court order Ledward to "show cause for why she should not be held in contempt for disobeying the Court's order" and suspend her role as administrator pending her permanent removal, putting Jason Rubin, a forensic accountant, in her place to investigate the "mismanagement."

The filing is the latest in a string of high-profile disputes over celebrity estates. Malcolm-Jamal Warner's widow recently challenged the late actor's trust, arguing it failed to provide adequate support for her and their 9-year-old daughter.



Lillian Afegbai Celebrates One Year Of 'To Kill A Monkey'

One year after award-winning crime series, 'To Kill A Monkey', started streaming, one of its lead actresses, Lillian Afegbai, has sent felicitations to the cast and crew of the drama.

In a post on her Instagram page, the actress, who plays the domineering Idia in the series, described 'To Kill A Monkey' as one of those projects that stays with one in the little things, the memories, friendships, lessons, the person they become because of them.

"Some projects come and go, but some become a part of your story forever. They shape you, challenge you, and leave a mark that time can never erase.

"It wasn't just a series; it was a movement. It sparked conversations, touched hearts, and reminded us why we do what we do. It gave us more than great scenes and unforgettable moments; it gave us a family. A group of people who laughed together, struggled

together, celebrated together, and created something we'll always be proud of," she wrote.

She further thanked the cast and crew of the series for showing up every day with passion, commitment, and heart.

"Working alongside all of you was an honour, and I'll forever be grateful that our paths crossed on this journey. What we created together will always be special to me. To everyone who watched, streamed, shared, recommended, talked about it, or supported us in any way, thank you. You gave this story a life far beyond our screens, and that kind of love is something we'll never take for granted.

"Happy one-year anniversary to all of us. Here's to the memories we've made, the impact this story continues to have, and the legacy it has become. May it continue to find new audiences and remind people why stories matter," she added.

Please Don't Let Me Die, Ngozi Nwosu Appeals To Fans

Veteran actress, Ngozi Nwosu, has appealed to her fans to come to her aid as she battles an undisclosed illness. In a post on her Instagram page, the actress, 61, said that she can no longer keep quiet about her predicament as she is in urgent need of life-saving surgeries.

Although she did not disclose the nature of her illness, Nwosu said that she needs to undergo three surgeries, which would amount to N30 million in hospital bills.

"My people, my fans, and my family, I know that you've not seen me in circulation for some time. I've been hospitalised now for three weeks. Please, the thing has gone beyond my control. I need your help. Don't let me die. I know that you people

will never forsake me. And I know that God will always see me through. But I'm begging you, my fans and family, don't let me die.

"I am going through a lot of pain. I have like three surgeries to go through. Please don't let me die. If there's anything you want to do for me, please contact my management. Thank you, God bless you. Sickness will never be anybody's portion in Jesus name," she said in the video.

She also urged well-meaning Nigerians who would like to donate to her cause to contact her legal representatives or management for more details.

"Please don't scroll past. Share this post and support if you can. God bless you and may you and yours never experience this affliction," she said.



How I Shut Down A Business I Spent Over A Billion Naira Starting — Ubi Franklin



Nigerian businessman and founder of the now defunct Made Mem Music Group, Ubi Franklin has spoken about losing over N1 billion on a failed venture. In the latest episode of his talk, 'Talks With Ubi Franklin', Franklin revealed that he started Instant Apartments, an instant pick-up app to help people with their laundry.

According to him, the platform was designed as a logistics platform for laundry where they go to people's houses, pick up their laundry and drop it off with their laundry outfit.

"It was a seamless business. We had a lot of laundry houses that had registered on the platform between Lagos and Abuja. The business was going fine. I was advised to get trip insurance, so I set up trip insurance for my business. Trip insurance means that if my logistics people come to your house to pick up your clothes, if anything happens on the road, we had insured it.

"What was left was for the laundry houses to insure the clothes. Some of them had insured their machines, but they had not insured people's clothes.

Well, we were doing all of these things; we didn't know that some laundry companies, especially the big ones, were not insured.

"Some of the people who came to join us were celebrities who had very expensive clothes. What happened? The laundry started spoiling people's clothes. And now, because I didn't want people to start calling us out for spoiling their clothes and all of that, I had to pay. One of the people that I had to refund money for his clothes was 2Face Idibia," he said.

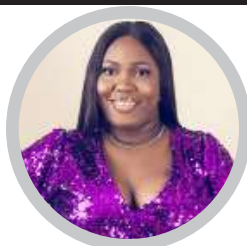
Speaking further, he said that in the space of three months, he

paid off almost N50 million in damaged clothes.

"I had to wake up one day. I called a meeting after about one year in business and told my staff that we were going to shut down the company. Luckily, at that time, I started Instant Apartment.

"Instant Apartment seemed more straightforward, and revenues were coming in. I advertised on Big Brother. Every time Big Brother aired our ads, we were making a lot of money. People who come on our platform monthly, we're doing about N300m to N400m on our platform, because people were booking apartments from us," he added.

StyleMania



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Regal Heritage Meets Modern Grandeur: Lai Labode Couture Debuts at Temple Muse

Lagos has long been the undisputed pulse of African fashion, a city where style is not merely worn, it is performed, celebrated, and worn like a badge of cultural honour. Yesterday, July 24, the high-fashion landscape expanded its borders once again as luxury fashion house, Lai Labode Couture makes its official, highly anticipated debut in an exclusive soirée at Temple Muse, Victoria Island.

Set against the refined backdrop of Temple Muse, Lagos' premier luxury concept store known for curating the absolute finest in African art, design, and couture, the launch unveils the brand's maiden collection to a select audience of fashion connoisseurs, stylists, industry heavyweights, and high-society tastemakers.

At the heart of Lai Labode Couture's identity is an un-

apologetic ode to African royalty. The debut collection bridges centuries of indigenous majesty with the sharp, technical discipline of contemporary haute couture. Every garment tells a story of ancestral grandeur reimagined for the modern, discerning wardrobe.

"The collection bridges centuries of indigenous majesty with the sharp, technical discipline of contemporary haute couture."

Beyond the aesthetic allure, Lai Labode Couture arrives at a time when the global fashion industry is looking toward Africa not just for inspiration, but for leadership in sustainable luxury and bespoke craftsmanship. By anchoring its creative vision in local heritage while maintaining international finishing standards, the brand sets out to build a lasting legacy in African high fashion.



NaijaEverything Founder Osinuga Oriola Unveils Expansion Plans



Nigerian digital entrepreneur and influencer Osinuga Oriola, Founder and CEO of NaijaEverything, is set to expand his platform to meet growing demand for authentic youth-focused content and creative entrepreneurship in Nigeria.

With a combined audience of over 1 million followers on Instagram, a business-verified TikTok channel, and a rapidly growing Snapchat presence

with Spotlight content that generated over 80 million views in a single month, Oriola has positioned NaijaEverything as one of the country's most dynamic digital media brands.

What began in 2013 as a self-built blog has evolved into a multi-platform media brand covering music, fashion, comedy, and celebrity news.

"A lot of people didn't take the movement seriously at the time, even

people close to me. In 2015, many didn't understand the internet yet. But with perseverance, I was able to take NaijaEverything to a greater height.

"Authenticity is non-negotiable. I built NaijaEverything because I genuinely loved Nigerian culture. Trends come and go, but I ask if it fits our voice first," he said.

According to Oriola, one key growth driver of the platform has been his

work as a top Snapchat lens creator with over 250,000 followers. His viral lens that puts users in native Nigerian attire became a fan favourite.

"I went into lens creation to make people happy. My filters either make people happy or beautify them. I listen to the people. I know what they are enthusiastic about and feed them content that blends with their energy," he stated.

Beyond digital media, Oriola releases music "just for fun and at random times," often spotlighting youth struggling to get out of the slums — a theme he says most Nigerians can relate to.

As an influencer, he adds: "Brands now know of someone they can trust to take their product to the next level, someone with 100% credibility."

Looking ahead, Oriola aims to grow NaijaEverything into a recognised name in African entertainment media.

"In five years, I want NaijaEverything to be more than a page for gist. I want original content, bigger collaborations, and our own shows. I also want to spotlight rising talent. You can start from nothing, stay consistent, and build something real," he said.



Extravagant Praise 2026: Over 5,000 Worshippers Expected As Annual Gospel Concert Takes Centre Stage In Yaba

No fewer than 5,000 worshippers from across various Christian denominations are expected to gather at St. Dominic's Catholic Church in Yaba, Lagos, on Friday, August 14, 2026, for this year's edition of the annual Extravagant Praise gospel concert.

Organisers disclosed during a press briefing in Lagos that the all-night worship experience, themed "Love Letter of Thanksgiving to God," is designed as an ecumenical movement focused on spiritual renewal, soul-winning, national unity, and uninhibited praise.

Speaking on behalf of the Chief Host, Rev. Fr. Alexius Agba, OP, the Associate Director, Rev. Fr. Raphael Amen, OP, described the annual gathering as a vital "channel of grace" that leverages sacred music to bridge denominational divides and draw people closer to God.

"The programme is ecumenical in nature and aimed at transforming lives beyond the Catholic Church," Fr. Amen stated. "It serves as a medium of preaching, discovering and nurturing young musical talents, and building people who will, in turn, go out to build others."

The event, which is scheduled to commence at 8:00 p.m. and run until dawn, will feature an array of gospel ministers, choral groups, and worship leaders.

Addressing journalists on the technical and logistical preparations, the Concert Executive Director, Dr. Peter Egbumokei, emphasised that the privately funded initiative requires months of rigorous planning, security coordination, and resource mobilisation.

Egbumokei noted that ministers for the concert were intentionally selected based on spiritual alignment and message rather than social media popularity or commercial appeal.

"We are not putting up performances; we are ministering," Egbumokei explained. "Our focus is not on personalities, but on God. The Extravagant Praise Concert brings together Catholics, Protestants, Anglicans, members of the Redeemed Christian Church of God, and believers from all walks of life to lift one voice in thanksgiving."

Highlighting lessons learned from previous editions, including crowd control, power management, and stage safety, Egbumokei assured attendees that security measures have been significantly reinforced in active partnership with relevant law enforcement agencies. He added that environmental impact and the comfort of neighbouring residents in the Yaba community have been factored into the event layout.

For worshippers unable to attend in person, the organisers confirmed that the entire night of praise will be broadcast live via YouTube and other digital channels in partnership with major media organisations, allowing global audiences to participate in real time.

"The vision is to build faith, encourage genuine thanksgiving rooted in liturgical tradition and cultural expression, and bring people into a deeper relationship with God," Egbumokei concluded. "We are careful not to be driven by popular culture, but by our Christian mandate."

Entertainment Xtra

Next Afrobeats Star Season 2: N225 Million Recording Contract Up For Grabs As MTN, Ultima Studios, ONErpm Raise Stakes

If you needed any more proof that Afrobeats is currently the most potent cultural export coming out of the African continent, MTN Nigeria, premier entertainment outfit Ultima Studios, and ONErpm have just upped the ante. In a high-powered media unveiling held on Saturday in Lagos, the organisers officially declared doors open for Season 2 of the Next Afrobeats Star (NAS) talent competition, unveiling incentives that are nothing short of life-changing.

For starters, the stakes have experienced a massive upgrade. The grand prize for the overall winner has been bumped from N150 million up to an eye-watering N225 million recording deal, complete with a brand-new Mercedes-Benz SUV to navigate the celebrity lifestyle in style. Recognising that real talent deserves real backing across the board, the organisers also revealed that the first, second, and third runners-up will earn recording deals valued at N100 million, N75 million, and N50 million respectively.

Speaking at the unveiling, the General Manager of Brand and Communications at MTN Nigeria, Ms. Emamoke Ogoro, emphasised that Next Afrobeats Star is intentionally designed to bridge the gap between raw talent and sustainable careers by providing emerging artistes with direct access to industry opportunities. Unlike conventional talent shows where contestants survive by performing existing



songs, participants on Next Afrobeats Star are required to create and perform strictly original music, helping them build lasting professional careers beyond the competition.

To turn these live performances into immediate commercial assets, Ogoro explained that all contestants' songs performed during the television broadcasts will be released immediately on major global streaming platforms, eliminating the long, frustrating

wait between television exposure and streaming revenue. In a move aimed at expanding access nationwide, six contestants drawn directly from MTN's grassroots talent discovery platform, alongside a wildcard entrant, will join the main competition for the first time. Ogoro noted that applications will remain open until August 17, urging aspiring musicians to take advantage of the platform to launch professional careers.

Unpacking the opera-

tional logistics, the Head of Content and Development at Ultima Studios, Richard Oluwabori, outlined the road to the main stage. He explained that entries can be submitted physically during regional auditions or online through the competition website using downloadable instrumentals. To qualify, contestants must be Nigerian citizens who are at least 18 years old, possess strong musical talent, and be willing to perform before live audiences.

The regional audition train will sweep across four major music hubs, kicking off in Lagos from August 15 to August 17, before moving to Benin from August 21 to August 23. From there, the team will proceed to Jos for auditions holding from August 28 to August 30, before wrapping up the regional search in Uyo from September 4 to September 6.

From the thousands of expected applicants, the best 200 contestants will advance to perform before a formida-

ble judging panel. Veteran music executive Obi Asika and legendary producer ID Cabasa return to the judging seats, joined this season by hitmaking producer Masterkraft and new addition Big Bird, also known as Ragee. Expressing strong confidence in the upcoming cycle, Oluwabori noted that the second edition is poised to attract significantly more entries and further deepen commercial opportunities for emerging Afrobeats talent across Nigeria.

Kasope Releases 'Bamise': A Prayer Song

Nigerian-British singer, songwriter and recording artiste Kasopefoluwa Sote, well known as Kasope, has unveiled his new single, "Bámisé (Help Me)". It is a heartfelt prayer of surrender, faith and complete dependence on God for anyone facing uncertainty, grief or the overwhelming challenges of life.

Produced by the acclaimed Olaitan Dada, whose credits include collaborations with Cobhams Asuquo, Dare Art-Alade, Mike Abdul, Monique, Onos, Solá Allyson, BBO, EmmaOMG, and Waje, Bámisé beautifully blends

soulful worship, Yoruba lyrics and the influence of soft rock into this contemporary gospel production. Bámisé triggers a powerful worship experience that reminds listeners that God's help is never out of reach.

A founding member of former gospel group 'Made In Heaven' consisting of Lumynors O'ven (now known as Waju) and Olu-sayo, Kasope continues to establish himself as one of the emerging voices in contemporary gospel music. His lyrics reflect lived experiences, faith and an unwavering conviction that even in life's darkest

moments, God remains faithful.

According to Kasope "I had been mandated in 2019 to teach the choir a new song. I had nothing prepared, but just before choir rehearsal after a Sunday service, while playing the keyboard, the chorus of 'Bámisé' came to me. The choir embraced it, and we ministered it the following Sunday. However, the verses came years later, which were shaped by profound personal experiences rooted in tragedies, health challenges and seasons of uncertainty. I cried to God for help because I knew He

could solve the problems. Thus, Bamise became a prayer song".

Written in first-person, Bámisé invites listeners to make its words their own, whether they are facing loss, waiting for breakthrough, seeking healing, or simply longing for God's direction. The song serves as a reminder that no situation is beyond His power, and no sincere prayer goes unheard. As a multidisciplinary creative, Kasope remains passionate about creating meaningful works that inspire faith, bring hope, encourage healing, and point people towards God.



Young Laureates



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What's up Laureates? We will be continuing our story. I believe you will want to know what happened to the greedy spider. To find out, please check the continuation of the story below. We will also be having some games and poems to make your day. Enjoy.

STORY

Continues from last Edition

The Greedy Spider (2)



The old tortoise's eyes widened in terror.

"These are the feathers of the Time Bird."

Spider's legs nearly collapsed.

"The Time Bird?" he whispered.

The tortoise nodded slowly.

"It collects debts for Time. One feather for each night before payment is demanded."

Spider laughed nervously.

"Payment? I only borrowed one day."

The old tortoise lowered his voice.

"No one borrows from Time. You stole from it."

Spider hurried home, but sleep abandoned him.

Every night the knocking returned.

Four feathers.

Five feathers.

Six.

And then, on the seventh night, the knocking stopped.

Silence filled the darkness.

Relieved, Spider smiled.

"Perhaps it has forgotten me."

Then a voice spoke from behind him.

"No debt is forgotten."

Spider turned.

Standing inside his house was a gigantic bird with silver feathers and eyes that shone like stars.

Its wings touched the roof.

Its beak gleamed like polished ivory.

Spider screamed.

"What do you want?"

The Time Bird stared at him.

"What belongs to me."

Spider threw bags of cowries before it.

"Take these!"

The bird remained still.

He offered his yams.

His land.

His house.

Everything.

The bird did not move.

Finally, trembling, Spider asked,

"What must I give?"

The Time Bird opened its wings.

"The day you stole."

Spider sighed with relief.

"Take it, then."

But the bird's eyes burned brighter.

"The day has already been spent."

Spider's smile vanished.

"Then... what do you mean?"

"The future you stole cannot be returned. A day must replace a day."

Cold fear gripped Spider.

"What day?"

The bird answered with terrible calm.

"One day from your life."

Spider's body froze.

"No!"

But Time had already decided.

The next morning, the animals came to visit the wealthy Spider.

They found his treasures untouched.

His food untouched.

His doors wide open.

But Spider himself had become old and weak overnight.

His hair had turned white.

His legs trembled.

And in his eyes lived the sorrow of one who had learned too late.

From that day forward, Spider spent his remaining years helping others and giving away his riches.

Whenever young creatures complained that success came too slowly, Spider would raise a shaking finger and say,

"Patience is cheaper than greed. For Time gives freely to those who wait, but it always collects from those who steal."

And to this day, whenever mysterious knocks are heard in the night, the elders say that the Time Bird is still flying through the world, searching for those who believe they can take tomorrow without paying for it.

MORAL LESSON:

Greed may bring quick rewards, but every dishonest gain carries a hidden cost. Time is precious, and those who seek shortcuts often discover that the price is far greater than they imagined.

Concluded



Lyrics Gimme Dat Ting

By Davido feat. NO11

(It's JJAY, baby)

Hee (Hee)

Hee (Hee)

'Cause I'm way too high, Omo (omo)

Me, I wanna feel that vibe, omo

I can't lie, I'm high, omo (omo)

Can you tell me what you want?

Don't lie, omo (Gege)

Me, I can't lie, I'm faded

Wón ní wón wá mi, baby

I get two vibes wey dey drive me

crazy (Baddest)

I just touch down ABJ lane

I don touch down ABJ fresh, uh

Can you tell me what you want?

I'ma buy you that thing

Anything you want, I'ma buy

you that thing

If you want me, better give me

that thing

Hee, hee, hee, hee (That thing)

Hee (Gimme that thing), hee, hee,

hee

Gimme that thing

Uh, better give me that thing

Mummy said, "Make sure it's not

illuminati"

Labels wanna give me signing

But first things first, better

gimme that thing

They just called me to do a book-

ing

But first things first, better

gimme that thing

That thing, gimme that thing

That thing, gimme that thing

That thing, gimme that thing,

gimme that thing

Let's work, better gimme that

thing

Fine shit, gimme that— (Woah)

Sé na Nepo? She's a lil' bougie

Know your papa no get money

pass me (Mhm)

Call me "Daddy", where's your

home training?

Nílè, when you see Alhaji

I carry racks, and you came with

body

Make we J.E.K., John Kennedy

My shima don get adrenaline

She just needs drip and a cup of

syrup (Cup of syrup)

She rockin' Casami', she needs a

Hero' (Hey)

So far, from my point of view

Fill me up like say na Cheeto

You never see anything, omoge-

ge (What?)

The balling I do fit to give them

seizure

Fine shit, baby, bring your body

'pon me

Tell the promoter make the mon-

ey complete

Ginger me, fuck you, pay me

Always active, baby, never lazy

YKB, baby, sé you no be?

Tell me say you don bo

Ginger me, fuck you, pay me

Always active, baby, never lazy

YKB, baby, sé you no bo? (Hee)

'Cause I'm way too high, omo

Poem And Game

VACATION RESOLUTION

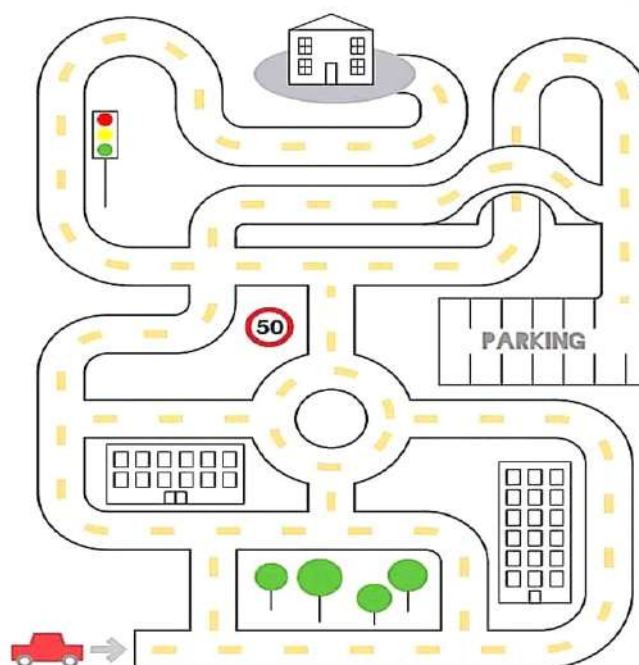
by Lenore Hetrick

I'm not getting up tomorrow!
Though I hear my mother call,
"Waffles and honey for breakfast!"
I'll turn my face tot he wall.
I'm not getting up though my friends come
Yelling, "We're off to the river!"
I'll just close my eyes and sleep
Without a regretful shiver.

The first day of vacation!
Oh grand and glorious feeling!
The solid bed beneath me,
Above, the dear old ceiling!
And I won't get up, I tell you,
To dine with a golden cup.
Not even if the President calls -
Still I won't get up.



THE ROAD HOME MAZE



FIND YOUR WAY HOME!

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Arts | Culture | Reviews

SPAN On The Road Initiative Climaxes With Talent Showcase In Lagos

The Society for the Performing Arts in Nigeria (SPAN), on Tuesday July 14, 2026, had a showcase of talented Nigerian youth who successfully underwent trainings in the pilot programme tagged SPAN on the Road (SOTR). The six-month empowerment programme came to a climax with a showcase event held at the SPAN Creative Hub, 47 Bourdillon Road, Ikoyi, Lagos.

Consisting of youth from different backgrounds, the showcase was a remarkable evening of colorful, breathtaking and artistic performances by the trainees who saw the opportunity to show off their dance skills acquired in the course of the six months training. SPAN on the Road took place at three different venues – The flagship Lagos center, Omojuwa-Ketu and in Maiduguri, Borno State.

In the opening remarks, SPAN Chief Operating Officer Remi Jemitola expressed deep gratitude to Ford Foundation who funded the project. Jemitola said what Ford Foundation did was to support the vision of SPAN founder and CEO Sarah Boulos who holds investing in the underserved close to heart. She lauded the visionary support of Ford Foundation while noting that the initiative was able to transition successfully from a bold blueprint into a thriving reality.

"The Youths of Nigeria are grateful," Jemitola started. "What Ford Foundation did for us was to allow us spread our tentacles up to Maiduguri. We were in the North, right here and at Omojuwa-Ketu, at the back of Mile 12 market. We

couldn't have done this without Ford Foundation, our esteemed Board Members, instructors and director of dance. She concluded.

Dr. Chichi Aniagolu, Ford Foundation Regional Director, West Africa, said it was a thing of joy to have watched the performances of the trainees. "I mean, you know, it's not all the time that things that you fund turn out the way you want. But, I think that this has turned out really beautifully. Of course, you know, these are young people, they still need training and the rest of it. But for what they put out today, they've done amazingly well and I'm very proud."

Furthermore, Aniagolu spoke about the importance of the partnership with SPAN in providing dance and music classes for young people especially young people in underserved communities. Vulnerable young people. She said it was because Ford Foundation considers music and dance as universal instruments for inspiring young people in attaining their dreams.

"If we look at Nigeria, the music industry and the film industry have done the very proudly. Yet, we still do not have a real organized opportunity in terms of funding to provide resources to be able to bring about the next generation of artists or filmmakers."

Aniagolu revealed that when SPAN came to them to ask for funds, they immediately reckoned it was a gap they would be happy to fill especially when SPAN wanted to go to underserved communities, even in conflict zones.

World Folklore Day 2026: Farimoyo Reimagines African Oral Storytelling For A New Generation

NGOZI UMA

As the world prepares to celebrate World Folklore Day 2026 in August, producer and cultural curator Oluwaseun Farimoyo stands out as one of the creative voices redefining how African folklore is preserved and experienced by younger generations.

For centuries, folklore has remained one of Africa's oldest and most effective ways of passing down history, values and cultural identity through stories. However, as urbanisation and digital culture continue to reshape society, traditional oral storytelling faces the risk of fading into the background. Farimoyo's work offers a refreshing response to this challenge by transforming ancient storytelling traditions into engaging contemporary performance experiences.

Her most notable project, Moonlight Tales: Immersive Oral Storytelling Festival, staged in Lagos in 2024, demonstrated how folklore can remain relevant in today's creative landscape. Inspired by the African tradition of communal storytelling under the moonlight, the festival blended spoken word, theatre, live music, movement and audience participation into a rich cultural experience.

Rather than presenting storytelling as a passive activity, Moonlight Tales invited audiences to become active participants. The performances explored themes of identity, memory, heritage and



Farimoyo

community, creating an emotional connection between performers and audiences while celebrating Africa's rich oral traditions.

As the festival's producer and curator, Farimoyo developed its artistic vision, supervised the curation process and managed its production. She successfully brought together storytellers, musicians and performance artists whose works reflected diverse African cultures and narratives. The result was a multidisciplinary performance that preserved indigenous stories while presenting them in creative forms that appealed to modern audiences.

The production's greatest strength lies in its ability to bridge the gap between ancestral oral histories and contemporary urban youths. By re-contextualising traditional storytelling within live performance, Moonlight

Tales proved that folklore is not merely a historical relic but a living cultural practice capable of inspiring dialogue, preserving intangible heritage and encouraging creative expression.

Viewed through a critical lens, the festival achieved much of what it set out to accomplish. It revived African oral storytelling without losing its authenticity while making it accessible to younger generations. Although Farimoyo does not come from a traditional theatre training background, her work demonstrates that artistic excellence is ultimately measured by the quality of creative output rather than conventional pathways into the profession.

Farimoyo combines her background in economics and cultural management to shape socially impactful creative projects. She founded Lead Cultural Production in 2020 and serves as its Artistic Director. Through the organisation, she uses the arts to amplify the voices of marginalised and underrepresented communities across Nigeria, Zambia and the United Kingdom.

Her productions are known for creating emotionally powerful live experiences that challenge colonial narratives while giving visibility to economically disadvantaged communities. Whether staging experimental drama in historical gardens, designing grassroots creative awards in Makoko, or developing community-centred

performances across Africa and Europe, Farimoyo consistently blends social realities with artistic innovation.

Beyond Moonlight Tales, her growing body of work includes Black History Month: The Unseen Narrative in the United Kingdom in 2025, A Day in Colonial Garden staged in both the UK and Nigeria, The Makoko Creative Talent Awards in Lagos, and The Marketplace Monologues in Lusaka, Zambia. Together, these projects reflect a clear commitment to preserving culture while using performance as a tool for education, inclusion and social change.

Academically, Farimoyo holds a Bachelor's degree in Economics from Babcock University, a Master's degree in Economics from the University of Lagos, and a Master's degree in Financial Management from Sheffield Hallam University, 2023; and Continuous Professional Development: Specialized course-work in Socially Engaged Theatre, Site-Specific Curation, and Creative Producing.

As conversations around cultural preservation take centre stage during World Folklore Day 2026, Moonlight Tales serves as a compelling example of how African oral traditions can thrive in the modern era. Through imagination, thoughtful curation and artistic innovation, Oluwaseun Farimoyo has shown that folklore is not simply a story of the past, but a living tradition with the power to shape the future.

NCC DG Bags Honorary Fellowship Of National Labour Institute

NGOZI UMA

The Director-General of the Nigerian Copyright Commission (NCC), Dr. John Asein, has been conferred with the Honorary Fellowship of the National Labour Institute (FNLI) in recognition of his contributions to copyright administration, workers' welfare and the promotion of harmonious labour-management relations in Nigeria.

The investiture ceremony took place on Wednesday at the Gama-iel Onosode Hall, University of Ibadan International Conference Centre, Ibadan, where labour leaders, academics, stakeholders in the creative industry and representatives of professional bodies gathered to celebrate the NCC boss.

The fellowship was awarded in recognition of Dr. Asein's efforts in repositioning copyright as a strategic tool for economic growth and the development of Nigeria's creative and knowledge economy. The honour also acknowledged his commitment to workers' rights, staff welfare, decent work prac-

es and institutional reforms at the Nigerian Copyright Commission.

Speaking at the ceremony, the Director-General and Chief Executive Officer of the Michael Imoudu National Institute for Labour Studies (MINILS), Ilorin, represented by Comrade Issa Aremu, MNI, NPOM, described Dr. Asein as a public servant whose leadership has transformed workplace relations and strengthened institutional capacity.

Aremu recalled that during MINILS' 40th anniversary celebration on May 9, 2023, the institute recognised 126 distinguished Nigerians as Fellows of the National Labour Institute, including governors, vice-chancellors, judges, lawyers, diplomats, business leaders and labour activists. He said Dr. Asein's induction follows that tradition of recognising individuals who have made significant contributions to labour development and national progress.

According to him, Dr. Asein has demonstrated exceptional commitment to workers by respecting their right to unionise, sponsoring

labour education programmes organised by MINILS, strengthening labour-management relations, introducing health and safety policies, implementing a 60 per cent Job-Specific Allowance, promoting gender-friendly and non-discriminatory workplace practices, conducting timely promotion exercises and providing modern working tools to improve staff productivity. He also commended the provision of a staff bus to ease official transportation for workers at the Commission's headquarters.

"These are not mere administrative actions; they are transformative interventions that uplift workers, strengthen institutions and advance the cause of decent work in Nigeria," Aremu said as he congratulated the NCC Director-General and urged him to continue promoting labour dignity, industrial harmony and national development.

Responding, Dr. Asein expressed appreciation to the Governing Council, management and staff of MINILS for the honour, describing the fellowship as one of

the most meaningful recognitions of his public service career.

"I am deeply honoured to accept the conferment of the Honorary Fellowship of the National Labour Institute. I receive this honour with profound gratitude and humility," he said.

He noted that although the fellowship was conferred on him personally, he accepted it on behalf of the management, staff and organised labour unions at the Nigerian Copyright Commission, stressing that the achievements recorded by the Commission were products of teamwork, mutual trust and shared commitment.

Dr. Asein recalled that upon assuming office, he challenged members of staff to embrace the vision of "Changing the Copyright Narrative for Wealth Creation," explaining that the vision goes beyond strengthening copyright protection and enforcement to building a professional institution founded on integrity, competence, teamwork and excellence in service delivery.

According to him, sustainable

institutional growth depends on investing in people through continuous training and improved welfare. He disclosed that the Commission partnered with MINILS to organise specialised training for officers on Grade Levels 13 and 14 on organisational ideals and workplace collaboration, while officers on Grade Levels 7 to 12 also received training on work ethics and values for effective service delivery.

He added that, in collaboration with the Administrative Staff College of Nigeria (ASCON), the Commission organised a strategic leadership programme for officers on Grade Levels 15 to 17, focusing on strategic leadership, digital transformation and effective copyright enforcement in a knowledge-driven economy.

Dr. Asein said the Commission has also sustained efforts to improve workplace safety, provide modern working tools, ensure timely promotions, strengthen labour-management relations and promote inclusive workplace policies that guarantee equal opportunities for all employees.

He noted that these initiatives align with President Bola Ahmed Tinubu's Renewed Hope Agenda, particularly its emphasis on strengthening public institutions, investing in human capital and improving service delivery.

The NCC Director-General thanked the Attorney-General of the Federation and Minister of Justice, the Commission's Governing Board, management, staff, organised labour representatives and stakeholders for their support, which he said had contributed immensely to the Commission's achievements.

The ceremony also featured goodwill messages from the Nigerian Publishers Association, Association of Nigerian Authors, the Intellectual Property and Technology Law Club (IPTLC), the University of Ibadan and other stakeholders.

In her goodwill message, IPTLC President Anna Odiachi described the fellowship as a fitting recognition of Dr. Asein's outstanding career in scholarship, visionary leadership and public service. She

Feature

Bukar Usman: Nigeria Needs Local Police, Not Necessarily State Police

Security expert Bukar Usman says Nigeria needs local police built on community knowledge rather than focusing exclusively on state police structures.



Some members of the First Panel of discussants: L-R: Dr. Reuben Abati, Arise News Morning Show Co-anchor; His Excellency Dauda Lawal, Governor of Zamfara State; Hon. Nenna Elendu-Ukeje, former Member of the House of Representatives; Gen. Lucky Irabor (rtd), former Chief of Defence Staff; Senator Adams Oshiomhole; His Excellency Peter Mbah, Governor of Enugu State; Dr. Bukar Usman, Historian, former Permanent Secretary in the Presidency and current President of the Nigerian Folklore Society (NFS) and... Hon. Benjamin Kalu, Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives and Senator Opeyemi Bamidele, Senate Leader who also served on the first panel were not captured in the photograph.

Historian, Bukar Usman, has urged Nigeria to prioritise the establishment of local police rooted in community knowledge rather than concentrating solely on the creation of state police, arguing that effective security depends more on local intelligence than on the level at which policing is organised.

Speaking at the ARISE NEWS Townhall on State Police, Usman said his advocacy for local policing was not new but dated back to his childhood experiences in Biu, Borno State, where he witnessed the effectiveness of the Native Authority Police, adding that decades of experience in security administration had also reinforced his conviction that community-based policing remains the most practical solution to Nigeria's security challenges. "I have been an advocate for local police, not necessarily state police. Local police."

Usman explained that his position was informed by both personal experience and years spent working in security administration, stressing that he had consistently championed local policing long before the current national

conversation on state police gathered momentum. "My position as an advocate for local police, not necessarily state police, dates back to my experience as a boy in the 1950s."

He argued that Nigeria's constitutional and legal framework already provides adequate structures for managing security at the national, state and local levels, suggesting that the real problem lies in implementation rather than institutional design. "The constitution is very clear as far as I'm concerned, there is nothing wrong with the structure in terms of security."

According to Usman, the critical questions are whether constitutionally recognised security bodies have been properly constituted, whether they meet regularly and whether they submit reports to the appropriate authorities as required. "My question is, are all these bodies properly set up? That is constituted. Do they meet regularly? Do they submit their reports to the authorities, higher authorities?"

He maintained that state governors already possess constitutional powers to direct police commissioners, pointing to provisions

in previous and current constitutions which, he said, clearly spell out those powers. "Go to section 213 and 215 of the old one and the new one. You will find all the powers required by a state governor to give instructions to the police commissioner and the police."

Usman noted that the constitution only limits such directives where they are unlawful, insisting that elected chief executives are already bound by their oath of office to act fairly. "The only provision is that, in case he is giving a not lawful direction, he says, police may say that, I think this needs to be cleared with the higher authority."

"State executives, or even chief executives, swear by oath when they take office that they will treat people, all manner of people, fairly."

While acknowledging concerns about political abuse of policing powers, he insisted that such risks stem from human conduct rather than constitutional deficiencies. "At the end of the day, it's a human factor."

Usman identified local knowledge as the missing element in Nigeria's security architecture, arguing that security personnel

cannot effectively operate in unfamiliar environments without community intelligence. "You cannot operate effectively without local knowledge."

He questioned why many communities had become ungoverned spaces despite the presence of people with intimate knowledge of the terrain. "Why should that arise when even ordinary hunters know in and out of whatever territory exists?"

Drawing an analogy, he said officers deployed into unfamiliar areas without local understanding would struggle to perform effectively.

"You take me to a riverine area. As you drop me into water, that is where I will sink. I don't know. I can't swim."

Usman argued that if the various security structures already provided for in the constitution functioned effectively, emerging threats could be identified and addressed before developing into national security crises. "If all these bodies set out in the Constitution are working properly, there is no reason or no way you cannot pick issues at the local level before they arise and become a problem at the national level."

He called for constitutional security bodies to be properly constituted, meet consistently and submit reports without political interference. "Let those bodies set out in the Constitution be properly constituted. Let them meet regularly. Let them submit reports regularly to the higher authorities without constraint to legal and political affiliation."

Although he reiterated his preference for local police, Usman said he had no objection if Nigeria eventually adopted state police, maintaining that success would ultimately depend on those entrusted with exercising the powers. "Mind you, I argue on local police, not necessarily state police. But if it comes to state police, no problem."

He concluded by insisting that misuse of policing powers would always remain a matter of individual conscience rather than constitutional design. "If you use or misuse a political instrument, it is you and your conscience. That is all."

Dr. Usman's most recent book "A Case for Local Police" Klamidas 2026, Pp. 1-211 was prompted by the resurgence of the debate on the subject matter.

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Social Diary

From 'Hot Money' To Household Wealth: Inside Anchoria's Power-Packed Investor Forum In Lagos

Victoria Island, Lagos, played host to a high-powered gathering of financial heavyweights, asset managers, and savvy investors as financial services group Anchoria hosted its landmark 'Quorum – Anchoria Investor Forum.' Conceived as an exclusive investor engagement platform, the forum was designed to pull back the curtain on hidden economic opportunities, deepen financial literacy, and chart a clear course for wealth preservation in an evolving market.

Unpacking the current state of the Nigerian economy, the Group Managing Director of Anchoria, Sam Chidioka, revealed a major structural shift in the Nigerian capital market: local investors now control approximately 80 per cent of market participation, drastically reducing the market's historical vulnerability to foreign capital flight.

"Before now, our market was dominated by foreign investors, but today foreign investors account for less than 20 per cent of our market," Chidioka explained during an exclusive chat. "About 80 per cent are Nigerians, corporates, asset managers, pension fund administrators, and individual retail investors buying shares. Eighty per cent means stability. When foreigners dominated, any adverse development made them pull out their funds immediately, what we call 'hot money.' Today, Nigeria has more 'cool money' than hot money, putting the market in a far better position."

Chidioka noted that relative stability in the exchange rate, interest rates, and broader macroeconomic indicators continues to support investor confidence.



From left: Jethro John, Executive Director of Treasury and Operations, Anchoria Asset Management; Folagbade Adeyemi, Managing Director, Anchoria Securities; Perpetua Alkay-Unegbu, Executive Director, Risk & Compliance, Anchoria; Dr Doyin Salami, Chief Executive Officer of Kainos Edge Consulting and Keynote Speaker; Group Managing Director, Anchoria, Sam Chidioka; Esther Ugwu, Managing Director, Anchoria Asset Management; Damilola Titiladunayo, Managing Director, Anchoria Advisory Services; and Emmanuel Osho, Executive Director, Anchoria Securities

However, he strongly cautioned retail investors against treating the stock market like a casino or falling prey to fraudulent schemes promising instant riches.

"The biggest risk is people investing without understanding the market," Chidioka warned, reflecting on the 2008 market crash where many lost short-term capital like rent and tuition fees to long-term equity bets. "We are not money doublers; we are professionals. Equities are long-term investments. Rather than general buy or sell advice, investors should speak to SEC-regulated profes-

sionals who evaluate micro and macro indicators to tailor portfolios based on age, risk appetite, and financial goals."

Delivering the keynote address, renowned economist and Chief Executive Officer of Kainos Edge Consulting, Dr. Doyin Salami, affirmed that Nigeria's economy is gradually gaining strength, characterised by expanding GDP, a calmer foreign exchange market, and easing inflation. While global investment opportunities remain concentrated in fast-growing tech sectors like AI, Salami stressed that domestic

opportunities driven by homegrown economic reforms, rising oil revenues, and improving FX liquidity currently offer higher returns for local investors, provided policy stability and regulatory clarity are maintained.

Speaking on the impact of the keynote, the Managing Director of Anchoria Securities, Folagbade Adeyemi, described Dr. Salami's insights as the defining highlight of the forum.

"Perspective is an asset in this market," Adeyemi shared in an exclusive interview. "Being able to see beyond

six months, especially as we navigate economic shifts and election cycles, is a major driver of business. For too long, we haven't been actively in the front and centre of the retail space. This forum lets people know that we are here to stay and highlights the value we bring. With households currently under pressure, everybody needs to be actively talking about wealth creation for themselves."

For the Managing Director of Anchoria Asset Management, Esther Ugwu, seeing the forum come to life marked the culmination of a deliberate seven-month journey that began early in the year.

"At the start of the year, we realised that while we've been in this business for a long time, people often asked what exactly we do and who we cater to," Ugwu revealed. "We decided to bring together investors, clients, prospects, and industry leaders to engage actively on how to create, build, and preserve wealth."

Addressing the stellar panel lineup, which featured prominent figures including Dr. Ola Brown, 'Uncle Dre' of Nairametrics, the Executive Director of Fidelity Pensions, and representatives from Voifa Credit, Ugwu clarified that while they are independent industry leaders rather than internal stakeholders, their presence was essential to providing well-rounded financial perspectives.

"Anchoria Asset Management has been an SEC-regulated business for over 11 years," Ugwu noted. "The biggest takeaway we want attendees to leave with is that building and preserving wealth requires discipline, foresight, and the right partner. If you are looking to build lasting wealth, think Anchoria."

Glitz, Glamour, Governance: Sanwo-Olu, Okpebholo Honoured At Grand 3rd Eko Mi Awards

It was an evening where high-octane governance, political heavyweights, and elite entertainment seamlessly converged under one glittering roof as the Shell Hall of the prestigious MUSON Centre, Ikoyi, hosted the third edition of the highly anticipated Eko Mi Awards on Friday, July 17. Designed to celebrate outstanding achievements, exemplary leadership, and the steady delivery of the dividends of democracy, the star-studded event proved to be a resounding tribute to public officers who have placed the welfare of the people at the heart of their administrative mandate.

Stealing the spotlight on a night of intense celebration were the Executive Governor of Lagos State, Mr. Babajide Sanwo-Olu, and his Edo State counterpart, Governor Monday Okpebholo, both of whom were bestowed with major honours for their transformative leadership styles. Represented by the Secretary to the Lagos State Government, Barrister Abimbola Salu-Hundeyin, Governor Sanwo-Olu expressed heartfelt appreciation to the organisers, noting that the recognition reflects the genuine affection of the populace while reaffirming his administration's unwavering commitment to delivering even greater infrastructural and socio-economic strides across the Centre



of Excellence.

In a remarkable show of inter-state synergy and inclusive governance, Edo State Governor, Monday Okpebholo, bagged the prestigious 'Friend of Lagos Award' in recognition of his steadfast support for Lagos State and his progressive administrative style. Receiving the plaque on his principal's behalf, the Edo State Commissioner for Information and Strategy, Prince Kassim Afegbua, commended the convener for identifying and celebrating Governor Okpebholo's

impactful performance in Edo State within such a short frame of time.

Unpacking the vision behind the awards, the Chief Executive Officer of Image Expressions and Publisher of Eko Mi Eko e Magazine, Otunba Bestman Nze-Jumbo, applauded both governors for running humane, people-centric administrations. Nze-Jumbo revealed that the decision to honour the duo was firmly anchored on direct feedback from the grassroots, praising Governor Okpebholo in particular for his sincere alignment



with the national vision of President Bola Ahmed Tinubu and describing him as a true brother to the people of Lagos.

The evening's honours list also extended to other distinguished public servants and industry icons who have made invaluable contributions to societal development. The Lagos State Head of Service, Mr. Bode Agoro, was presented with the Excellent Leadership Award, while the Executive Director of Galaxy Backbone, Hon. Olusegun Olulade (Eleniyan), Hon. James Faleke, the Publisher of City

People Magazine, Mayor Akinpelu, celebrated Nollywood star Dayo Amusa, and the Lagos Metropolitan Area Transport Authority (LAMATA) were all decorated for their stellar contributions to their respective fields.

Adding royal gravitas and executive flair to the room was a galaxy of dignitaries, including the former Director-General of the Nigerian Stock Exchange, Prof. Ndi Okereke-Onyiuoke, the Permanent Secretary of the Lagos State Independent Electoral Commission (LASIEC), Mr. Abdul-Rafiu Fashola, the Chief Bajulaye of Lagos, alongside top political office holders, captains of industry, and cultural icons. Master of Ceremonies and comedy pioneer Gbenga Adeyinka D 1st steered the night's proceedings with effortless charm and razor-sharp humour, while electrifying performances by veteran musician 9ice and Nigeria's premier female thunder-drummer, Ara, kept the high-society audience thoroughly entertained until the late hours of the night.

Trend Scoop



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Critics Still Can't Believe Peller And Jarvis' Wedding Is Real

Despite their pre-wedding photos, wedding date announcement, and months of preparation, many critics, especially users on X (formerly Twitter), still insist that Peller and Jarvis' wedding is nothing more than content.

However, with their wedding set for August 1, 2026, it is becoming increasingly clear that the ceremony is real. Judging by the scale of the preparations and the calibre of guests expected, the event could become one of the biggest and most talked-about celebrity weddings in Nigeria this year.

Peller and Jarvis have become two of the most talked-about personalities on Nigerian social media. Since announcing their engagement, hardly a week has passed without the couple dominating conversations on Instagram, TikTok, Facebook, and X. Whether they are being praised or heavily criticised, they remain at the centre of online discussions.

In fact, many social media users now believe that anyone looking for quick engagement only needs to make a post about Peller or Jarvis. Such posts often attract thousands of comments, shares, and reactions because of the couple's massive online following.

Their popularity has also made them regular guests on television programmes and podcasts, where they continue to share their inspiring journey from humble beginnings to internet fame. These interviews often go viral because many people find their love story genuine, relatable, and entertaining.

As their wedding day draws closer, preparations have intensified. Several top musicians, influencers, content creators, and celebrities are expected to attend the event, which the couple has said will be strictly by invitation.

Yet, despite the proposal, engagement announcement, and pre-wedding shoots, many critics remain unconvinced. Some argue that Peller, who is 21 years old, is too young to get married. Others claim that Jarvis is only with him because of his wealth and fame, while some believe they are not compatible and predict that the marriage will not last. According to these critics, Peller may eventually want to enjoy life and explore other relationships because of



his age.

The couple recently addressed many of these concerns during an appearance on The Honest Bunch Podcast. Peller explained that one of his biggest reasons for getting married is to break a generational pattern in his family. He revealed that his parents never got married, while Jarvis also shared that her parents were never married and eventually separated after having their children.

Responding to those who believe he is too young for marriage, Peller insisted that his online personality is different from who he is in real life. According to him, he is much calmer and more mature offline, adding that he only becomes energetic and dramatic whenever a camera is on.

Peller also revealed that he has never cheated on Jarvis and has no intention of doing so. He said they both made a personal vow to remain faithful to each other throughout their marriage, a statement that quickly sparked widespread reactions online.

As expected, several of the couple's comments from the podcast have continued to fuel debates across social media. While many Nigerians praised Peller for his determination to build a stable family and commended Jarvis for her calm and thoughtful responses, others remained unconvinced, continuing to question the couple's decision to marry at a young age.

With only days left before the ceremony, supporters eagerly await what promises to be a grand celebration, while critics continue to wonder whether the wedding will finally silence doubts or generate even more conversations online.

2Baba And Annie's Reunion Rumours Won't Go Away As Viral Dance Video Keeps Fans Talking

Just when many Nigerians thought the love story between music icon 2Baba and his ex-wife, Annie Idibia, had finally come to an end, an old video has reopened the conversation, leaving fans divided over whether the former couple could be heading for a reunion.

Over the weekend, social media was flooded with a video showing 2Baba and Annie sharing a close, romantic dance. The pair held each other tightly, smiling as they swayed to the music, a moment that many viewers described as looking like two people who never wanted the dance to end.

Although the clip was not new, it spread rapidly across Instagram, TikTok, Facebook and X, formerly known as Twitter. Within hours, thousands of fans had concluded that the two had reconciled, with many claiming Annie had "taken back her husband" from his new wife, whom some critics alleged had been controlling the singer.

The rumours gained even more attention after popular blogger Tunde Ednut reposted the video on his Instagram page. For many social media users, a post from one of Nigeria's biggest entertainment bloggers was enough to convince them that there was some truth to the reunion claims. Soon, several blogs and content creators picked up the story, sharing the same video with captions suggesting that the former couple were back together.

For supporters of 2Baba and Annie, it was the news they had been waiting to hear. Since the couple parted ways, many fans have openly wished for a reconciliation, believing their love story deserved another chance. They celebrated the viral clip, expressing hope that the singer and actress had finally found their way back to each other.

However, not everyone shared the excitement. Some social media users criticised the idea of Annie returning to her former husband after everything that happened in their marriage. They argued that she should protect her peace,

maintain her self-worth and continue with her healing journey instead of revisiting a relationship that had caused her emotional pain. Others insisted she deserved a fresh start rather than another chapter with her ex-husband.

As debates continued to dominate social media, entertainment gossip platform Cute Juicy added another twist to the story with a series of posts on X. The platform claimed that some of 2Baba's close friends allegedly deceived his new wife and took the singer to a rehabilitation centre. It further alleged that he could not remember many of the incidents that happened while he was with his new wife.

Although the claims remain unverified, they quickly became another major talking point online, with many people linking them to the reunion rumours and suggesting they could explain why Annie and 2Baba might be reconnecting.

Adding to the speculation was Annie's recent interview while

discussing her newly released book. Speaking about love, relationships, self-worth and the lessons life has taught her, many fans believed her comments were indirectly connected to the trending video and her past relationship with 2Baba. Her interview sparked fresh interpretations, with supporters reading hidden meanings into almost every statement she made.

However, both Annie and 2Baba have dismissed the rumours.

Reacting to the viral reports, Annie took to her Instagram Story, writing, "Old news circulating everywhere, false news everywhere," making it clear that the trending video was not recent.

2Baba also confirmed that the dance clip was an old video and urged people not to read too much into it.

Despite their clarifications, many fans remain unconvinced. For them, the chemistry displayed in the video was too genuine to ignore, and they continue to believe there may still be more to the story than either Annie or 2Baba is willing to reveal publicly.



Simi Sanya Says N80 Million Is Too Small for A Big Wedding As Rising Costs Leave Nigerians Talking

In Nigeria today, weddings have become more than just a celebration of love. They have evolved into grand productions where venue, decoration, food, fashion and entertainment often determine how memorable the day will be. For many couples, especially celebrities, saying "I do" now comes with a price tag running into tens of millions of naira.

Content creator and entrepreneur Simi Sanya Dapson has added her voice to the conversation after revealing that N80 million is too small for a big wedding, especially one with about 300 guests.

Speaking during the Chi Chat podcast, Simi said many people have no idea how expensive weddings have become until they begin planning one themselves.



Her comment came after she was asked how much she spent on her wedding, which took place earlier this year. Although she refused to disclose the exact

amount, she admitted that the final cost became so overwhelming that she and her team stopped calculating.

"If I say how much I spent on my wedding, they may come and pick me up," she said jokingly.

She continued: "Did we do calculations at a point? We stopped because it was getting scary. There is no return on investment. No matter how much people spray you, you are not getting your money back."

According to Simi, her goal was never to organise the biggest wedding. Instead, she simply wanted the wedding she had always dreamed of.

"I wasn't planning for it to be big. I was just planning my dream wedding. I wanted to be happy," she explained.

When asked whether N80 million is too small for a wedding, Simi replied that it depends on the kind of ceremony a couple wants.

"If you want to do a big wedding, that is small," she said, adding that while N80 million could comfortably fund two different weddings, the quality and outcome would be completely different.

She explained that one of the biggest factors determining the cost of a wedding is the choice of location.

Using her own wedding as an example, she revealed that her traditional wedding was held on Lagos Island, while her white wedding took place on the mainland. According to her, moving the second ceremony

to the mainland helped reduce expenses because event centres there are generally cheaper.

"If you want to do your wedding on the Island, just budget about N10 million for the hall," she said, stressing that the amount does not include decoration or other expenses.

She added that a couple can still organise a beautiful wedding with N40 million, but the final result will depend on factors such as the venue, vendors, catering and other services.

Food, she noted, is another major expense that many couples overlook.

Some people reduce costs by serving only one meal to each guest, but Simi said that was never part of her plan.

"I wanted my guests to eat to

their full," she said, explaining why she was willing to spend more on catering.

The conversation also turned romantic when she was asked what she would have done if her husband had not supported her dream wedding.

Without hesitation, Simi replied: "He loves me, so he would want my dream wedding. Anything that makes me happy."

Her comments have since generated reactions online, with many Nigerians agreeing that the cost of hosting weddings has increased significantly in recent years. Others argued that while every couple deserves a memorable celebration, the focus should remain on building a successful marriage rather than organising an extravagant event.

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The Youths & The Future

A starving dog that dances frantically at the sight of a dry bone forgets that the bone holds no marrow, offering only the hollow, mocking illusion of a feast. When a society casts aside its dignity to worship the mere shadow of power rather than its substance, it sinks into a deep, tragic slumber of the soul, a paralysis where critical thought dies, and moral clarity is buried alive.

On July 21st, 2026, the Nigerian public discourse was held hostage by TWO separate yet deeply intertwined SPECTACLES. Together, they formed a grotesquely clear mirror, reflecting our collective addiction to political sycophancy, our shattered national conscience, and our desperate, humiliating hunger for foreign validation.

In Abia State, the quiet dignity of the indigenous weavers of Akwete fabric was drowned out by the thunderous sirens of an imperial motorcade. First Lady, Senator Oluremi Tinubu arrived in grand, royal state, pledging a breathtaking ₦2 billion donation to boost the local textile heritage. On paper, supporting local craft appears noble. But beneath the velvet curtains of state banquets and the orchestrated adulation lay the stench of an unconstitutional monarchy.

The fawning display brought to life an ancient, bitter truth: "When a slave suddenly sees a fellow slave dressed in a master's discarded robe, he bends his knee as if he has seen the master himself."

He bends his knee not because he is certain of who inhabits the cloth, but be-

The Mirror Of Sycophancy: When A Nation Bows To Shadows



cause, the slave mentality is internally programmed for outward servitude. The tragic mark of the subjugated mind is the loss of independent reasoning, acting on impulse, devoid of self-respect.

While state actors sang panegyrics and converted a public visit into a carnival of adulation, they ignored the blood flowing freely across the nation's soil.

How can a people break into wild applause in a society bleeding from a thousand unhealed wounds?

Consider the gruesome tally of that very same day and week:

In Rivers State, assassins snuffed out the life of a vigilante commander and three women.

In Borno State, coordinated horrors ripped through Gwoza, where fe-

male suicide bombers blew apart a wedding, a funeral, and a hospital, leaving at least 18 dead (including pregnant women and children), and dozens maimed. In nearby Kuwawu, over 20 farmers were slaughtered in their fields; attacks in Kross Kauwa and Logomani claimed military personnel, burning police outposts and primary health centres to ash.

In Katsina State, armed bandits invaded a mosque in Unguwar Mantau during Fajr prayers, cutting down at least 34 worshippers as they bowed before God.

In Niger, Benue, and Plateau, armed raiders continue their relentless march, erasing whole villages from the map.

This is a bloody season that Nigeria should be wrapped in sackcloth

and ashes, weeping uncontrollably. We ought to be in a state of national mourning. Yet, we beat drums and sing praise songs for political royalty. We have shed the fundamental instincts of humanity—empathy, grief, and solidarity; and sadly, we have been transformed into a herd that grazes peacefully beside the fresh graves of its own kin.

In a mature democracy, the spouse of a leader occupies a defined, bounded space. Melania Trump does not tour

American states flanked by state-funded armadas to dole out multi-billion-dollar pledges, nor do citizens fall to their knees addressing her as "Her Excellency." She remains a private citizen married to a public servant.

This craving for royalty metastasized in the SECOND SPECTACLE to this piece: The frantic, embarrassing escalation of an unverified routine diplomatic letter, specifically talking about security cooperation, generated a lot of controversies, especially with the allegation that the letter may have been forged, as it didn't contain certain US President's Official Diplomatic Letter features, such as, the standard White House Seal, Watermark, official

Letterhead and authentic Signature of the US President. Even with all these abnormalities, this routine correspondence sent by US President, Donald Trump to President Bola Ahmed Tinubu became the magic wand to this regime's sycophantic hype.

Overnight, the ruling All Progressives Congress (APC) and its apparatus transformed routine diplomatic etiquette into a triumphant victory song for PBAT re-election. Political forums became cheerleading clubs, waving a piece of unverified foreign paper like a holy parchment or a divine stamp of legitimacy.

This hysteria laid bare to a profound national embarrassment and inferiority complex. It showcased the pathetic belief that governance is validated not by whether citizens have food, security, or electricity, but by polite words penned in Washington. A tragic scenario of, "A hunter who boasts endlessly in the village square because a foreigner praised the handle of his gun, but forgets that his children are starving at home."

International diplomacy is built on cold, shifting interest, not sentimental affection. Foreign praise is as fragile as morning dew; it evaporates the moment geopolitical interests pivot. Celebrating a foreign President's routine note while basic internal security crumbles is nothing more than narcotic distraction. And it can be likened to,

"A bird that builds its nest in a burning tree and still expects its eggs to hatch in peace."

We cannot continue to dance beneath a burning roof. As long as we mistake official grandiosity for actual achievement and beg foreign thrones for a nod of approval, true democratic accountability will remain a distant mirage.

Finally my fellow Nigerians, I want to sincerely remind us that, National dignity is not minted in the entourage of a First Lady, nor is it signed in the White House. It is forged when citizens reject sycophancy, demand relentless accountability, and remember that, those in power are not deities to be worshiped, but servants hired to serve and protect the living.

A river that forgets its source will inevitably dry up in the heat of the sun. When a nation trades its collective pain for political pageantry, it becomes a ghost walking among the living, a shadow bowing to shadows, and the result is that, I come in PEACE.

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Saturday Reflections

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July 25th is the 206th day of the year and also the 159 days to the end of the year. Today is the International Day for Women and Girls of African Descent. It was established by the United Nations to honor the immense contributions, resilience, and leadership of women and girls of African descent, while advocating to end systemic racism, sexism, and gender-based disparities.

The observance builds upon the legacy of the First Pan-African Women's Conference,

which was held in Santo Domingo, Dominican Republic, on July 25, 1992. During this historic gathering, Afro-descendant women from 32 countries in the Americas and the Caribbean convened to strategise against racism, sexism, and economic marginalisation, formally declaring July 25 as the International Day of Afro-Latin American, Afro-Caribbean, and Diaspora Women.

Following years of grassroots activism, the United Nations General Assembly

Happy International Day For Judicial Well-Being

officially adopted a resolution to recognise this observance globally. This monumental decision was championed by international advocates and member states to shed light on the unique "double burden" of discrimination faced by women and girls of African descent.

July 25 is also the International Day for Judicial Well-being. It was established by the United Nations General Assembly to recognise the fact that judges' mental and physical health is fundamental to safeguarding judicial independence, integrity, and the rule of law.

The annual theme for the International Day for Judicial Well-being is focused on embedding well-being within judicial culture and structures to up-

hold integrity and the quality of justice. Centered around the seven core principles of the Nuru Declaration, it emphasizes that judicial well-being is a shared, systemic responsibility rather than just an individual burden.

Above all, today, July 25th is the feast of St. James. St. James the Great was one of the Twelve Apostles of Jesus. According to the New Testament, he was the second of the apostles to die, after Judas Iscariot, and the first to be martyred. He was a fisherman by trade; he and his brother John were nicknamed the "Sons of Thunder" by Jesus. James became a vital part of Jesus' inner circle. James was one of only three apostles privileged to witness pivotal moments in Jesus' life, includ-

ing the Transfiguration and the agony in the Garden of Gethsemane.

Around 44 AD, James was executed by the sword under the orders of King Herod Agrippa I. He is the only apostle whose martyrdom is recorded in the New Testament (Acts 12:2).

Some of the remarkable events in the bible where Peter, James and John were present were the transfiguration of our Lord Jesus Christ as recorded in the gospel of Matthew 17:1-9: "After six days Jesus took with him Peter, James and John the brother of James, and led them up a high mountain by themselves. There he was transfigured before them. His face shone like the sun, and his clothes became as white as the

light. Saint James, alongside Peter and John were the only lucky disciples of our Lord Jesus Christ who experienced the transfiguration.

In the gospel of Matthew 2:37 our Lord Jesus Christ took Peter and the two sons of Zebedee along with him, and he began to be sorrowful and troubled. This happened at the garden of Gethsemane a night before Jesus was crucified and James was there. It is this same James that we are celebrating today. As you continue to celebrate him you will also be celebrated and it shall be well with you in Jesus name – Amen! (follow: Apostle of Divine Mercy @ Tiktok.com and Altar of Divine Mercy Eucharistic Adoration @ Facebook and YouTube.com)

In My Frame

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Nuisance Upon Nonsense: Thick smoke emanating from scavengers' shanties said to have been set ablaze by the Lagos State Taskforce chokes the residents and passersby at Ile-Epo area of Lagos, on Sunday. PHOTO: KUNLE AJAYI

Odd News

Compiled By Oyinkan Somorin

Spain's Fabian Ruiz, Gavi Awarded Weight In Tomatoes For World Cup Win

Los Palacios y Villafraanca honored hometown heroes Fabian Ruiz and Gavi with their weight in tomatoes for helping Spain win the 2026 World Cup.

The midfielders participated in a ceremony Tuesday at town hall in the Spanish province of Seville, which is known for tomato production. They stepped on scales and were presented with their weight -- in kilograms -- of the fruit.

Ruiz weighed in at about 187 pounds (85 kg.), while Gavi was about 151 pounds, or 68.5 kg.

Ruiz, 30, played 366 minutes for the Spaniards at the World Cup. The Paris Saint-Germain midfielder scored the first goal in a 2-1 win over Belgium in the quarterfinals.

Gavi, 21, logged 85 min-

utes at the tournament. The Barcelona midfielder also teamed up with Ruiz and the Spaniards to win a 2023 UEFA Nations League title.

Officials also announced the municipal grass soccer fields in the area will be renamed "Fabian Ruiz Football Field" and "Pablo Pez Gabira 'Gavi' Football Field."

The city plans to construct a monument honoring Gavi, Ruiz and Jesus Navas, another local who won the 2010 World Cup with the Spaniards.

Gavi and Ruiz participated in a parade with their teammates Monday in Madrid. Spain also will receive \$51 million and become the first World Cup team to receive championship rings for winning the title. Those rings will be customized and presented at a later date.



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Perspectives

Why Nigeria's Agrifood Transformation Plan Faces Funding Test As Country Seeks Food Sovereignty

Nigeria has unveiled its most ambitious agricultural roadmap in a generation – a 10-year Agrifood System Strategy and Action Plan aimed at achieving food sovereignty and ending the cycle of fragmented interventions. But even as the government presented the blueprint as a turning point, fresh data from civil society revealed a stark funding gap that threatens to undermine the entire transformation agenda. **ROLAND OGBONNAYA** writes

In a packed hall in Abuja last Thursday, Nigeria's agricultural establishment gathered to witness what officials described as a turning point for the nation's food system. The Minister of Agriculture and Food Security, Senator Abubakar Kyari, stood before the Agrifood System Working Group (ASWG) to unveil a 10-year Agrifood System Strategy and Action Plan – a document that, he insisted, would finally move the country beyond the cycle of pilot projects and fragmented interventions that have long hampered progress.

"The President has given us a clear and urgent charge: to move beyond rhetoric, beyond pilot projects, and beyond fragmented interventions, and instead deliver a coherent, bankable, and implementable plan that will fundamentally transform Nigeria's agrifood system for the long term," Kyari declared.

The strategy, developed under the Comprehensive Africa Agriculture Development Programme (CAADP) Kampala Declaration (2026–2035), represents a shift in approach. Rather than treating agriculture as a collection of isolated projects, the plan adopts an integrated food systems framework that encompasses production, processing, markets, resilience, investment, nutrition and governance. It is an ambitious blueprint, one that President Bola Tinubu has elevated to a national security priority. Yet even as the minister spoke, a shadow hung over the proceedings: the question of whether Nigeria's notoriously underfunded agricultural sector can marshal the resources needed to translate vision into reality.

The CAADP Kampala Declaration, signed by African heads of state, commits signatories to a series of measurable targets by 2035: increasing agrifood output, tripling intra-African trade in agrifood products, halving post-harvest losses, improving nutrition outcomes, mobilising \$100 billion in investments, and narrowing the gender productivity gap. Kyari identified governance as the foundation of success. "Strong coordination, effective institutions and accountability mechanisms will determine the success of Nigeria's implementation plan," he said.

Nigeria's plan, developed through consultations across all six geopolitical zones, will be presented for stakeholder adoption before being forwarded to the Federal Executive Council for approval. Once approved, it would compel all ministries, departments and agencies to align their budgets and programmes with the transformation vision. On paper, it is a coherent document. But agriculture in Nigeria has long suffered from a gap between policy ambition and fiscal reality.

The most arresting intervention at the meeting came not from a government minister but from a civil society analyst. Azubike Nwokoye, Food Systems Specialist at ActionAid Nigeria, presented findings from a newly developed



Nigeria's typical food market

dashboard that tracked agricultural capital spending across all 36 states and the Federal Capital Territory between 2023 and 2025. The data painted a grim picture. "The findings are not encouraging. Between 2023 and 2025, Nigeria has performed poorly in terms of capital spending on agriculture," Nwokoye said.

His analysis showed that in 2025, only ten states achieved high performance in agricultural capital expenditure; sixteen states recorded very low performance, while eight registered medium performance. The combined allocation for 2026 across all states and the FCT stood at just 4.58 per cent of total budgets – less than half the 10 per cent benchmark set under the Maputo, Malabo and Kampala commitments. "As a country, we must act quickly, including through complementary budgets where necessary, if we are to meet these commitments," Nwokoye warned.

The data also revealed a paradox: underfunding coexists with significant potential returns. ActionAid's modelling suggests that if states fully implement their 2026 agricultural budgets, Nigeria could generate approximately 1.4 million direct quality jobs at state level, with federal spending adding another 2.1 million, for a combined potential of 3.5 million jobs. "Increasing investment would raise this figure significantly," Nwokoye said. The organisation plans to transmit its findings to state governors in the hope of spurring greater commitment.

Any serious discussion of Nigeria's food system must reckon with the scale of its smallholder population. The Minister of Budget and Economic Planning, Senator Atiku Bagudu, reminded the audience that more than 42 million agricultural households form the backbone of the sector – most of them small-scale, family-based producers. "For us to

achieve our objectives, we must ensure that these 42 million agricultural households thrive," he said.

Bagudu pointed to ongoing reforms: the creation of a Ministry of Livestock Development, the establishment of the National Agricultural Development Fund, and increased support for agricultural land development. He also noted that the constitution itself, under Section 16, recognises food security as a state responsibility. But he acknowledged that global headwinds – rising energy costs, expensive fertiliser, disrupted supply chains – have made the task harder.

"Nigeria's greatest strength lies in its private sector-driven agricultural system," he said. The government's role, he argued, is to create an enabling environment where agriculture becomes profitable, modern and productive.

One of the most pointed contributions came from the Minister of Women Affairs, Hajiya Imaan Sulaiman-Ibrahim, who insisted that gender equity is not optional under the Kampala framework. The declaration requires countries to halve the gender productivity gap by 2035. "Closing the gender gap in agriculture is not a request from the Ministry of Women Affairs. It is an obligation under the declaration that Nigeria has already signed," she said.

Sulaiman-Ibrahim noted that millions of women farmers are disadvantaged by limited access to land, credit, inputs, extension services and mechanisation. "We are not dealing with underperforming farmers. We are dealing with under-resourced farmers," she declared. Programmes such as the Nigeria for Women Programme and the Women Agro Value Expansion (WAVE) Initiative have improved participation and earnings, she said, but urged the

ASWG to establish measurable gender targets, improve sex-disaggregated data, and ensure women benefit from government support.

The newly created Ministry of Livestock Development also made its voice heard, with its minister arguing that livestock should no longer be treated as a secondary component of agriculture. He called for investment in animal health, veterinary infrastructure, disease surveillance, genetic improvement, feed development, processing facilities and climate-smart production systems – describing the sector as a strategic engine for rural transformation. It was a sign that Nigeria is beginning to take a more holistic view of its agrifood system, one that integrates crops, livestock and the people who depend on them.

Underpinning the entire strategy is the Agrifood System Working Group itself. The Permanent Secretary of the Ministry of Agriculture, Dr Marcus Ogunbiyi, described the ASWG as the technical platform for coordinating policies, monitoring implementation and ensuring that commitments translate into measurable results. Challenges such as climate change, insecurity, post-harvest losses, inadequate infrastructure and limited financing, he said, require collaboration across government, private sector, research institutions and development partners.

Ogunbiyi gave the gathering a working definition of the ultimate goal. "Food sovereignty means Nigerians eating what we grow and growing what we eat. It means building a resilient food system that guarantees every citizen physical and economic access to safe, nutritious and affordable food," he said. It was a phrase that resonated throughout the day's proceedings.

In a development that lent credi-

bility to the government's efforts, the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) confirmed that Nigeria has become the first African country to develop a national strategy and action plan for domesticating the CAADP Kampala Declaration. IFAD described the milestone as a landmark achievement that places Nigeria at the forefront of implementing Africa's agricultural transformation agenda.

The organisation praised the inclusive and consultative process that produced the strategy, noting collaboration with the African Development Bank, AGRA, the International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI), the Food and Agriculture Organisation, and the World Bank. IFAD highlighted the strategy's mainstreaming of climate resilience, nutrition, gender equality, youth empowerment, and support for vulnerable groups including persons with disabilities and internally displaced persons.

Importantly, the strategy embraces digital agriculture – including digital farmer registries, climate advisory services, electronic extension services, digital financial platforms and market information systems. IFAD said embracing digital innovation will improve productivity, expand market access, enhance transparency and equip millions of farmers with modern solutions.

The meeting in Abuja brought together senior officials from the African Union, the World Bank, the African Development Bank, GIZ, AGRA, research institutions, farmers' organisations, private sector actors and civil society groups. It was a testament to the breadth of support for the transformation agenda. But as the speeches ended and delegates filed out, the hard questions remained. Nigeria has a plan, a continental first, and political backing at the highest level. What it lacks is a track record of sustained investment.

The 4.58 per cent allocation stands as a glaring gap between rhetoric and resources. The 42 million smallholder households still lack access to credit, land, and modern inputs. Women farmers remain systematically marginalised. And the global economic environment, with its rising costs and supply pressures, offers no respite.

Yet there are grounds for cautious optimism. The strategy itself is genuinely comprehensive. The political will at the ministerial level appears genuine. International partners have lined up behind it. And the ActionAid analysis, stark as it is, also points to a clear upside: every percentage point increase in agricultural spending translates into hundreds of thousands of jobs.

As Dr Ogunbiyi put it, food sovereignty is the ultimate goal. Whether Nigeria can achieve it will depend not on the elegance of its strategy documents, but on the willingness of its governments – federal and state – to put money behind the words. The plan is on the table. The test now is execution.

Sports



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R-e-v-e-a-l-e-d

AYO BADA
LAGOS

Why Super Falcons Players Fear Marriage

Former Levante midfielder Ngozi Okobi-Okeoghene has revealed that many Super Falcons players are afraid to get married because they fear it could cost them their place in Nigeria's national team.

The 32-year-old, who has won four Women's Africa Cup of Nations (WAFCON) titles and earned 75 international caps, made the comments while speaking to BBC Sport Africa as Nigeria prepare for the 2026 WAFCON in Morocco.

Okobi knows the challenges first-hand. She married her husband, Okeoghene Ahmed in 2017 and continued representing Nigeria shortly after her wedding. Years later, she stepped away from football because of a high-risk pregnancy, missing the 2023 FIFA Women's World Cup and the Paris 2024 Olympic Games.

After seven years of marriage, she welcomed her first child, a baby boy named Nathan in September 2024 in Canada. Five months later, in February 2025, she began an intense fitness programme to regain match sharpness before making her return to competitive football in June 2025. She came off the bench in the 83rd minute for Ottawa Rapid FC in Canada's Northern Super League, completing a remarkable comeback only eight months after giving birth.

Her performances eventually earned her a recall to the Super Falcons by head coach Justin Madugu in early 2026 for friendly matches against Cameroon and Senegal. Okobi-Okeoghene has been included Nigeria's squad to the 2026 WAFCON in Morocco, where the record ten-time African champions are drawn in Group C alongside Malawi, Zambia and Egypt.

Okobi believes her journey proves that marriage and motherhood do not have to bring an end to a footballer's career.

The experienced midfielder said negative attitudes towards married women and mothers remain the key reason some Nigerian players delay starting families.

"Nigerians, most of the fans out there, feel when a woman is married, she's old," Okobi said. "When a woman gives birth, she's old; she doesn't have the strength to do whatever she's doing."

According to the former



Ngozi Okobi-Okeoghene in action for the Super Falcons of Nigeria

Washington Spirit star, those opinions have created fear among several members of the Super Falcons.

"They keep making us feel bad about ourselves," she said. "Most of the girls are so scared to get married. They feel by the time they get married, they won't be called to the national team anymore."

Okobi rejected that belief, insisting that being an athlete should not prevent a woman from having a family or pursuing other ambitions.

"Being a soccer player doesn't stop me from being a wife. It doesn't stop me from being a career woman, an athlete," she added. "We need to encourage our women. We need to make them understand that of course they can do more." "Motherhood should not be the end of anyone's story."

Okobi helped Nigeria win WAFCON titles in 2010, 2014, 2016 and 2018, scored against Sweden at the 2015 FIFA Women's World Cup in Canada, and was named the Live Your Goal Player of the Match.

Four years later, she played every minute of Nigeria's campaign at the 2019 FIFA Women's World Cup in France, helping the Super Falcons reach the knockout stage for the first time in 20 years.

Now, she is helping the Super Falcons prepare for another WAFCON campaign in Morocco, where they will face Malawi on Tuesday, July 28, Zambia on Saturday, August 1 and Egypt on Wednesday, August 5.

The 2026 Women's Africa Cup of Nations, commonly referred to as 'WAFCON 2026', will be the 14th edition (16th if editions of the tournament without hosts

are included) of the Women's Africa Cup of Nations, the biennial international football championship organised by Confederation of African Football (CAF) for the women's national teams of Africa.

The tournament which will kick off on Sunday, July 26, will be held in Morocco for the third consecutive tournament becoming the first country to achieve this feat. Venues in Casablanca, Fez and Rabat will be used for the tournament.

Despite originally being planned to be a 12 team tournament, CAF decided to expand the tournament to 16 teams after qualification ended.

Qualification took place between February and October 2025 to decide who qualified, while hosts Morocco qualified automatically. Cape Verde and Malawi will make their debut.

The tournament also doubled as the African qualifiers for the 2027 FIFA Women's World Cup in Brazil. The top four teams will qualify for the World Cup, and two more teams will advance to the inter-confederation play-offs.

Nigeria are the defending champions after beating Morocco 3-2 in the 2024 final in Rabat.

A total of 39 CAF member nations entered the competition qualifiers. With hosts Morocco automatically qualified, the remaining 38 teams contested two qualifying rounds to decide the other 11 places in the final tournament.

Chad, who were set to make their debut in WAFCON qualifying, withdrew before the first round due to financial difficulties. Congo withdrew prior to the first leg of the first round due to a lack of competitions and preparation.

In early October 2025, ahead of the second and final round of qualification, reports emerged suggesting that the tournament would be expanded to 16 teams, though no details were provided regarding potential format changes.

However, on October 25, the Confederation of African Football (CAF) dismissed these claims, clarifying that the qualification process would determine 11 teams to join the hosts.

Subsequent reports indicated that CAF was nonetheless considering expansion. On November 3, 2025, CAF officially confirmed the expansion from 12 to 16 teams. As the qualification phase for the tournament had already concluded, the four highest-ranked teams based on the FIFA Women's World Ranking of August 7, 2025, among those eliminated in the final qualifying round were selected to complete the list of 16 participating nations.

Of the 16 qualified teams, nine had taken part in the 2024 edition, while Botswana, Democratic Republic of Congo and Tunisia missed out, having qualified in 2024. Cape Verde and Malawi both will make their first appearance in the final tournament.

News

Oyo SSG Commissions Newly Constructed Amotekun Office In Oluyole, Hails Olatunji's Visionary Leadership**● As Oyo APM Deputy Governorship Candidate Rally Grassroots Support Ahead Of 2027 Polls****KAZEEM AWOJODU,**
IBADAN

The Secretary to the Oyo State Government (SSG), Professor Musbaudeen Babatunde, has commissioned a newly constructed Omotuntun Amotekun Office at Ayegun in Oluyole Local Government Area.

The Oyo SSG described the Executive Chairman of the council, Engr. Akeem Olatunji, as a visionary leader whose commitment to grassroots development and security has continued to impact lives positively.

The commissioning ceremony, which recorded a large turnout of political leaders, traditional rulers, community stakeholders and residents, was attended by the Allied People's Movement (APM) Deputy Governorship candidate, Engr. Muftau Open Salawu, alongside other top government officials and party faithful.

The event also featured the presentation of empowerment equipment to beneficiaries as part of efforts to boost economic activities at the grassroots.

In a further demonstration of support for community policing and grassroots security architecture, three motorcycles were donated to strengthen security operations.

One motorcycle was allocated to the newly commissioned Omotuntun Amotekun Office, while another was presented to the Nigeria Forest Security Service

(NFSS), whose office was commissioned in the area last week.

The remaining motorcycle is expected to complement security patrol activities within the Oluyole local government.

Speaking shortly after unveiling the facility, Professor Babatunde commended Olatunji for prioritising the security of lives and property, noting that no meaningful development could thrive in an atmosphere of insecurity.

He urged residents to continue supporting the administration of Governor Seyi Makinde, stressing that sustained cooperation between government and the people remained vital to maintaining the state's developmental trajectory.

According to him, the achievements recorded under the present administration across various sectors should encourage the electorate to consolidate on the gains by supporting the APM in the forthcoming elections.

The SSG also expressed confidence in Olatunji's capacity to represent Oluyole Federal Constituency in the House of Representatives, describing his performance as council chairman as evidence of his competence and commitment to public service.

"From what he has demonstrated at the local government level, I have no doubt that Engr. Akeem Olatunji possesses the experience, vision and capacity to deliver quality representation for the people of Oluyole at the National Assembly," he said.

PFN Urges Tinubu To Reject Road Safety Bill, Seeks Wider Consultation**SEYI TAIWO-OGUNTUASE**

The Pentecostal Fellowship of Nigeria (PFN) has called on President Bola Tinubu to decline assent to the proposed Federal Road Safety Code Amendment Bill 2026, urging him to return the legislation for wider public consultation over concerns that it could inflame religious tensions.

The fellowship said the bill, which proposes sanctions against preaching in commercial vehicles, should be subjected to broader engagement with stakeholders before any decision is taken.

Addressing newsmen after the National Executive Council (NEC) meeting of the PFN in Lagos, Bishop David Bakare, the fellowship's National Secretary, said while members appreciated efforts to strengthen road safety, they believed the proposed legislation required further review.

"We are asking that the President, in his wisdom, should please set aside that law and not assent to it. If anything, send it back for the public to debate it, to look at it. Invite the relevant

people who are directly affected by such laws to come sit down. Let's discuss it," Bakare said.

He noted that the PFN supported initiatives aimed at making Nigerian roads safer and acknowledged the work of the Federal Road Safety Corps (FRSC), but argued that the proposed amendment was not among the country's most urgent priorities.

According to him, insecurity, hunger, economic hardship and infrastructure challenges should command greater legislative attention.

Bakare also expressed concern that the provision prohibiting preaching in commercial vehicles appeared to target Christians, since evangelism in buses is largely associated with the Christian faith.

He questioned why preaching had been classified as a traffic offence, saying neither he nor church leaders were aware of any incident in which preaching inside a commercial vehicle had distracted a driver and caused an accident.

Ensure Judiciary Is Insulated From External Influence, Bode George Urges NJC**● Charges PDP Members To Remain In Party Despite Challenges****JOY ANIGBOGU**
LAGOS

Chief Bode George, former Deputy National Chairman of the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP), has urged the National Judicial Council (NJC) to ensure that the judiciary is insulated from external interference.

George disclosed this on Friday in a press conference in his Ikoyi, Lagos office, through an open letter he addressed to the chairman of NJC, stressing that political interference compromises the administration of justice.

While urging the NJC to discharge its constitutional mandate with the courage, impartiality and firmness, George said, "The NJC must continue to demonstrate, both in action and in resolve, that the Judiciary

remains insulated from every form of external influence and committed solely to the dictates of the Constitution and the law."

The Atona Odua of Yorubaland, also reference the court judgement where according to him, an action instituted by the Chairman and members of the Board of Trustees of the PDP sought to compel the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) to comply with and give effect to subsisting judgments of the Supreme Court, the Court of Appeal and the Federal High Court by updating its official portal to reflect the authentic faction of the Peoples Democratic Party as led by Chief Kabiru Tanimu Turaki, SAN recognised by the judgments, rather than continuing to recognise the Wike-led faction.

He noted that instead of first determining the substantive con-

stitutional questions before it including whether INEC was under a legal obligation to comply with those subsisting judgments and amend its official records accordingly, the Court dismissed the action as a waste of judicial time and proceeded to award costs of ₦140 million against the Board of Trustees and a further ₦10 million against counsel. "It's the greatest joke in the civilised international community today. Morally and ethically, is it possible for a child to expel a father from his house whilst the father is still alive?" George stated.

According to him, "the integrity of the Judiciary is not negotiable; it's the lifeblood of the Nigerian Republic. The Judiciary remains the last hope of the common man only so long as the common man remains convinced that justice is administered according to law, guided by the

Constitution, and uninfluenced by power or expediency. The preservation of that confidence is the solemn responsibility of every judicial officer, and ultimately, of the National Judicial Council itself.

"I, therefore, respectfully call upon the NJC to discharge its constitutional mandate with the courage, impartiality and firmness expected of the guardian of judicial ethics and accountability.

"In doing so, the Council won't only preserve the honour of the Bench but also reaffirm the confidence of the Nigerian people that justice in our country remains blind to political pressure and faithful only to the Constitution and the rule of law."

George also appealed to members of his party not to defect to other parties, saying that they'll remain and ensure that justice is served.



Steve Omanufeme, Managing Director/Editor-in-Chief, Independent Newspapers (left); Richard Akinola, Executive Director, Centre for Free Speech (middle), and Gbenga Omotosho, Commissioner for Information and Strategy, Lagos State, during the fourth Lateef Jakande Memorial Lecture 2026 on 'The Media, INEC, Voters and Path to Credible Elections', organised by the Nigerian Guild of Editors (NGE), in Lagos, on Thursday.

PHOTO: KINGSTON DANIEL

BOLU-OLU ESHO,
AKURE

In a move to ensure victory for all candidates of All Progressives Congress (APC) and President Bola Ahmed Tinubu in the forthcoming general elections, a reconciliation committee has been constituted by the State Working Committee.

This was disclosed on Friday by the state Chairman of the party, Hon. Kolawole Babatunde while on a familiarisation visit to the Secretariat of the Nigeria Union of Journalists (NUJ), Ondo State Council, at Alagbaka, Akure, the state capital.

The committee, led by Prince Biyi Poroye Chairman of OSOPADEC, would look into

2027: Ondo APC Constitutes Reconciliation Committee, Says APC Chairman, Kolawole**● Assures 84 Support Groups Will Campaign For Tinubu**

how to bring all the aggrieved members of the party together ahead of the 2027 general elections.

Kolawole said: "There is no way we will go through political activities without issues. There will be political bickering, there will be arguments, but one thing that is good about our party is that we have internal mechanisms for resolving disagreements.

"These are political activities that will always result in one issue or another. There is no way one can get all of this

done without disagreements. After completing the cycle, the next thing is to sit down as leaders and resolve the issues that have arisen.

"We've done extensive consultations with the leadership, and approval has been given to set up a Reconciliation Committee that will hit the ground running immediately.

"Prince Biyi Poroye would lead the committee alongside very competent stakeholders and leaders with both state and national coverage to reconcile aggrieved members."

Speaking on how to harmonize all the support groups before the election, Babatunde, a former House of Representatives member, disclosed that 84 support groups had registered with the party in the state.

He assured that the support groups would not work at cross purposes during the electioneering campaign.

The APC chairman assured that all the support groups would work together and campaign for all the party candidates, including President Tinubu.



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Sports

El-Kanemi Intensify Preparations For CAF Confederations Cup

El-Kanemi Warriors have intensified preparations ahead of its CAF Confederation Cup campaign and the upcoming Nigeria National League (NNL) season.

Speaking after the team's training session on days ago, Team Manager, Coach Ibb, expressed confidence in the club's ongoing recruitment process.

"Alhamdulillah. I want to assure our fans that we are doing everything humanly possible to bring in quality players who will strengthen the team and make everyone proud.

"Experienced players from professional clubs have been invited. Some have already joined the team, while others are expected to arrive soon.

"By the grace of Allah, everything will go according to plan. We urge our fans to trust the process and have confidence in the positive changes that will

soon begin, In Sha Allah."

Coach Ibb also appealed to supporters to rely only on official information from the club.

"I also want to call on our fans to disregard any news or reports that do not originate from the Media Unit of Elkanemi Warriors FC. Once all the necessary arrangements have been concluded, the Media Director will officially announce the list of retained players, those placed on the transfer market, and other squad updates. Our supporters will also witness the official unveiling of our new signings very soon, In Sha Allah.

"The club remains committed to building a competitive squad capable of making a strong impact in both the CAF Confederation Cup and the Nigeria National League, while appreciating the support and patience of our loyal fans."



Tornadoes Chairman Inspects Stadium Ahead Of Next Season

The Chairman of the Niger Tornadoes Management Committee, Dr. Abubakar Abdullahi Kuso (Dan Wadatan Nupe), earlier in the week, inspected the ongoing renovation work at the Bako Kontagora Memorial Stadium in Minna as preparations continue for the commencement of the new Nigeria Premier Football League (NPFL) season.

During the inspection, Dr. Abubakar Kuso assessed the level of work carried out across various sections of the stadium and expressed satisfaction with the pace and quality of the renovation.

He noted that the project had reached 90 percent completion, describing the progress as encouraging and a clear demonstration of the commitment to delivering a befitting sporting facility for the state.

The chairman commended the contractors for their dedication and urged them to maintain the standard of work while ensuring the remaining aspects of the project are completed within the stipulated timeframe. He expressed optimism that the upgraded stadium will provide a conducive environment for Niger Tornadoes to host its home matches and inspire greater success in the forthcoming league season.

The ongoing renovation of the Bako Kontagora Memorial Stadium is part of

the Niger State Government's commitment to revitalising sports infrastructure and creating world-class facilities that will enhance football development and promote sporting excellence in the state.



Tornadoes chairman, Abubakar

Kwara United Make Statement Of Intent, Sign 16 Players

Ahead of the 2026/2027 season, Kwara United have sent a strong message to their rivals after unveiling 16 new players, with club chairman Kumbi Titiloye, declaring that nothing short of the league title and the President Federation Cup will satisfy the 'Harmony Boys'.

The unveiling ceremony, held at the club's secretariat in Ilorin recently, marked the beginning of a new chapter for the 'Afonja Warriors' as they look to build on last season and establish themselves among Nigeria's elite clubs.

Speaking during the ceremony, Titiloye revealed that the club embarked on an extensive recruitment exercise following the departure of several players whose contracts expired, while retaining the core of last season's squad to maintain stability.

"Our target this season is to finish at the top of the league and win every available trophy. We want to win the Nigeria Premier Football League (NPFL) title and reclaim the President Federation Cup," Titiloye said.

The ambitious recruitment drive saw Kwara United strengthen every department of the team, bringing in experienced NPFL campaigners alongside exciting young talents.

Among the headline arrivals are former Rangers International forward Jerry Alex, ex-Bendel Insurance duo Peace Dewan and Anthony Nnamdi, Nasarawa United striker Benjamin Jack, Ikorodu City forward Ajibola Ayomade, and Malian goalkeeper Ouattara Khalifa, who adds international experience to the squad.

The 'Harmony Boys' also retained 16 players from last season, ensuring continuity as the club seeks to blend ex-



perience with fresh talent in pursuit of silverware.

Titiloye insisted lessons have been learnt from the previous campaign, promising supporters that the club will approach every fixture with greater determination.

"We are treating every game like a World Cup final. The mistakes of last season will not be repeated," he added.

The chairman also acknowledged the continued backing of Kwara State governor, AbdulRahman AbdulRazaq, and the Kwara State Sports Commission, describing their support as instrumental

to the club's growing ambitions.

Kwara United's aggressive transfer strategy underlines the increasing competition expected in the 2026/27 NPFL season, with several clubs strengthening their squads in pursuit of continental qualification and domestic honours.

For the 'Harmony Boys', however, the objective has already been made clear.

After reinforcing the squad with 16 new faces while keeping the nucleus of last season's team intact, Kwara United believe they now possess the quality to challenge on all fronts and end the campaign with major silverware.

Doma Clarify Report On Transfer, Disclaim Media Account



Doma United have reacted to a report claiming that they have acquired the services of Crown FC goalkeeper, Muiyiwa Majayogbe.

In a statement endorsed by the management of the team, it said there was no truth in the report, affirming that at no time had the club thought of such a transfer.

The statement read; "Doma United Football Club has become aware of a false and misleading publication by

G25Sports claiming that the club has completed the signing of goalkeeper Muiyiwa Majayogbe from Crown FC, Osogbo.

"We wish to categorically state that this report is entirely false, baseless, and was published without the knowledge, consent, or authorization of Doma United FC.

"At no time has the club announced or confirmed such a transfer through any of its official communication chan-

nels.

"Doma United FC strongly condemns the growing trend of irresponsible journalism and the dissemination of unverified transfer stories capable of misleading our supporters, stakeholders, players, and the general public.

"We hereby issues a strong warning to G25Sports and all other media organizations, bloggers, and social media platforms to refrain from publishing speculative or unverified stories concerning Doma United FC. Any news relating to player recruitment, appointments, or official club activities should only be regarded as authentic when released through the Club's authorized communication channels.

"Be advised that any media organization or individual who continues to publish false, defamatory, or misleading information capable of damaging the reputation of Doma United FC shall be exposed to appropriate legal action without further notice.

"We urge our supporters and the football community to disregard the said publication and rely solely on official club announcements for accurate information."

Sports

Why Bursaspor's Move Excites Iheanacho

AYO BADA
LAGOS

Super Eagles striker Kelechi Iheanacho has spoken publicly for the first time since rejecting a contract extension at Celtic in favour of joining Turkish side Bursaspor.

The 29-year-old completed a surprise move to the Turkish second-tier club last week after helping Celtic win a domestic double during the 2025/26 season.

His decision raised eyebrows in Scotland, particularly after Celtic manager Martin O'Neill revealed he believed an agreement had been reached for the Nigerian to remain at Parkhead before negotiations collapsed.

However, Iheanacho has now explained that Bursaspor's long-term sporting project, not financial incentives, convinced him to make the move.

Speaking on Bursaspor's official YouTube Channel, Iheanacho admitted he became convinced after hearing the club's vision of returning to the Turkish Super Lig and competing in Europe again.

He said: "I'm very happy to come to Bursaspor. I thank the president for making this possible, with the help of my agent as well. I'm really excited to start here."

The former Manchester City and Leicester City striker revealed he was already aware of



Super Eagles and Celtic forward Kelechi Iheanacho

Bursaspor's history as Turkish champions.

"Bursaspor is a big club in Turkey and I had heard that they had previously won the Turkish Super Lig."

"When I heard about their project, that they wanted to climb up to the Super Lig and also play in Europe, I said this is a big project and it's very good for me to come and be involved and help the team."

Iheanacho then disclosed that he personally instructed his representatives to prioritise the transfer.

"So I asked my agent to make sure he does everything possible to make sure I come to Bursaspor. This is a big project and I hope I will be a part of it and help the team achieve this big project."

While Iheanacho arrives as

one of the biggest names in the Turkish second division, he insisted his focus is helping Bursaspor secure promotion rather than chasing individual glory.

"We know what we want as a team. Collectively as a team, hopefully we achieve promotion—that is our main target before the individual target of a player."

"My target is for us to go to the Super Lig." The striker also thanked Bursaspor supporters for welcoming him even before the transfer was completed.

"The fans are really positive and energetic. I thank them a lot for all their support since I've signed."

"They always commented on my posts asking me to come to Bursaspor. Finally, I'm here. They made it possible, so they

are part of it. Hopefully we will enjoy winning together and enjoy going to the Super Lig together."

Iheanacho's comments come days after O'Neill admitted Celtic were caught off guard by the Nigerian's decision to leave.

The Scottish champions had hoped to keep him after his nine-goal campaign, but discussions broke down before Bursaspor finalised a three-year contract for the Super Eagles forward.

Reports in Scotland initially suggested Iheanacho chose Turkey because of a lucrative salary package, but Bursaspor president Enes Çelik later dismissed claims that the striker would earn around £47,000 per week, confirming instead that his guaranteed annual salary stands at £1.4 million.

Rather than discussing finances, Iheanacho pointed to Bursaspor's sporting ambition as the decisive factor behind his decision.

Iheanacho also joked about swapping one green-and-white shirt for another after leaving Celtic.

"It's the same green and white, to be fair." I don't know if it's déjà vu, like they say in French."

"Celtic is a bit lighter green, Bursaspor is dark green. It's a little bit different but it's all similar. It's all good."

For the Super Eagles striker, the objective is to help restore one of Turkey's most historic clubs to the Super Lig while reigniting his own career after an eventful spell in Scottish football.

Klopp Starts Germany Reign By Threatening To Quit



Jurgen Klopp started his reign as Germany's head coach by threatening to quit if the media invades his family's privacy.

The former Liverpool manager was appointed on a four-year deal on Friday to replace Julian Nagelsmann, who resigned this month after Germany's shock FIFA World Cup defeat by Paraguay in the last 32.

But the 59-year-old issued a warning to the media as he held his first news conference as Germany's head coach.

"If you behave badly and don't leave my family in peace then I'll be gone, I'll just turn away," Klopp said.

"I know there are other countries where national team coaches are treated even worse.

"I'm not doing this job for myself, I'm doing it for you. I'm taking this job even though I've seen how you've treated Julian Nagelsmann and Thomas Tuchel.

"I love this job but I am always ready to call it quits if need be."

Both Nagelsmann and England boss Tuchel came under media scrutiny after their exits from the World Cup, with Tuchel

criticised for his defensive tactics and substitutions as the Three Lions let slip a 1-0 lead in their semifinal defeat by Argentina.

Klopp's appointment was widely expected for weeks and his contract will see him through to the 2030 FIFA World Cup, co-hosted by Spain, Portugal and Morocco.

"Jurgen Klopp is not going to have any 'career' after the national team," he added.

"This is the pinnacle, the absolutely high point of my footballing career as coach. I will give everything I have got."

It is Klopp's first coaching job since ending his nine-year tenure at Liverpool in the summer of 2024 after "running out of energy".

He said he feels "the time is right" for his return to coaching and to take up his first role in international football.

"Over the last few days it was almost like a movie happening to myself," he said.

"I have always surmised the job of Germany head coach is really big but now it is really dawning on me what being the national team head coach is all about.

"For many, many years it was unimaginable for me to assume this position. As the years went by, it became more or less evident that sooner or later I would be asked to do this job.

"Now I think the time is right."

His first game in charge will be against the Netherlands in a Nations League group-stage match on September 24.

Glasgow 2026: Nworgu Breaks Record, Clinches Nigeria's First Gold



AYO BADA
LAGOS

Nigerian athlete Esther Nworgu set a new Commonwealth Games record in Glasgow on Friday in the women's para powerlifting lightweight event with a phenomenal lift of 123 kg, scoring 119 points.

With this feat, she claimed Team Nigeria's first gold medal at the ongoing 2026 Games being held in Scotland.

The occasion was even sweeter for Team Nigeria as Esther Oyema completed a dominant Nigerian 1-2 finish by taking the silver medal with a best lift of 125.0kg (115.5 points).

England's Olivia Broome went home with the bronze following a lift of 119 kg and 106.6 points, while Kenya's Hellen Wawira Kariuki, England's Charlotte McGuinness, and India's Suman Devi finished fourth, fifth, and sixth respectively.

Nworgu's victory came just hours after veteran para-powerlifter Roland Ezuruike opened Nigeria's medal account with a silver in the men's lightweight event, ensuring the country's campaign got off to an encouraging start.

This means Team Nigeria has now won three medals on the opening day – one gold and two silvers.

Guardiola Turns Down Italy Manager Job

Pep Guardiola has turned down the chance to coach the Italian national side.

Earlier this week, Italian Football Federation (FIGC) president Giovanni Malago said talks had been held with Guardiola, who left Manchester City this summer after 10 years, and that "exceptions" could be made for his salary.

On Thursday, FIGC technical director Paolo Maldini said Italy first approached their former player Carlo Ancelotti, who is currently in charge of Brazil.

Ancelotti has agreed to stay in post and now Guardiola has informed the FIGC he intends to continue with his plan to take a break from the game, which will allow him to rest, spend more

time with his family and travel.

In addition to a huge salary, the FIGC is understood to have effectively told Guardiola he could shape the job as he saw fit, as they tried to tempt one of the most successful coaches in the game to take charge of a side that has failed to qualify for three FIFA World Cups in a row.

However, after taking some time to consider the situation, he has said no.

It means former Italy playmaker Andrea Pirlo, currently head coach of Dubai-based United FC, is the frontrunner to be tasked with navigating Italy through a Nations League group that includes France, Belgium and Turkey in the autumn and then try to qualify for Euro 2028.

Swansea City have completed the signing of Ghana winger Joseph Opoku from Zulte Waregem.

The 20-year-old joined the Belgian top-flight side in 2024, helping them to win promotion to the Belgian Pro League.

He has signed a four-year deal with the Championship Swans - who hold the option

Swansea City Sign Ghana Winger Opoku

to extend the contract by an additional 12 months.

"He is a young player, who has been exposed to a lot of senior football in Belgium," said Swans head coach Vitor Matos.

"He will be able to adapt to the physicality, the in-

tensity and the amount of games in the Championship as we know he is a fast and sharp player.

"Opoku has joined us here in Austria (on their pre-season tour), and he has had his first training session and we're excited to

have him here."

Opoku's breakthrough came last season where he finished with 10 goals and six assists.

He was called up to the senior Ghana team for a set of friendlies in May, but missed out on World Cup se-

lection after being named in the preliminary squad.

Swansea's sporting director Ben Stevens said: "Really excited with Joseph joining us and looking forward to seeing his attacking potential flourish in Vitor's team.

"Two full seasons with Zulte Waregem in Belgium's top division plus being involved with Ghana national teams highlight the ability of this young talent."

Opoku is Matos' fifth signing of the summer following the arrivals of Elijah Just, Stephen Welsh, Moussa Yeo and Leo Walta.

Crime Tracker



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TITILOPE JOSEPH
 LAGOS

Beyond The Bill: Can Nigeria's States Build Police Forces That Work?



The passage of the state police bill has brought Nigeria to a defining moment in its decades-long search for a more effective security system, ending years of intense political and constitutional debate over whether policing should remain the exclusive responsibility of the Federal Government.

The legislation, widely regarded as one of the most far-reaching security reforms in recent years, has shifted attention from the campaign for state police to the more difficult task of implementation.

As states begin to examine the legal, financial and operational demands of establishing their own police services, questions are emerging over whether they possess the institutional capacity, resources and safeguards needed to build forces that can improve security without creating new challenges.

For many Nigerians, the reform comes against the backdrop of persistent insecurity that has stretched the country's centralised policing system.

Kidnappings, armed robbery, communal violence, terrorism, banditry and other violent crimes have continued to test the capacity of security agencies, prompting renewed calls for policing structures that are closer to the communities they serve.

Yet, while supporters see state police as a long-awaited opportunity to strengthen local security and improve intelligence gathering, others caution that the success of the reform will depend less on the passage of the legislation than on how effectively it is implemented.

From funding and recruitment to accountability, inter-agency coordination and protection against political interference, the real challenge may only just be beginning.

The answer may ultimately depend less on the law itself than on how states choose to implement it.

For years, Nigeria's security landscape has become increasingly complex. Kidnapping for ransom, armed banditry, farmer-herder conflicts, communal violence, cult-related crimes, terrorism, piracy and urban criminality have stretched the capacity of the Nigeria Police Force, despite repeated recruitment drives and operational reforms. Officers are often deployed far from their states of origin, sometimes with little understanding of local languages, terrain or community dynamics.

This gap has, over time, encouraged many states to establish alternative security arrangements. Various regional and community-based outfits emerged to complement federal policing, reflecting growing frustration with delayed response times and limited police presence in rural communities. While these initiatives improved intelligence gathering in some areas, they generally lacked full policing powers such as investigation, arrest and prosecution.

The new legal framework seeks to address that structural limitation by allowing states to establish their own police organisations within a constitutional framework. Yet creating a police force involves far more than recruiting officers and providing uniforms.

Experience from many jurisdictions suggests that effective policing is built on institutions rather than personalities.

The success of any state police system will depend on recruitment standards, leadership quality, operational indepen-

dence, internal discipline and public trust. Without these pillars, decentralising policing could merely reproduce existing weaknesses at multiple levels.

Recruitment presents one of the earliest and perhaps most important tests.

States will inevitably face pressure from political actors seeking employment opportunities for supporters. If recruitment becomes politicised rather than merit-based, professionalism could suffer from inception. A credible process would require transparent eligibility criteria, competitive selection, psychological screening, background checks and comprehensive training.

Equally important is continuous professional development. Modern policing increasingly involves digital investigations, forensic science, financial crimes, cybercrime, intelligence analysis and crisis negotiation. States that invest only in manpower while neglecting these specialised skills may struggle to deliver meaningful improvements.

The Funding Question

Perhaps no issue will shape the future of state police more than sustainable financing.

Creating a police organisation requires substantial and recurring expenditure. Beyond salaries, governments must provide patrol vehicles, communication equipment, forensic facilities, armouries, protective gears, barracks, insurance, healthcare, pensions, digital infrastructure and regular training.

These obligations continue long after inauguration ceremonies have ended.

The financial realities differ sharply across Nigeria. While some states maintain relatively stronger internally generated revenue, others rely heavily on federal allocations to fund routine government operations. Questions therefore arise over whether all states possess the fiscal capacity to sustain professional police institutions over the long term.

Funding instability could create significant operational risks. Delayed salaries, inadequate logistics and poor welfare have historically affected morale across security institutions. Replicating those conditions at the state level could undermine the very objectives the reform seeks to achieve.

Some analysts have suggested phased implementation, allowing states to establish police services only after demonstrating minimum financial and institutional readiness. Such an approach could reduce the risk of poorly resourced agencies struggling to fulfil their mandates. Security threats rarely respect geographical boundaries.

Kidnapping syndicates, armed robbery networks, cyber-criminals and trafficking organisations frequently operate across several states. This reality makes coordination between state police organisations and federal security agencies indispensable.

Questions surrounding jurisdiction, intelligence sharing, suspect transfers and operational command will require clearly defined protocols.

Without effective coordination, criminals could exploit institutional gaps, jurisdictional disputes or communication failures.

Technology could help bridge this challenge. Integrated criminal databases, digital fingerprint systems, biometric identification, shared intelligence platforms and interoperable emergency communication networks would enable faster information exchange between agencies.

The effectiveness of state police may therefore depend not only on decentralisation but also on the strength of collaboration across all tiers of law enforcement.

Winning Public Trust

Perhaps the greatest resource any police organisation possesses is public confidence.

Communities are far more likely to provide intelligence, report crimes and cooperate with investigations when they believe officers will act fairly and professionally.

Building that trust will require visible commitment to accountability.

Independent complaints mechanisms, transparent disciplinary procedures, human rights training, body-worn cameras where feasible, regular public reporting and civilian oversight could all contribute to improving confidence.

States that prioritise these safeguards

from the outset may find it easier to cultivate constructive relationships between officers and the communities they serve.

Conversely, allegations of corruption, unlawful detention, excessive force or political interference could quickly erode public support.

Much of the debate surrounding state police has centred on fears of political influence.

Critics have long expressed concern that governors could deploy state police against political opponents, critics or protesters. While constitutional safeguards and oversight mechanisms may reduce such risks, legislation alone cannot guarantee institutional neutrality.

Professional culture ultimately develops through leadership.

Police commissioners, senior officers and oversight bodies will play critical roles in ensuring operational decisions remain guided by evidence, law and public interest rather than partisan considerations.

Clear appointment procedures, fixed tenure where appropriate, transparent disciplinary systems and legislative oversight could strengthen institutional independence.

Across different parts of the country, governments have accumulated experience through regional security networks, neighbourhood safety initiatives and community policing programmes. While these structures vary considerably in organisation and legal authority, they offer valuable lessons.

Successful initiatives often benefited from strong community engagement, local intelligence and familiarity with cultural dynamics. At the same time, operational limitations highlighted the importance of clear legal mandates, sustainable funding and coordination with existing security agencies.

States preparing to establish police organisations may find it useful to study these experiences rather than attempting entirely new models.

Recruiting officers is only the beginning, retaining experienced personnel may also prove equally difficult.

Competitive salaries, housing, healthcare, insurance, opportunities for promotion and continuous learning influence morale and performance. Poor welfare

has historically contributed to frustration within many security institutions.

States that invest in officer wellbeing are more likely to reduce attrition and improve operational effectiveness.

Recruitment processes should reflect the ethnic, religious and cultural diversity within each state while maintaining merit as the overriding principle. Inclusive institutions generally enjoy greater public legitimacy and broader community acceptance.

The effectiveness of state police should not be measured solely by the number of officers recruited or patrol vehicles commissioned.

More meaningful indicators include response times, crime detection rates, successful prosecutions, community confidence, protection of human rights and reductions in violent crime.

Public perception surveys, independent audits and transparent performance reporting can provide objective measures of progress.

These metrics would also help governments identify operational weaknesses before they become systemic problems.

Institutional reform rarely produces immediate results. Even countries with long-established decentralised policing systems continue to refine oversight structures, training standards and accountability mechanisms.

Nigeria's transition is therefore likely to involve adjustments, legal interpretation and policy refinement over several years.

Success will require sustained political commitment that extends beyond election cycles.

States must resist the temptation to prioritise ceremonial launches over institutional capacity. Citizens, meanwhile, should judge the reform not by political promises but by measurable improvements in safety, professionalism and respect for the rule of law.

The passage of the state police law is undoubtedly historic, but legislation alone cannot transform public security.

Laws create possibilities; institutions determine outcomes.

Whether state police ultimately strengthens Nigeria's security landscape will depend on decisions taken after the headlines fade, how officers are recruited, how budgets are managed, how misconduct is punished, how technology is deployed and how faithfully the principles of accountability are upheld.

If those foundations are carefully laid, state police could become an important component of a more responsive and locally informed security system. If they are neglected, decentralisation may simply reproduce familiar challenges under new administrative structures.

The real test, therefore, begins now. The debate over whether Nigeria should establish state police has largely run its course. The more consequential question is whether the states can build police forces that command public confidence, operate professionally and deliver the safer communities that citizens have long demanded.

That answer will not be found in the text of the law alone, but in the quality of the institutions that emerge from it.

News Xtra

ACU Management Pays Tribute As Engr. Olaniyi Buries Mother

SEYI TAIWO-OGUNTUASE

The management of Ajayi Crowther University (ACU), Oyo, led by the Vice-Chancellor, Prof. Ebuloluwa Olufemi Oduwale, joined family members, friends and associates in Ipetu-Ijesa, Osun State, to pay their last respects to Mama Christianah Monisola Olaniyi, mother of the university's Director of Works and Services, Engr. Oluwale Aderogba Olaniyi.

Tributes began during the Christian Wake, where Prof. Oduwale described Engr. Olaniyi as a calm, dependable and disciplined administrator whose character reflected the sound values instilled in him by his late mother.

The Vice-Chancellor, the first female to lead ACU, said her working relationship with Engr. Olaniyi since assuming office had revealed a man who remained composed and professional even in challenging situations.

"I have come to know Engr. Olaniyi at a very close range. In my working experience with him, he has always displayed calmness, even when I was blowing hot. His calmness remained unshaken," she said.

According to her, his customary response of "Yes, Ma," before diligently carrying out assigned responsibilities, exemplified the discipline and good upbringing he received from his mother. She added that the large turnout at the wake was a testament to

the esteem in which he is held and a reflection of the enduring legacy of the late matriarch.

Also paying tribute, the immediate past Vice-Chancellor, Prof. Timothy Adeniyi, described the deceased as an elder sister who played a significant role in his life and family.

"She was a great asset to the family. She was my older sister. We have taken solace in the Lord because Mama died peacefully and is now resting in the bosom of the Lord," he said.

The funeral service which took place at St. Mary's Anglican Church, Iloro, Ipetu-Ijesa, where the officiating priest, Venerable. I. Adegoke Adekunle Jacob, preaching from John 14:1-6, urged the congrega-

tion to live with eternity in view.

He described the late Mama Olaniyi as a woman of unwavering Christian faith, a devoted mother and a worthy example of godly living.

The service was followed by a reception attended by the Vice-Chancellor, principal officers of the university, the former Vice-Chancellor, members of staff, relatives and other well-wishers.

An emotional Engr. Olaniyi expressed heartfelt appreciation to all who came to honour the memory of his mother, personally moving round the reception venue to thank guests for their support, prayers and solidarity with his family during the period of bereavement.



Engr. Oluwale Olaniyi, Director of Works and Services, Ajayi Crowther University, Oyo, and Prof. Ebuloluwa Olufemi Oduwale, Vice Chancellor of the institution during the burial of Mrs. Christianah Monisola Olaniyi, mother of ACU's Director of Works and Services at Ipetu-Ijesa, Osun State.



Tope Glory Marks Birthday With Widows, Urges Better Health Practices

SEYI TAIWO-OGUNTUASE

Tope Awolesi, a gospel musician popularly called Tope Glory has called on widows and other vulnerable women to prioritise preventive healthcare as he marked his birthday by providing food items and health awareness to widows in Ojodu community.

Speaking during the outreach, which was held at St. Paul's Anglican Church Ojodu Hall, Tope Glory said the annual initiative was inspired by his desire to support widows, having witnessed the challenges they face following the loss of their husbands.

According to him, his mother is also a widow, a personal experience that motivated him to begin the annual outreach five years ago.

"I imagine how they feel without a husband. My mother is also a widow, so for the past five years I have been visiting widows on my birthday to bless them with gifts. I draw my inspiration from 1 Timothy 5:3, which says, 'Honour your widows that are widows indeed,'" he said.

He explained that although the programme started on a smaller scale, that this year's

edition was expanded to reach more beneficiaries.

As part of the outreach, the widows received food items including rice, garri, sliced bread, tomato paste sachets and salt.

Nurse Olufunmilayo Oduwale, a medical practitioner who addressed the beneficiaries urged the women to embrace preventive healthcare, stressing that prevention is less expensive than treatment.

The health expert advised the widows to wash their hands regularly with soap and water to prevent diseases such as cholera, maintain clean surroundings to reduce the spread of malaria, and go for routine blood pressure and blood sugar checks.

She also encouraged them to maintain healthy eating habits, exercise regularly, avoid patronising unqualified medical practitioners and support one another emotionally to guard against depression.

"They should not commit their health into the hands of quacks, and they should continue to check on one another so that no one suffers from depression alone," the medical practitioner said.

Dr. Idowu Philips, popularly

called Iya Rainbow, a veteran actress who is the Mother of the day and chairman of the event described the initiative as commendable and appealed to government authorities to support the humanitarian effort.

"What Tope Glory has done is a powerful one. I appeal to the government to support him. I believe God will take him higher in this ministry," she said.

She also encouraged the widows to remain steadfast in faith, assuring them that God would continue to stand by them despite their circumstances.

Beneficiaries expressed gratitude for the support, describing the outreach as a life-changing gesture.

One of the widows Evan Titi Odubela said, "Tope Glory has really done well for us, particularly myself. We will never forget this. He has done what some people have never done before. May God Almighty bless him miraculously and prosper the work of his hands."

The annual birthday outreach has become a platform through which Tope Glory provides practical support and hope to widows while promoting healthy living and community care.

AI Is Not The End Of Advertising: AAAN Challenges Agencies To Evolve, Lead Next Era

The Association of Advertising Agencies of Nigeria (AAAN) has commenced its 53rd Annual General Meeting (AGM) and Congress in Lagos, bringing together advertising professionals, government representatives, regulators, and stakeholders across the marketing communications industry to examine the future of advertising in a rapidly evolving landscape.

Held at Providence Hotel, Ikeja GRA, Lagos, the two-day gathering themed "AdVolution: The End of Advertising as We Know It and How to Win What Comes Next," focused on the impact of artificial intelligence, changing consumer behaviour, technology, and emerging creative models on the future of the industry.

The AGM commenced on Thursday with a members-only Business Session, which featured the President's stewardship address, as well as reports from various committees on the activities, progress, and priorities of the Association.

A key highlight of the session was the induction of new members and agencies into the association including, JT Agency, Purple Stardust Limited and Omniflex Options Limited. The new members were welcomed as part of AAAN's continued efforts to expand its community and strengthen collaboration across Nigeria's advertising and marketing communications ecosystem.

Opening the conference on Friday, AAAN President, Lanre Adisa, described the industry's current moment as one that requires agencies to embrace change and build the capabilities needed to thrive in a fast-evolving



environment.

"The greatest challenge facing the industry is not change itself, but the risk of failing to adapt alongside it, stressing the need for talent development and a stronger understanding of how emerging technologies can work alongside human creativity," he stated.

The conference, which featured keynote addresses from Tomiwa Aladekomo, Chief Executive Officer of Big Cabal Media, and Dr. Meksley Nwagboh, Division Head, Brands and Communications, Fidelity Bank Plc, explored how agencies can remain relevant as technology continues to reshape advertising.

Speaking during his keynote session, Aladekomo noted that while artificial intelligence is changing the rules of the industry, human creativity remains the biggest differentiator. He challenged agencies to focus on the value they provide clients, noting that technology can support the creative process but cannot replace human intuition, cultural understanding, and the ability to develop original ideas.

Dr. Nwagboh described the current transformation within advertising as an opportunity

for agencies to rethink how they create value, noting that consumers increasingly seek relevance, authenticity, and meaningful connections from brands. He emphasised that agencies that will thrive are those that can combine data, technology, and human judgement to create work that resonates with audiences.

Representing the Lagos State Governor, Mr. Gbenga Omotoso, Commissioner for Information and Strategy, described the theme as timely, noting that while technology continues to shape the world, creativity remains uniquely human.

The panel session moderated by Oyindamola Fakile featured Segun Akinjemiju, Head of White Spirit, MSS Category, Guinness Nigeria Plc; Rotimi Ade-Onajobi, Creative Director, Spice 360; Damola R. Salvador, Managing Director/Chief Executive Officer, Digisplash Limited; Oluwatobiloba Beckley-Williams, Creative Director, 7even Interactive; and Seun Adaramola, Marketing Director, Visa Nigeria, who explored the evolving business models and ways of working required for agencies to remain competitive in an AI-driven landscape.

SATURDAY INDEPENDENT

THE MOST READ NEWSPAPER AMONG THE POLITICAL AND BUSINESS ELITE

“We become what we think about.”
— Earl Nightingale

Quick Take

Newcastle Seal £34m Move For Monaco's Bamba

Newcastle United have signed Monaco midfielder Aladji Bamba for a fee which could rise to £34m.

The Frenchman has joined the club on a five-year deal after undergoing a medical on Tyneside on Thursday.

"I was very excited when I heard Newcastle were interested in signing me," the 20-year-old said.

"I know about the history of the club and I've visited the stadium already, which is amazing. I can't wait to be on the pitch there and hope to have some great times with the fans.

"I'm excited to test myself in a new league, the biggest league in the world. I learned a lot last season and now I feel ready for this new opportunity. I will give my all for this club."

Bamba only made his professional debut last season, but caught the eye of Newcastle with his performances in Ligue 1 and the Champions League.

Kane Set For Talks Over New Deal

Harry Kane is set to open formal talks with Bayern Munich over a new contract with the German champions.

England captain Kane's current deal expires at the end of the coming season, but Bayern are keen to extend the striker's stay.

It is understood the 32-year-old is aware of the Bundesliga club's intention to offer him a new contract, with discussions expected to progress in the coming weeks.

Kane joined Bayern from Tottenham in 2023 in a deal worth a reported £86m. The striker has enjoyed great success in Munich, helping the club win two Bundesliga titles and the German Cup.

Kane, who scored six goals for England at the recent World Cup, has scored 146 goals in 134 appearances for Bayern since his arrival.

Chelsea To Sign Palace Defender Lacroix

Crystal Palace defender Maxence Lacroix is set to join Chelsea on a long-term contract after the clubs reached agreement on a deal for the player.

BBC Sport reported that both clubs had held positive talks over a move for the France international, with Palace seeking about £60m for the centre-back.

An agreement has now been reached between the two clubs, with personal terms not believed to be an issue.

Lacroix is expected to sign a long-term contract, understood to run until 2032.

The agreement between the two London clubs has been negotiated at ownership level.

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Is Glasgow 2026 Last Dance Or A Future-Proofing Revamp?

It is an event that has been going for 96 years.

The Commonwealth Games have provided iconic sporting moments – from Roger Bannister's win in the 'Miracle Mile' of 1954 and Eilish McColgan breaking her mum's record in 2022 to England's netball victory four years earlier in Australia.

But the 2026 Games, which opened in Glasgow on Thursday, come at an intriguing time for the event. Many doubted whether they would even happen – and when they do go ahead, they will do so in a stripped-back form.

So how did we get here? And do athletes and fans still care and what could the future hold?

The 2026 Commonwealth Games were thrown into doubt when its original hosts, the Australian state of Victoria, pulled out in 2023 citing spiraling costs. That decision took even the leaders of Commonwealth Sport by surprise.

After more than a year of uncertainty, Glasgow stepped in to host the Games for the second time, following on from the highly successful event in the Scottish city in 2014.

But, with limited preparation time a significant factor, the Games' return to Glasgow a much smaller event.

There was competition across 18 sports in 2014 – a number that rose to 20 for Birmingham 2022 – but only 10 sports will feature this year.

There are expected to be around 2,000 fewer athletes and no new stadiums have been built, with the athletics events having moved from the 46,000-seater Hampden Park to the Scotstoun Stadium, which will hold just over 10,000 people.

Costs of running the event have been cut from between £700m and £800m for Birmingham 2022 and the Gold Coast Games in 2018 to £160m for Glasgow.

Whether by accident or design, organisers insist the situation has created a template for the future.

They believe a smaller, cheaper, more sustainable Commonwealth Games can last.

"I don't think we have ever been stronger," Katie Sadleir, chief executive of Commonwealth Sport, told BBC Sport.

"We took a hard look at ourselves and realised we needed to reset and reimagine this Games so it is an attractive proposition for our members."

Crucially, the Commonwealth Games have already secured the Indian city of Ahmedabad as host for 2030, when the number of sports is expected rise to between 15 and 18.

Several countries have also expressed interest in hosting in 2034. New Zealand has done so publicly while Nigeria remains interested after challenging Ahmedabad's bid for 2030.

Having begun in 1930 as the British Empire Games, the Commonwealth Games face questions about their place and relevance in the modern world.

England weightlifter Emily Campbell told the BBC the Games are "one of the best things that came out of colonisation" while three-time Olympic swimming gold medallist Tom Dean insists they can be a "force for good" despite the difficult past.

"It is even more reason to push the Commonwealths into the spotlight because it shows the best side of sport," he told BBC Sport.

However, the Glasgow edition has been hit by the absence of star names.

Injuries, such as those to Olympic gold-medal winning gymnast Max Whitlock and Australia's Olympic backstroke champion Kaylee McKeown, are unavoidable and unfortunate.

But other athletes have opted to prioritise different events.

Olympic 800m champion Keely Hodgkinson is skipping Glasgow in favour of the European Athletics Championships, which start in Birmingham on 10 August and are arguably the bigger track and field event this summer.

Dina Asher-Smith, the fastest British woman in history, and Olympic 100m champion Julien Alfred of St Lucia have also pulled out. Canadian swimming superstar Summer McIntosh is another notable absentee.

But it is not all doom and gloom.

Josh Kerr, fresh from breaking the mile world record, will return to home soil to race for Scotland, as will McColgan, while Adam Ramsay-Peaty returns to the same pool in which he won two golds in 2014.

The Commonwealth Games remain a pinnacle for sports like netball and there is also an increased focus on Para-sport, with this the most integrated Games ever.

Six of the 10 sports include Para-competitions with a Commonwealth Games record 47 medal events. Golds, silvers and bronzes won in Para-events will, unlike with other multi-sport events, count towards the overall medal total.

"There are not many opportunities for the integration of multi-sports (events)," Paralympic swimming champion Brock Whiston told BBC Sport.

"Without the Commonwealth Games, the smaller countries don't get the chance to show how powerful that integration is.

"The Commonwealth Games is vital to ensuring there are equal opportunities."

English swimmer James Guy, another Olympic champion who will be at his fourth Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, told BBC Sport the event remains a crucial part of an athlete's development.

"It is a bit easier to make than the GB team," he said.

"It is a really good way to get on there, get on a relay and get a medal and that is really important for development so the younger guys and girls can progress."

As ever, another major factor in assessing the potential longevity of the Commonwealth Games will be the re-

sponse from fans.

Around 1.3 million tickets were sold in 2014 – a figure that will certainly not be matched this time.

Sales have been strongest for athletics and cycling but tickets remain available for all sports across the 11 days of competition.

There is also a significant change in the UK this year with the BBC, who had provided coverage for 18 Commonwealth Games in a row, being replaced by TNT Sports as the live television broadcaster. The Games are also available to watch on streaming service HBO Max.

While radio coverage remains on BBC Radio 5 Live, it means there will be no free-to-air live TV coverage.

That makes cutting through to the general public more challenging at a crucial time.

The next 10 days remain significant for the Games' future.

The 2026 Commonwealth Games, officially known as the XXIII Commonwealth Games and commonly known as Glasgow 2026, is an ongoing multi-sport event being held from Thursday, July 23 to Sunday, August 2, 2026 in Glasgow, the largest city in Scotland, for members of the Commonwealth of Nations.

This is the fourth Commonwealth Games to be hosted in Scotland, following the 1970 and 1986 games in Edinburgh, and the 2014 Games in Glasgow. The 2026 Commonwealth Games is the first to be held since the death of Queen Elizabeth II and the accession of King Charles III as Head of the Commonwealth, and the first edition since Donald Rukare became president of the Commonwealth Games Federation (CGF).

For some time, the Games were without a host after the Victoria, Australia, bid for the 2026 Commonwealth Games was withdrawn, Victoria having initially been announced as the host in April 2022.

On July 18, 2023, the Victorian state government cancelled its plans due to

escalating cost projections. The city of Gold Coast, Queensland, briefly offered to co-host the event but later withdrew for similar reasons. With no host, there was a risk that the Games might be postponed to 2027 or cancelled entirely.

On August 11, 2024, reports surfaced that Glasgow had reached an agreement to take over the hosting rights, but the next day it was clarified that talks were ongoing with no final agreement or imminent announcement.

Commonwealth Games Scotland proposed a scaled-back version of the event, featuring 10 to 13 sports and using existing infrastructure, with £100 million in funding from the CGF and an additional £30 to 50 million from commercial sources, ensuring no significant public funds would be required.

A further update on 30 August 2024 confirmed that the Games would be primarily funded by AU\$200 million, secured as compensation from the Victorian government following their withdrawal.

On September 17, 2024, it was announced that the Scottish Government had agreed to host the games with financial backing from Commonwealth Games Australia.

The scaled-down and low-cost Games will feature 10 sports taking place over seven venues and no athletes' village.

The 2026 Commonwealth Games would have a special touch as the organisers in Glasgow have added a special touch to the medals that the winners would receive after securing a podium finish in any sporting event.

The CWG 2026 have been officially declared open by King Charles III at the extravagant opening ceremony, which highlighted Scottish heritage, music and culture at OVO Hydro in Glasgow on Thursday.

Apart from the stellar opening spectacle, the 2026 CWG's medals also feature a unique element.

Culled from BBC Sport

SATURDAY CRACKERS



UNCLE BOSCO, MY AUNTY SAID I SHOULD TELL YOU SHE HAS GONE BACK TO SCHOOL LAST WEEK